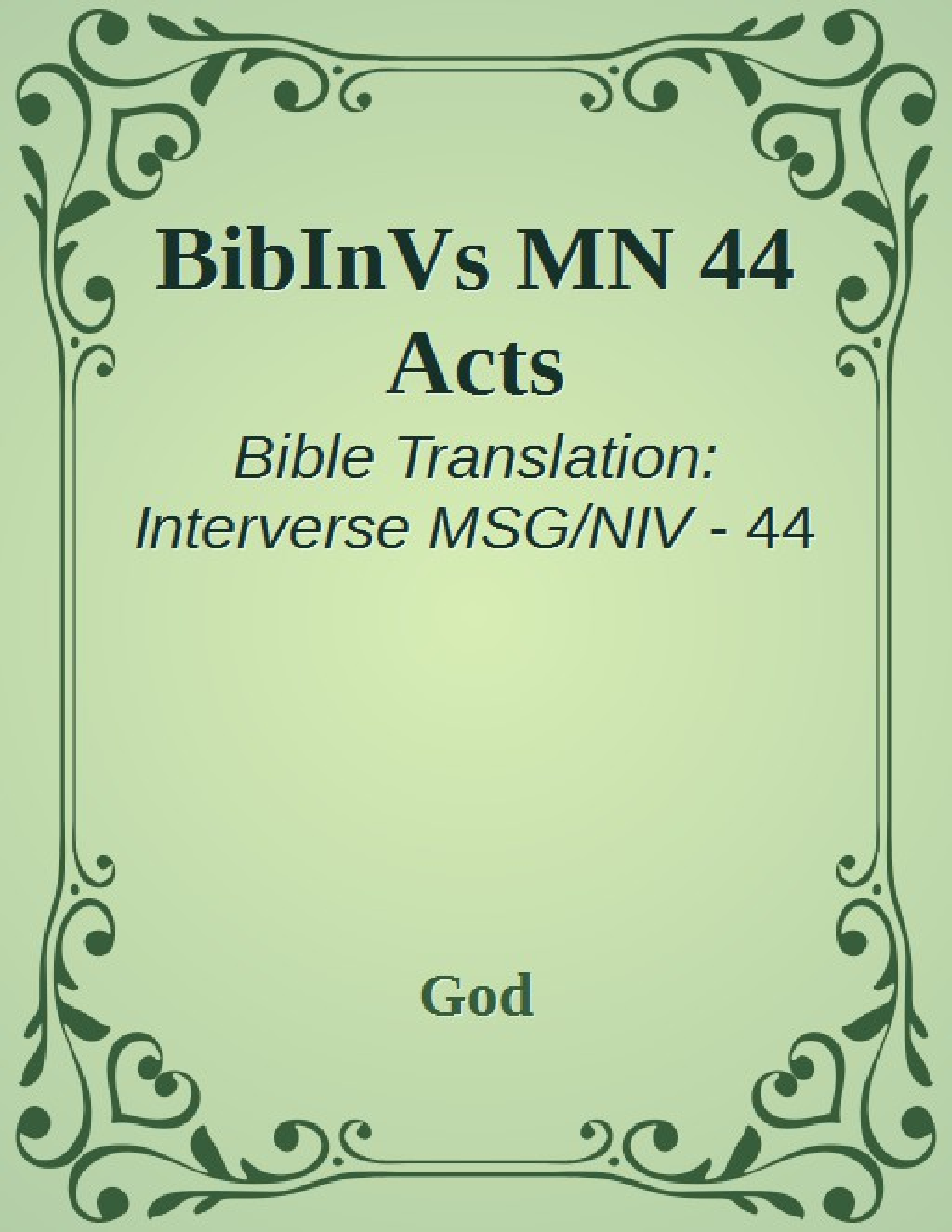


A decorative border with intricate floral and scrollwork patterns, rendered in a dark green color, framing the entire page.

BibInVs MN 44

Acts

*Bible Translation:
Interverse MSG/NIV - 44*

God

Table of Contents

[Acts 1](#)
[Acts 2](#)
[Acts 3](#)
[Acts 4](#)
[Acts 5](#)
[Acts 6](#)
[Acts 7](#)
[Acts 8](#)
[Acts 9](#)
[Acts 10](#)
[Acts 11](#)
[Acts 12](#)
[Acts 13](#)
[Acts 14](#)
[Acts 15](#)
[Acts 16](#)
[Acts 17](#)
[Acts 18](#)
[Acts 19](#)
[Acts 20](#)
[Acts 21](#)
[Acts 22](#)
[Acts 23](#)
[Acts 24](#)
[Acts 25](#)
[Acts 26](#)
[Acts 27](#)
[Acts 28](#)

Interversed Message/NIV Bible

Acts

Acts 1

MSG

NIV

- 1 Dear Theophilus, in the first volume of this book I wrote on everything that Jesus began to do and teach
- 1 In my former book, Theophilus, I wrote about all that Jesus began to do and to teach
- 2 until the day he said good-bye to the apostles, the ones he had chosen through the Holy Spirit, and was taken up to heaven.
- 2 until the day he was taken up to heaven, after giving instructions through the Holy Spirit to the apostles he had chosen.
- 3 After his death, he presented himself alive to them in many different settings over a period of forty days. In face-to-face meetings, he talked to them about things concerning the kingdom of God.
- 3 After his suffering, he showed himself to these men and gave many convincing proofs that he was alive. He appeared to them over a period of forty days and spoke about the kingdom of God.
- 4 As they met and ate meals together, he told them that they were on no account to leave Jerusalem but "must wait for what the Father promised: the promise you heard from me.
- 4 On one occasion, while he was eating with them, he gave them this command: "Do not leave Jerusalem, but wait for the gift my Father promised, which you have heard me speak about.
- 5 John baptized in water; you will be baptized in the Holy Spirit. And soon."
- 5 For John baptized with water, but in a few days you will be baptized with the Holy Spirit."
- 6 When they were together for the last time they asked, "Master, are you going to restore the kingdom to Israel now? Is this the time?"

- 6 So when they met together, they asked him, "Lord, are you at this time going to restore the kingdom to Israel?"
- 7 He told them, "You don't get to know the time. Timing is the Father's business.
- 7 He said to them: "It is not for you to know the times or dates the Father has set by his own authority.
- 8 What you'll get is the Holy Spirit. And when the Holy Spirit comes on you, you will be able to be my witnesses in Jerusalem, all over Judea and Samaria, even to the ends of the world."
- 8 But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit comes on you; and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the ends of the earth."
- 9 These were his last words. As they watched, he was taken up and disappeared in a cloud.
- 9 After he said this, he was taken up before their very eyes, and a cloud hid him from their sight.
- 10 They stood there, staring into the empty sky. Suddenly two men appeared--in white robes!
- 10 They were looking intently up into the sky as he was going, when suddenly two men dressed in white stood beside them.
- 11 They said, "You Galileans!--why do you just stand here looking up at an empty sky? This very Jesus who was taken up from among you to heaven will come as certainly--and mysteriously--as he left."
- 11 Men of Galilee, they said, "why do you stand here looking into the sky? This same Jesus, who has been taken from you into heaven, will come back in the same way you have seen him go into heaven."
- 12 So they left the mountain called Olives and returned to Jerusalem. It was a little over half a mile.
- 12 Then they returned to Jerusalem from the hill called the Mount of Olives, a Sabbath day's walk from the city.
- 13 They went to the upper room they had been using as a meeting place: Peter, John, James, Andrew, Philip, Thomas, Bartholomew, Matthew, James, son of Alphaeus, Simon the Zealot, Judas, son of James.
- 13 When they arrived, they went upstairs to the room where they were staying. Those present were Peter, John, James and Andrew; Philip and

Thomas, Bartholomew and Matthew; James son of Alphaeus and Simon the Zealot, and Judas son of James.

14 They agreed they were in this for good, completely together in prayer, the women included. Also Jesus' mother, Mary, and his brothers.

14 They all joined together constantly in prayer, along with the women and Mary the mother of Jesus, and with his brothers.

15 During this time, Peter stood up in the company--there were about one hundred twenty of them in the room at the time--

15 In those days Peter stood up among the believers (a group numbering about a hundred and twenty)

16 and said, "Friends, long ago the Holy Spirit spoke through David regarding Judas, who became the guide to those who arrested Jesus. That Scripture had to be fulfilled, and now has been.

16 and said, "Brothers, the Scripture had to be fulfilled which the Holy Spirit spoke long ago through the mouth of David concerning Judas, who served as guide for those who arrested Jesus--

17 Judas was one of us and had his assigned place in this ministry.

17 he was one of our number and shared in this ministry."

18 "As you know, he took the evil bribe money and bought a small farm. There he came to a bad end, rupturing his belly and spilling his guts.

18 (With the reward he got for his wickedness, Judas bought a field; there he fell headlong, his body burst open and all his intestines spilled out.

19 Everybody in Jerusalem knows this by now; they call the place Murder Meadow.

19 Everyone in Jerusalem heard about this, so they called that field in their language Akeldama, that is, Field of Blood.)

20 It's exactly what we find written in the Psalms: Let his farm become haunted So no one can ever live there. "And also what was written later: Let someone else take over his post.

20 For, said Peter, "it is written in the book of Psalms, " 'May his place be deserted; let there be no one to dwell in it,' and, " 'May another take his place of leadership.'

21 "Judas must now be replaced. The replacement must come from the company of men who stayed together with us

21 Therefore it is necessary to choose one of the men who have been with us the whole time the Lord Jesus went in and out among us,

- 22 from the time Jesus was baptized by John up to the day of his ascension, designated along with us as a witness to his resurrection."
- 22 beginning from John's baptism to the time when Jesus was taken up from us. For one of these must become a witness with us of his resurrection."
- 23 They nominated two: Joseph Barsabbas, nicknamed Justus, and Matthias.
- 23 So they proposed two men: Joseph called Barsabbas (also known as Justus) and Matthias.
- 24 Then they prayed, "You, O God, know every one of us inside and out. Make plain which of these two men you choose
- 24 Then they prayed, "Lord, you know everyone's heart. Show us which of these two you have chosen
- 25 to take the place in this ministry and leadership that Judas threw away in order to go his own way."
- 25 to take over this apostolic ministry, which Judas left to go where he belongs."
- 26 They then drew straws. Matthias won and was counted in with the eleven apostles.
- 26 Then they cast lots, and the lot fell to Matthias; so he was added to the eleven apostles.

Acts 2

MSG

NIV

- 1 When the Feast of Pentecost came, they were all together in one place.
- 1 When the day of Pentecost came, they were all together in one place.
- 2 Without warning there was a sound like a strong wind, gale force--no one could tell where it came from. It filled the whole building.
- 2 Suddenly a sound like the blowing of a violent wind came from heaven and filled the whole house where they were sitting.
- 3 Then, like a wildfire, the Holy Spirit spread through their ranks,
- 3 They saw what seemed to be tongues of fire that separated and came to rest on each of them.

- 4 and they started speaking in a number of different languages as the Spirit prompted them.
- 4 All of them were filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak in other tongues as the Spirit enabled them.
- 5 There were many Jews staying in Jerusalem just then, devout pilgrims from all over the world.
- 5 Now there were staying in Jerusalem God-fearing Jews from every nation under heaven.
- 6 When they heard the sound, they came on the run. Then when they heard, one after another, their own mother tongues being spoken, they were thunderstruck.
- 6 When they heard this sound, a crowd came together in bewilderment, because each one heard them speaking in his own language.
- 7 They couldn't for the life of them figure out what was going on, and kept saying, "Aren't these all Galileans?"
- 7 Utterly amazed, they asked: "Are not all these men who are speaking Galileans?"
- 8 How come we're hearing them talk in our various mother tongues?
- 8 Then how is it that each of us hears them in his own native language?
- 9 Parthians, Medes, and Elamites; Visitors from Mesopotamia, Judea, and Cappadocia, Pontus and Asia,
- 9 Parthians, Medes and Elamites; residents of Mesopotamia, Judea and Cappadocia, Pontus and Asia,
- 10 Phrygia and Pamphylia, Egypt and the parts of Libya belonging to Cyrene; Immigrants from Rome,
- 10 Phrygia and Pamphylia, Egypt and the parts of Libya near Cyrene; visitors from Rome
- 11 both Jews and proselytes; Even Cretans and Arabs! "They're speaking our languages, describing God's mighty works!"
- 11 (both Jews and converts to Judaism); Cretans and Arabs--we hear them declaring the wonders of God in our own tongues!"
- 12 Their heads were spinning; they couldn't make head or tail of any of it. They talked back and forth, confused: "What's going on here?"
- 12 Amazed and perplexed, they asked one another, "What does this mean?"
- 13 Others joked, "They're drunk on cheap wine."

- 13 Some, however, made fun of them and said, "They have had too much wine. "
- 14 That's when Peter stood up and, backed by the other eleven, spoke out with bold urgency: "Fellow Jews, all of you who are visiting Jerusalem, listen carefully and get this story straight.
- 14 Then Peter stood up with the Eleven, raised his voice and addressed the crowd: "Fellow Jews and all of you who live in Jerusalem, let me explain this to you; listen carefully to what I say.
- 15 These people aren't drunk as some of you suspect. They haven't had time to get drunk--it's only nine o'clock in the morning.
- 15 These men are not drunk, as you suppose. It's only nine in the morning!
- 16 This is what the prophet Joel announced would happen:
- 16 No, this is what was spoken by the prophet Joel:
- 17 "In the Last Days," God says, "I will pour out my Spirit on every kind of people: Your sons will prophesy, also your daughters; Your young men will see visions, your old men dream dreams.
- 17 'In the last days, God says, I will pour out my Spirit on all people. Your sons and daughters will prophesy, your young men will see visions, your old men will dream dreams.
- 18 When the time comes, I'll pour out my Spirit On those who serve me, men and women both, and they'll prophesy.
- 18 Even on my servants, both men and women, I will pour out my Spirit in those days, and they will prophesy.
- 19 I'll set wonders in the sky above and signs on the earth below, Blood and fire and billowing smoke,
- 19 I will show wonders in the heaven above and signs on the earth below, blood and fire and billows of smoke.
- 20 the sun turning black and the moon blood-red, Before the Day of the Lord arrives, the Day tremendous and marvelous;
- 20 The sun will be turned to darkness and the moon to blood before the coming of the great and glorious day of the Lord.
- 21 And whoever calls out for help to me, God, will be saved."
- 21 And everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.'
- 22 "Fellow Israelites, listen carefully to these words: Jesus the Nazarene, a man thoroughly accredited by God to you--the miracles and wonders and signs that God did through him are common knowledge--

- 22 Men of Israel, listen to this: Jesus of Nazareth was a man accredited by God to you by miracles, wonders and signs, which God did among you through him, as you yourselves know.
- 23 this Jesus, following the deliberate and well-thought-out plan of God, was betrayed by men who took the law into their own hands, and was handed over to you. And you pinned him to a cross and killed him.
- 23 This man was handed over to you by God's set purpose and foreknowledge; and you, with the help of wicked men, put him to death by nailing him to the cross.
- 24 But God untied the death ropes and raised him up. Death was no match for him.
- 24 But God raised him from the dead, freeing him from the agony of death, because it was impossible for death to keep its hold on him.
- 25 David said it all: I saw God before me for all time. Nothing can shake me; he's right by my side.
- 25 David said about him: " 'I saw the Lord always before me. Because he is at my right hand, I will not be shaken.
- 26 I'm glad from the inside out, ecstatic; I've pitched my tent in the land of hope.
- 26 Therefore my heart is glad and my tongue rejoices; my body also will live in hope,
- 27 I know you'll never dump me in Hades; I'll never even smell the stench of death.
- 27 because you will not abandon me to the grave, nor will you let your Holy One see decay.
- 28 You've got my feet on the life-path, with your face shining sun-joy all around.
- 28 You have made known to me the paths of life; you will fill me with joy in your presence.'
- 29 "Dear friends, let me be completely frank with you. Our ancestor David is dead and buried--his tomb is in plain sight today.
- 29 Brothers, I can tell you confidently that the patriarch David died and was buried, and his tomb is here to this day.
- 30 But being also a prophet and knowing that God had solemnly sworn that a descendant of his would rule his kingdom,

30 But he was a prophet and knew that God had promised him on oath that he would place one of his descendants on his throne.

31 seeing far ahead, he talked of the resurrection of the Messiah--'no trip to Hades, no stench of death.'

31 Seeing what was ahead, he spoke of the resurrection of the Christ, that he was not abandoned to the grave, nor did his body see decay.

32 This Jesus, God raised up. And every one of us here is a witness to it.

32 God has raised this Jesus to life, and we are all witnesses of the fact.

33 Then, raised to the heights at the right hand of God and receiving the promise of the Holy Spirit from the Father, he poured out the Spirit he had just received. That is what you see and hear.

33 Exalted to the right hand of God, he has received from the Father the promised Holy Spirit and has poured out what you now see and hear.

34 For David himself did not ascend to heaven, but he did say, God said to my Master, "Sit at my right hand

34 For David did not ascend to heaven, and yet he said, " "The Lord said to my Lord: "Sit at my right hand

35 Until I make your enemies a stool for resting your feet."

35 until I make your enemies a footstool for your feet." ' "

36 "All Israel, then, know this: There's no longer room for doubt--God made him Master and Messiah, this Jesus whom you killed on a cross."

36 Therefore let all Israel be assured of this: God has made this Jesus, whom you crucified, both Lord and Christ.

37 Cut to the quick, those who were there listening asked Peter and the other apostles, "Brothers! Brothers! So now what do we do?"

37 When the people heard this, they were cut to the heart and said to Peter and the other apostles, "Brothers, what shall we do?"

38 Peter said, "Change your life. Turn to God and be baptized, each of you, in the name of Jesus Christ, so your sins are forgiven. Receive the gift of the Holy Spirit.

38 Peter replied, "Repent and be baptized, every one of you, in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins. And you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit.

39 The promise is targeted to you and your children, but also to all who are far away--whomever, in fact, our Master God invites."

39 The promise is for you and your children and for all who are far off--for all whom the Lord our God will call."

40 He went on in this vein for a long time, urging them over and over, "Get out while you can; get out of this sick and stupid culture!"

40 With many other words he warned them; and he pleaded with them, "Save yourselves from this corrupt generation."

41 That day about three thousand took him at his word, were baptized and were signed up.

41 Those who accepted his message were baptized, and about three thousand were added to their number that day.

42 They committed themselves to the teaching of the apostles, the life together, the common meal, and the prayers.

42 They devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching and to the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and to prayer.

43 Everyone around was in awe--all those wonders and signs done through the apostles!

43 Everyone was filled with awe, and many wonders and miraculous signs were done by the apostles.

44 And all the believers lived in a wonderful harmony, holding everything in common.

44 All the believers were together and had everything in common.

45 They sold whatever they owned and pooled their resources so that each person's need was met.

45 Selling their possessions and goods, they gave to anyone as he had need.

46 They followed a daily discipline of worship in the Temple followed by meals at home, every meal a celebration, exuberant and joyful,

46 Every day they continued to meet together in the temple courts. They broke bread in their homes and ate together with glad and sincere hearts,

47 as they praised God. People in general liked what they saw. Every day their number grew as God added those who were saved.

47 praising God and enjoying the favor of all the people. And the Lord added to their number daily those who were being saved.

Acts 3

MSG

NIV

- 1 One day at three o'clock in the afternoon, Peter and John were on their way into the Temple for prayer meeting.
- 1 One day Peter and John were going up to the temple at the time of prayer--at three in the afternoon.
- 2 At the same time there was a man crippled from birth being carried up. Every day he was set down at the Temple gate, the one named Beautiful, to beg from those going into the Temple.
- 2 Now a man crippled from birth was being carried to the temple gate called Beautiful, where he was put every day to beg from those going into the temple courts.
- 3 When he saw Peter and John about to enter the Temple, he asked for a handout.
- 3 When he saw Peter and John about to enter, he asked them for money.
- 4 Peter, with John at his side, looked him straight in the eye and said, "Look here."
- 4 Peter looked straight at him, as did John. Then Peter said, "Look at us!"
- 5 He looked up, expecting to get something from them.
- 5 So the man gave them his attention, expecting to get something from them.
- 6 Peter said, "I don't have a nickel to my name, but what I do have, I give you: In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, walk!"
- 6 Then Peter said, "Silver or gold I do not have, but what I have I give you. In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, walk."
- 7 He grabbed him by the right hand and pulled him up. In an instant his feet and ankles became firm.
- 7 Taking him by the right hand, he helped him up, and instantly the man's feet and ankles became strong.
- 8 He jumped to his feet and walked. The man went into the Temple with them, walking back and forth, dancing and praising God.
- 8 He jumped to his feet and began to walk. Then he went with them into the temple courts, walking and jumping, and praising God.
- 9 Everybody there saw him walking around and praising God.
- 9 When all the people saw him walking and praising God,

- 10 They recognized him as the one who sat begging at the Temple's Gate Beautiful and rubbed their eyes, astonished, scarcely believing what they were seeing.
- 10 they recognized him as the same man who used to sit begging at the temple gate called Beautiful, and they were filled with wonder and amazement at what had happened to him.
- 11 The man threw his arms around Peter and John, ecstatic. All the people ran up to where they were at Solomon's Porch to see it for themselves.
- 11 While the beggar held on to Peter and John, all the people were astonished and came running to them in the place called Solomon's Colonnade.
- 12 When Peter saw he had a congregation, he addressed the people: "Oh, Israelites, why does this take you by such complete surprise, and why stare at us as if our power or piety made him walk?
- 12 When Peter saw this, he said to them: "Men of Israel, why does this surprise you? Why do you stare at us as if by our own power or godliness we had made this man walk?
- 13 The God of Abraham and Isaac and Jacob, the God of our ancestors, has glorified his Son Jesus. The very One that Pilate called innocent, you repudiated.
- 13 The God of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, the God of our fathers, has glorified his servant Jesus. You handed him over to be killed, and you disowned him before Pilate, though he had decided to let him go.
- 14 You repudiated the Holy One, the Just One, and asked for a murderer in his place.
- 14 You disowned the Holy and Righteous One and asked that a murderer be released to you.
- 15 You no sooner killed the Author of Life than God raised him from the dead--and we're the witnesses.
- 15 You killed the author of life, but God raised him from the dead. We are witnesses of this.
- 16 Faith in Jesus' name put this man, whose condition you know so well, on his feet--yes, faith and nothing but faith put this man healed and whole right before your eyes.
- 16 By faith in the name of Jesus, this man whom you see and know was made strong. It is Jesus' name and the faith that comes through him that

- has given this complete healing to him, as you can all see.
- 17 "And now, friends, I know you had no idea what you were doing when you killed Jesus, and neither did your leaders.
- 17 Now, brothers, I know that you acted in ignorance, as did your leaders.
- 18 But God, who through the preaching of all the prophets had said all along that his Messiah would be killed, knew exactly what you were doing and used it to fulfill his plans.
- 18 But this is how God fulfilled what he had foretold through all the prophets, saying that his Christ would suffer.
- 19 "Now it's time to change your ways! Turn to face God so he can wipe away your sins, pour out showers of blessing to refresh you,
- 19 Repent, then, and turn to God, so that your sins may be wiped out, that times of refreshing may come from the Lord,
- 20 and send you the Messiah he prepared for you, namely, Jesus.
- 20 and that he may send the Christ, who has been appointed for you--even Jesus.
- 21 For the time being he must remain out of sight in heaven until everything is restored to order again just the way God, through the preaching of his holy prophets of old, said it would be.
- 21 He must remain in heaven until the time comes for God to restore everything, as he promised long ago through his holy prophets.
- 22 Moses, for instance, said, 'Your God will raise up for you a prophet just like me from your family. Listen to every word he speaks to you.
- 22 For Moses said, 'The Lord your God will raise up for you a prophet like me from among your own people; you must listen to everything he tells you.
- 23 Every last living soul who refuses to listen to that prophet will be wiped out from the people.'
- 23 Anyone who does not listen to him will be completely cut off from among his people.'
- 24 "All the prophets from Samuel on down said the same thing, said most emphatically that these days would come.
- 24 Indeed, all the prophets from Samuel on, as many as have spoken, have foretold these days.
- 25 These prophets, along with the covenant God made with your ancestors, are your family tree. God's covenant-word to Abraham provides the text:

- 'By your offspring all the families of the earth will be blessed.'
- 25 And you are heirs of the prophets and of the covenant God made with your fathers. He said to Abraham, 'Through your offspring all peoples on earth will be blessed.'
- 26 But you are first in line: God, having raised up his Son, sent him to bless you as you turn, one by one, from your evil ways."
- 26 When God raised up his servant, he sent him first to you to bless you by turning each of you from your wicked ways."

Acts 4

MSG

NIV

- 1 While Peter and John were addressing the people, the priests, the chief of the Temple police, and some Sadducees came up,
- 1 The priests and the captain of the temple guard and the Sadducees came up to Peter and John while they were speaking to the people.
- 2 indignant that these upstart apostles were instructing the people and proclaiming that the resurrection from the dead had taken place in Jesus.
- 2 They were greatly disturbed because the apostles were teaching the people and proclaiming in Jesus the resurrection of the dead.
- 3 They arrested them and threw them in jail until morning, for by now it was late in the evening.
- 3 They seized Peter and John, and because it was evening, they put them in jail until the next day.
- 4 But many of those who listened had already believed the Message--in round numbers about five thousand!
- 4 But many who heard the message believed, and the number of men grew to about five thousand.
- 5 The next day a meeting was called in Jerusalem. The rulers, religious leaders, religion scholars,
- 5 The next day the rulers, elders and teachers of the law met in Jerusalem.
- 6 Annas the Chief Priest, Caiaphas, John, Alexander--everybody who was anybody was there.
- 6 Annas the high priest was there, and so were Caiaphas, John, Alexander and the other men of the high priest's family.

- 7 They stood Peter and John in the middle of the room and grilled them: "Who put you in charge here? What business do you have doing this?"
- 7 They had Peter and John brought before them and began to question them: "By what power or what name did you do this?"
- 8 With that, Peter, full of the Holy Spirit, let loose: "Rulers and leaders of the people,
- 8 Then Peter, filled with the Holy Spirit, said to them: "Rulers and elders of the people!
- 9 if we have been brought to trial today for helping a sick man, put under investigation regarding this healing,
- 9 If we are being called to account today for an act of kindness shown to a cripple and are asked how he was healed,
- 10 I'll be completely frank with you--we have nothing to hide. By the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, the One you killed on a cross, the One God raised from the dead, by means of his name this man stands before you healthy and whole.
- 10 then know this, you and all the people of Israel: It is by the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, whom you crucified but whom God raised from the dead, that this man stands before you healed.
- 11 Jesus is 'the stone you masons threw out, which is now the cornerstone.'
- 11 He is " 'the stone you builders rejected, which has become the capstone.
- 12 Salvation comes no other way; no other name has been or will be given to us by which we can be saved, only this one."
- 12 Salvation is found in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given to men by which we must be saved."
- 13 They couldn't take their eyes off them--Peter and John standing there so confident, so sure of themselves! Their fascination deepened when they realized these two were laymen with no training in Scripture or formal education. They recognized them as companions of Jesus,
- 13 When they saw the courage of Peter and John and realized that they were unschooled, ordinary men, they were astonished and they took note that these men had been with Jesus.
- 14 but with the man right before them, seeing him standing there so upright--so healed!--what could they say against that?

- 14 But since they could see the man who had been healed standing there with them, there was nothing they could say.
- 15 They sent them out of the room so they could work out a plan. They talked it over:
- 15 So they ordered them to withdraw from the Sanhedrin and then conferred together.
- 16 "What can we do with these men? By now it's known all over town that a miracle has occurred, and that they are behind it. There is no way we can refute that.
- 16 What are we going to do with these men? they asked. "Everybody living in Jerusalem knows they have done an outstanding miracle, and we cannot deny it.
- 17 But so that it doesn't go any further, let's silence them with threats so they won't dare to use Jesus' name ever again with anyone."
- 17 But to stop this thing from spreading any further among the people, we must warn these men to speak no longer to anyone in this name."
- 18 They called them back and warned them that they were on no account ever again to speak or teach in the name of Jesus.
- 18 Then they called them in again and commanded them not to speak or teach at all in the name of Jesus.
- 19 But Peter and John spoke right back, "Whether it's right in God's eyes to listen to you rather than to God, you decide.
- 19 But Peter and John replied, "Judge for yourselves whether it is right in God's sight to obey you rather than God.
- 20 As for us, there's no question--we can't keep quiet about what we've seen and heard."
- 20 For we cannot help speaking about what we have seen and heard."
- 21 The religious leaders renewed their threats, but then released them. They couldn't come up with a charge that would stick, that would keep them in jail. The people wouldn't have stood for it--they were all praising God over what had happened.
- 21 After further threats they let them go. They could not decide how to punish them, because all the people were praising God for what had happened.
- 22 The man who had been miraculously healed was over forty years old.
- 22 For the man who was miraculously healed was over forty years old.

23 As soon as Peter and John were let go, they went to their friends and told them what the high priests and religious leaders had said.

23 On their release, Peter and John went back to their own people and reported all that the chief priests and elders had said to them.

24 Hearing the report, they lifted their voices in a wonderful harmony in prayer: "Strong God, you made heaven and earth and sea and everything in them.

24 When they heard this, they raised their voices together in prayer to God. "Sovereign Lord," they said, "you made the heaven and the earth and the sea, and everything in them.

25 By the Holy Spirit you spoke through the mouth of your servant and our father, David: Why the big noise, nations? Why the mean plots, peoples?

25 You spoke by the Holy Spirit through the mouth of your servant, our father David: " 'Why do the nations rage and the peoples plot in vain?

26 Earth's leaders push for position, Potentates meet for summit talks, The God-deniers, the Messiah-defiers!

26 The kings of the earth take their stand and the rulers gather together against the Lord and against his Anointed One. '

27 "For in fact they did meet--Herod and Pontius Pilate with nations and peoples, even Israel itself!--met in this very city to plot against your holy Son Jesus, the One you made Messiah,

27 Indeed Herod and Pontius Pilate met together with the Gentiles and the people of Israel in this city to conspire against your holy servant Jesus, whom you anointed.

28 to carry out the plans you long ago set in motion.

28 They did what your power and will had decided beforehand should happen.

29 "And now they're at it again! Take care of their threats and give your servants fearless confidence in preaching your Message,

29 Now, Lord, consider their threats and enable your servants to speak your word with great boldness.

30 as you stretch out your hand to us in healings and miracles and wonders done in the name of your holy servant Jesus."

30 Stretch out your hand to heal and perform miraculous signs and wonders through the name of your holy servant Jesus."

- 31 While they were praying, the place where they were meeting trembled and shook. They were all filled with the Holy Spirit and continued to speak God's Word with fearless confidence.
- 31 After they prayed, the place where they were meeting was shaken. And they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and spoke the word of God boldly.
- 32 The whole congregation of believers was united as one--one heart, one mind! They didn't even claim ownership of their own possessions. No one said, "That's mine; you can't have it." They shared everything.
- 32 All the believers were one in heart and mind. No one claimed that any of his possessions was his own, but they shared everything they had.
- 33 The apostles gave powerful witness to the resurrection of the Master Jesus, and grace was on all of them.
- 33 With great power the apostles continued to testify to the resurrection of the Lord Jesus, and much grace was upon them all.
- 34 And so it turned out that not a person among them was needy. Those who owned fields or houses sold them and brought the price of the sale
- 34 There were no needy persons among them. For from time to time those who owned lands or houses sold them, brought the money from the sales
- 35 to the apostles and made an offering of it. The apostles then distributed it according to each person's need.
- 35 and put it at the apostles' feet, and it was distributed to anyone as he had need.
- 36 Joseph, called by the apostles "Barnabas" (which means "Son of Comfort"), a Levite born in Cyprus,
- 36 Joseph, a Levite from Cyprus, whom the apostles called Barnabas (which means Son of Encouragement),
- 37 sold a field that he owned, brought the money, and made an offering of it to the apostles.
- 37 sold a field he owned and brought the money and put it at the apostles' feet.

Acts 5

MSG

NIV

- 1 But a man named Ananias--his wife, Sapphira, conniving in this with him--sold a piece of land,
- 1 Now a man named Ananias, together with his wife Sapphira, also sold a piece of property.
- 2 secretly kept part of the price for himself, and then brought the rest to the apostles and made an offering of it.
- 2 With his wife's full knowledge he kept back part of the money for himself, but brought the rest and put it at the apostles' feet.
- 3 Peter said, "Ananias, how did Satan get you to lie to the Holy Spirit and secretly keep back part of the price of the field?
- 3 Then Peter said, "Ananias, how is it that Satan has so filled your heart that you have lied to the Holy Spirit and have kept for yourself some of the money you received for the land?
- 4 Before you sold it, it was all yours, and after you sold it, the money was yours to do with as you wished. So what got into you to pull a trick like this? You didn't lie to men but to God."
- 4 Didn't it belong to you before it was sold? And after it was sold, wasn't the money at your disposal? What made you think of doing such a thing? You have not lied to men but to God."
- 5 Ananias, when he heard those words, fell down dead. That put the fear of God into everyone who heard of it.
- 5 When Ananias heard this, he fell down and died. And great fear seized all who heard what had happened.
- 6 The younger men went right to work and wrapped him up, then carried him out and buried him.
- 6 Then the young men came forward, wrapped up his body, and carried him out and buried him.
- 7 Not more than three hours later, his wife, knowing nothing of what had happened, came in.
- 7 About three hours later his wife came in, not knowing what had happened.
- 8 Peter said, "Tell me, were you given this price for your field?" "Yes," she said, "that price."
- 8 Peter asked her, "Tell me, is this the price you and Ananias got for the land?" "Yes," she said, "that is the price."

- 9 Peter responded, "What's going on here that you connived to conspire against the Spirit of the Master? The men who buried your husband are at the door, and you're next."
- 9 Peter said to her, "How could you agree to test the Spirit of the Lord? Look! The feet of the men who buried your husband are at the door, and they will carry you out also."
- 10 No sooner were the words out of his mouth than she also fell down, dead. When the young men returned they found her body. They carried her out and buried her beside her husband.
- 10 At that moment she fell down at his feet and died. Then the young men came in and, finding her dead, carried her out and buried her beside her husband.
- 11 By this time the whole church and, in fact, everyone who heard of these things had a healthy respect for God. They knew God was not to be trifled with.
- 11 Great fear seized the whole church and all who heard about these events.
- 12 Through the work of the apostles, many God-signs were set up among the people, many wonderful things done. They all met regularly and in remarkable harmony on the Temple porch named after Solomon.
- 12 The apostles performed many miraculous signs and wonders among the people. And all the believers used to meet together in Solomon's Colonnade.
- 13 But even though people admired them a lot, outsiders were wary about joining them.
- 13 No one else dared join them, even though they were highly regarded by the people.
- 14 On the other hand, those who put their trust in the Master were added right and left, men and women both.
- 14 Nevertheless, more and more men and women believed in the Lord and were added to their number.
- 15 They even carried the sick out into the streets and laid them on stretchers and bedrolls, hoping they would be touched by Peter's shadow when he walked by.
- 15 As a result, people brought the sick into the streets and laid them on beds and mats so that at least Peter's shadow might fall on some of them

as he passed by.

16 They came from the villages surrounding Jerusalem, throngs of them, bringing the sick and bedeviled. And they all were healed.

16 Crowds gathered also from the towns around Jerusalem, bringing their sick and those tormented by evil spirits, and all of them were healed.

17 Provoked mightily by all this, the Chief Priest and those on his side, mainly the sect of Sadducees, went into action,

17 Then the high priest and all his associates, who were members of the party of the Sadducees, were filled with jealousy.

18 arrested the apostles, and put them in the town jail.

18 They arrested the apostles and put them in the public jail.

19 But during the night an angel of God opened the jailhouse door and led them out.

19 But during the night an angel of the Lord opened the doors of the jail and brought them out.

20 He said, "Go to the Temple and take your stand. Tell the people everything there is to say about this Life."

20 Go, stand in the temple courts, he said, "and tell the people the full message of this new life."

21 Promptly obedient, they entered the Temple at daybreak and went on with their teaching. Meanwhile, the Chief Priest and his cronies convened the High Council, Israel's senate, and sent to the jail to have the prisoners brought in.

21 At daybreak they entered the temple courts, as they had been told, and began to teach the people. When the high priest and his associates arrived, they called together the Sanhedrin--the full assembly of the elders of Israel--and sent to the jail for the apostles.

22 When the police got there, they couldn't find them anywhere in the jail. They went back and reported,

22 But on arriving at the jail, the officers did not find them there. So they went back and reported,

23 "We found the jail locked tight as a drum and the guards posted at the doors, but when we went inside we didn't find a soul."

23 We found the jail securely locked, with the guards standing at the doors; but when we opened them, we found no one inside.

24 The chief of the Temple police and the high priests were puzzled.
"What's going on here anyway?"

24 On hearing this report, the captain of the temple guard and the chief priests were puzzled, wondering what would come of this.

25 Just then someone showed up and said, "Did you know that the men you put in jail are back in the Temple teaching the people?"

25 Then someone came and said, "Look! The men you put in jail are standing in the temple courts teaching the people."

26 The chief and his police went and got them, but they handled them gently, fearful that the people would riot and turn on them.

26 At that, the captain went with his officers and brought the apostles. They did not use force, because they feared that the people would stone them.

27 Bringing them back, they stood them before the High Council. The Chief Priest said,

27 Having brought the apostles, they made them appear before the Sanhedrin to be questioned by the high priest.

28 "Didn't we give you strict orders not to teach in Jesus' name? And here you have filled Jerusalem with your teaching and are trying your best to blame us for the death of this man."

28 We gave you strict orders not to teach in this name, he said. "Yet you have filled Jerusalem with your teaching and are determined to make us guilty of this man's blood."

29 Peter and the apostles answered, "It's necessary to obey God rather than men.

29 Peter and the other apostles replied: "We must obey God rather than men!

30 The God of our ancestors raised up Jesus, the One you killed by hanging him on a cross.

30 The God of our fathers raised Jesus from the dead--whom you had killed by hanging him on a tree.

31 God set him on high at his side, Prince and Savior, to give Israel the gift of a changed life and sins forgiven.

31 God exalted him to his own right hand as Prince and Savior that he might give repentance and forgiveness of sins to Israel.

- 32 And we are witnesses to these things. The Holy Spirit, whom God gives to those who obey him, corroborates every detail."
- 32 We are witnesses of these things, and so is the Holy Spirit, whom God has given to those who obey him."
- 33 When they heard that, they were furious and wanted to kill them on the spot.
- 33 When they heard this, they were furious and wanted to put them to death.
- 34 But one of the council members stood up, a Pharisee by the name of Gamaliel, a teacher of God's Law who was honored by everyone. He ordered the men taken out of the room for a short time,
- 34 But a Pharisee named Gamaliel, a teacher of the law, who was honored by all the people, stood up in the Sanhedrin and ordered that the men be put outside for a little while.
- 35 then said, "Fellow Israelites, be careful what you do to these men.
- 35 Then he addressed them: "Men of Israel, consider carefully what you intend to do to these men.
- 36 Not long ago Theudas made something of a splash, claiming to be somebody, and got about four hundred men to join him. He was killed, his followers dispersed, and nothing came of it.
- 36 Some time ago Theudas appeared, claiming to be somebody, and about four hundred men rallied to him. He was killed, all his followers were dispersed, and it all came to nothing.
- 37 A little later, at the time of the census, Judas the Galilean appeared and acquired a following. He also fizzled out and the people following him were scattered to the four winds.
- 37 After him, Judas the Galilean appeared in the days of the census and led a band of people in revolt. He too was killed, and all his followers were scattered.
- 38 "So I am telling you: Hands off these men! Let them alone. If this program or this work is merely human, it will fall apart,
- 38 Therefore, in the present case I advise you: Leave these men alone! Let them go! For if their purpose or activity is of human origin, it will fail.
- 39 but if it is of God, there is nothing you can do about it--and you better not be found fighting against God!"

- 39 But if it is from God, you will not be able to stop these men; you will only find yourselves fighting against God."
- 40 That convinced them. They called the apostles back in. After giving them a thorough whipping, they warned them not to speak in Jesus' name and sent them off.
- 40 His speech persuaded them. They called the apostles in and had them flogged. Then they ordered them not to speak in the name of Jesus, and let them go.
- 41 The apostles went out of the High Council overjoyed because they had been given the honor of being dishonored on account of the Name.
- 41 The apostles left the Sanhedrin, rejoicing because they had been counted worthy of suffering disgrace for the Name.
- 42 Every day they were in the Temple and homes, teaching and preaching Christ Jesus, not letting up for a minute.
- 42 Day after day, in the temple courts and from house to house, they never stopped teaching and proclaiming the good news that Jesus is the Christ.

Acts 6

MSG

NIV

- 1 During this time, as the disciples were increasing in numbers by leaps and bounds, hard feelings developed among the Greek-speaking believers--"Hellenists"--toward the Hebrew-speaking believers because their widows were being discriminated against in the daily food lines.
- 1 In those days when the number of disciples was increasing, the Grecian Jews among them complained against the Hebraic Jews because their widows were being overlooked in the daily distribution of food.
- 2 So the Twelve called a meeting of the disciples. They said, "It wouldn't be right for us to abandon our responsibilities for preaching and teaching the Word of God to help with the care of the poor.
- 2 So the Twelve gathered all the disciples together and said, "It would not be right for us to neglect the ministry of the word of God in order to wait on tables.
- 3 So, friends, choose seven men from among you whom everyone trusts, men full of the Holy Spirit and good sense, and we'll assign them this

task.

- 3 Brothers, choose seven men from among you who are known to be full of the Spirit and wisdom. We will turn this responsibility over to them
- 4 Meanwhile, we'll stick to our assigned tasks of prayer and speaking God's Word."
- 4 and will give our attention to prayer and the ministry of the word."
- 5 The congregation thought this was a great idea. They went ahead and chose-- Stephen, a man full of faith and the Holy Spirit, Philip, Procorus, Nicanor, Timon, Parmenas, Nicolas, a convert from Antioch.
- 5 This proposal pleased the whole group. They chose Stephen, a man full of faith and of the Holy Spirit; also Philip, Procorus, Nicanor, Timon, Parmenas, and Nicolas from Antioch, a convert to Judaism.
- 6 Then they presented them to the apostles. Praying, the apostles laid on hands and commissioned them for their task.
- 6 They presented these men to the apostles, who prayed and laid their hands on them.
- 7 The Word of God prospered. The number of disciples in Jerusalem increased dramatically. Not least, a great many priests submitted themselves to the faith.
- 7 So the word of God spread. The number of disciples in Jerusalem increased rapidly, and a large number of priests became obedient to the faith.
- 8 Stephen, brimming with God's grace and energy, was doing wonderful things among the people, unmistakable signs that God was among them.
- 8 Now Stephen, a man full of God's grace and power, did great wonders and miraculous signs among the people.
- 9 But then some men from the meeting place whose membership was made up of freed slaves, Cyrenians, Alexandrians, and some others from Cilicia and Asia, went up against him trying to argue him down.
- 9 Opposition arose, however, from members of the Synagogue of the Freedmen (as it was called)--Jews of Cyrene and Alexandria as well as the provinces of Cilicia and Asia. These men began to argue with Stephen,
- 10 But they were no match for his wisdom and spirit when he spoke.
- 10 but they could not stand up against his wisdom or the Spirit by whom he spoke.

- 11 So in secret they bribed men to lie: "We heard him cursing Moses and God."
- 11 Then they secretly persuaded some men to say, "We have heard Stephen speak words of blasphemy against Moses and against God."
- 12 That stirred up the people, the religious leaders, and religion scholars. They grabbed Stephen and took him before the High Council
- 12 So they stirred up the people and the elders and the teachers of the law. They seized Stephen and brought him before the Sanhedrin.
- 13 They put forward their bribed witnesses to testify: "This man talks nonstop against this Holy Place and God's Law.
- 13 They produced false witnesses, who testified, "This fellow never stops speaking against this holy place and against the law.
- 14 We even heard him say that Jesus of Nazareth would tear this place down and throw out all the customs Moses gave us."
- 14 For we have heard him say that this Jesus of Nazareth will destroy this place and change the customs Moses handed down to us."
- 15 As all those who sat on the High Council looked at Stephen, they found they couldn't take their eyes off him--his face was like the face of an angel!
- 15 All who were sitting in the Sanhedrin looked intently at Stephen, and they saw that his face was like the face of an angel.

Acts 7

MSG

NIV

- 1 Then the Chief Priest said, "What do you have to say for yourself?"
- 1 Then the high priest asked him, "Are these charges true?"
- 2 Stephen replied, "Friends, fathers, and brothers, the God of glory appeared to our father Abraham when he was still in Mesopotamia, before the move to Haran,
- 2 To this he replied: "Brothers and fathers, listen to me! The God of glory appeared to our father Abraham while he was still in Mesopotamia, before he lived in Haran.
- 3 and told him, 'Leave your country and family and go to the land I'll show you.'

- 3 'Leave your country and your people,' God said, 'and go to the land I will show you.'
- 4 "So he left the country of the Chaldees and moved to Haran. After the death of his father, he immigrated to this country where you now live,
- 4 So he left the land of the Chaldeans and settled in Haran. After the death of his father, God sent him to this land where you are now living.
- 5 but God gave him nothing, not so much as a foothold. He did promise to give the country to him and his son later on, even though Abraham had no son at the time.
- 5 He gave him no inheritance here, not even a foot of ground. But God promised him that he and his descendants after him would possess the land, even though at that time Abraham had no child.
- 6 God let him know that his offspring would move to an alien country where they would be enslaved and brutalized for four hundred years.
- 6 God spoke to him in this way: 'Your descendants will be strangers in a country not their own, and they will be enslaved and mistreated four hundred years.
- 7 'But,' God said, 'I will step in and take care of those slaveholders and bring my people out so they can worship me in this place.'
- 7 But I will punish the nation they serve as slaves,' God said, 'and afterward they will come out of that country and worship me in this place.'
- 8 "Then he made a covenant with him and signed it in Abraham's flesh by circumcision. When Abraham had his son Isaac, within eight days he reproduced the sign of circumcision in him. Isaac became father of Jacob, and Jacob father of twelve 'fathers,' each faithfully passing on the covenant sign.
- 8 Then he gave Abraham the covenant of circumcision. And Abraham became the father of Isaac and circumcised him eight days after his birth. Later Isaac became the father of Jacob, and Jacob became the father of the twelve patriarchs.
- 9 "But then those 'fathers,' burning up with jealousy, sent Joseph off to Egypt as a slave. God was right there with him, though--
- 9 Because the patriarchs were jealous of Joseph, they sold him as a slave into Egypt. But God was with him

- 10 he not only rescued him from all his troubles but brought him to the attention of Pharaoh, king of Egypt. He was so impressed with Joseph that he put him in charge of the whole country, including his own personal affairs.
- 10 and rescued him from all his troubles. He gave Joseph wisdom and enabled him to gain the goodwill of Pharaoh king of Egypt; so he made him ruler over Egypt and all his palace.
- 11 "Later a famine descended on that entire region, stretching from Egypt to Canaan, bringing terrific hardship. Our hungry fathers looked high and low for food, but the cupboard was bare.
- 11 Then a famine struck all Egypt and Canaan, bringing great suffering, and our fathers could not find food.
- 12 Jacob heard there was food in Egypt and sent our fathers to scout it out.
- 12 When Jacob heard that there was grain in Egypt, he sent our fathers on their first visit.
- 13 Having confirmed the report, they went back to Egypt a second time to get food. On that visit, Joseph revealed his true identity to his brothers and introduced the Jacob family to Pharaoh.
- 13 On their second visit, Joseph told his brothers who he was, and Pharaoh learned about Joseph's family.
- 14 Then Joseph sent for his father, Jacob, and everyone else in the family, seventy-five in all.
- 14 After this, Joseph sent for his father Jacob and his whole family, seventy-five in all.
- 15 That's how the Jacob family got to Egypt. "Jacob died, and our fathers after him.
- 15 Then Jacob went down to Egypt, where he and our fathers died.
- 16 They were taken to Shechem and buried in the tomb for which Abraham paid a good price to the sons of Hamor.
- 16 Their bodies were brought back to Shechem and placed in the tomb that Abraham had bought from the sons of Hamor at Shechem for a certain sum of money.
- 17 "When the four hundred years were nearly up, the time God promised Abraham for deliverance, the population of our people in Egypt had become very large.

- 17 As the time drew near for God to fulfill his promise to Abraham, the number of our people in Egypt greatly increased.
- 18 And there was now a king over Egypt who had never heard of Joseph.
- 18 Then another king, who knew nothing about Joseph, became ruler of Egypt.
- 19 He exploited our race mercilessly. He went so far as forcing us to abandon our newborn infants, exposing them to the elements to die a cruel death.
- 19 He dealt treacherously with our people and oppressed our forefathers by forcing them to throw out their newborn babies so that they would die.
- 20 "In just such a time Moses was born, a most beautiful baby. He was hidden at home for three months.
- 20 At that time Moses was born, and he was no ordinary child. For three months he was cared for in his father's house.
- 21 When he could be hidden no longer, he was put outside--and immediately rescued by Pharaoh's daughter, who mothered him as her own son.
- 21 When he was placed outside, Pharaoh's daughter took him and brought him up as her own son.
- 22 Moses was educated in the best schools in Egypt. He was equally impressive as a thinker and an athlete.
- 22 Moses was educated in all the wisdom of the Egyptians and was powerful in speech and action.
- 23 "When he was forty years old, he wondered how everything was going with his Hebrew kin and went out to look things over.
- 23 When Moses was forty years old, he decided to visit his fellow Israelites.
- 24 He saw an Egyptian abusing one of them and stepped in, avenging his underdog brother by knocking the Egyptian flat.
- 24 He saw one of them being mistreated by an Egyptian, so he went to his defense and avenged him by killing the Egyptian.
- 25 He thought his brothers would be glad that he was on their side, and even see him as an instrument of God to deliver them. But they didn't see it that way.
- 25 Moses thought that his own people would realize that God was using him to rescue them, but they did not.

- 26 The next day two of them were fighting and he tried to break it up, told them to shake hands and get along with each other: 'Friends, you are brothers, why are you beating up on each other?'
- 26 The next day Moses came upon two Israelites who were fighting. He tried to reconcile them by saying, 'Men, you are brothers; why do you want to hurt each other?'
- 27 'The one who had started the fight said, 'Who put you in charge of us?
- 27 But the man who was mistreating the other pushed Moses aside and said, 'Who made you ruler and judge over us?
- 28 Are you going to kill me like you killed that Egyptian yesterday?'
- 28 Do you want to kill me as you killed the Egyptian yesterday?'
- 29 When Moses heard that, realizing that the word was out, he ran for his life and lived in exile over in Midian. During the years of exile, two sons were born to him.
- 29 When Moses heard this, he fled to Midian, where he settled as a foreigner and had two sons.
- 30 'Forty years later, in the wilderness of Mount Sinai, an angel appeared to him in the guise of flames of a burning bush.
- 30 After forty years had passed, an angel appeared to Moses in the flames of a burning bush in the desert near Mount Sinai.
- 31 Moses, not believing his eyes, went up to take a closer look. He heard God's voice:
- 31 When he saw this, he was amazed at the sight. As he went over to look more closely, he heard the Lord's voice:
- 32 'I am the God of your fathers, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.' Frightened nearly out of his skin, Moses shut his eyes and turned away.
- 32 'I am the God of your fathers, the God of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob.' Moses trembled with fear and did not dare to look.
- 33 'God said, 'Kneel and pray. You are in a holy place, on holy ground.
- 33 Then the Lord said to him, 'Take off your sandals; the place where you are standing is holy ground.
- 34 I've seen the agony of my people in Egypt. I've heard their groans. I've come to help them. So get yourself ready; I'm sending you back to Egypt.'
- 34 I have indeed seen the oppression of my people in Egypt. I have heard their groaning and have come down to set them free. Now come, I will

send you back to Egypt.'

35 "This is the same Moses whom they earlier rejected, saying, 'Who put you in charge of us?' This is the Moses that God, using the angel flaming in the burning bush, sent back as ruler and redeemer.

35 This is the same Moses whom they had rejected with the words, 'Who made you ruler and judge?' He was sent to be their ruler and deliverer by God himself, through the angel who appeared to him in the bush.

36 He led them out of their slavery. He did wonderful things, setting up God-signs all through Egypt, down at the Red Sea, and out in the wilderness for forty years.

36 He led them out of Egypt and did wonders and miraculous signs in Egypt, at the Red Sea and for forty years in the desert.

37 This is the Moses who said to his congregation, 'God will raise up a prophet just like me from your descendants.'

37 This is that Moses who told the Israelites, 'God will send you a prophet like me from your own people.'

38 This is the Moses who stood between the angel speaking at Sinai and your fathers assembled in the wilderness and took the life-giving words given to him and handed them over to us,

38 He was in the assembly in the desert, with the angel who spoke to him on Mount Sinai, and with our fathers; and he received living words to pass on to us.

39 words our fathers would have nothing to do with. "They craved the old Egyptian ways,

39 But our fathers refused to obey him. Instead, they rejected him and in their hearts turned back to Egypt.

40 whining to Aaron, 'Make us gods we can see and follow. This Moses who got us out here miles from nowhere--who knows what's happened to him!'

40 They told Aaron, 'Make us gods who will go before us. As for this fellow Moses who led us out of Egypt--we don't know what has happened to him!'

41 That was the time when they made a calf-idol, brought sacrifices to it, and congratulated each other on the wonderful religious program they had put together.

- 41 That was the time they made an idol in the form of a calf. They brought sacrifices to it and held a celebration in honor of what their hands had made.
- 42 "God wasn't at all pleased; but he let them do it their way, worship every new god that came down the pike--and live with the consequences, consequences described by the prophet Amos: Did you bring me offerings of animals and grains those forty wilderness years, O Israel?
- 42 But God turned away and gave them over to the worship of the heavenly bodies. This agrees with what is written in the book of the prophets: " 'Did you bring me sacrifices and offerings forty years in the desert, O house of Israel?
- 43 Hardly. You were too busy building shrines to war gods, to sex goddesses, Worshiping them with all your might. That's why I put you in exile in Babylon.
- 43 You have lifted up the shrine of Molech and the star of your god Rephan, the idols you made to worship. Therefore I will send you into exile' beyond Babylon.
- 44 "And all this time our ancestors had a tent shrine for true worship, made to the exact specifications God provided Moses.
- 44 Our forefathers had the tabernacle of the Testimony with them in the desert. It had been made as God directed Moses, according to the pattern he had seen.
- 45 They had it with them as they followed Joshua, when God cleared the land of pagans, and still had it right down to the time of David.
- 45 Having received the tabernacle, our fathers under Joshua brought it with them when they took the land from the nations God drove out before them. It remained in the land until the time of David,
- 46 David asked God for a permanent place for worship.
- 46 who enjoyed God's favor and asked that he might provide a dwelling place for the God of Jacob.
- 47 But Solomon built it.
- 47 But it was Solomon who built the house for him.
- 48 "Yet that doesn't mean that Most High God lives in a building made by carpenters and masons. The prophet Isaiah put it well when he wrote,
- 48 However, the Most High does not live in houses made by men. As the prophet says:

49 "Heaven is my throne room; I rest my feet on earth. So what kind of house will you build me?" says God. "Where I can get away and relax?"

49 'Heaven is my throne, and the earth is my footstool. What kind of house will you build for me? says the Lord. Or where will my resting place be?

50 It's already built, and I built it."

50 Has not my hand made all these things?"

51 "And you continue, so bullheaded! Calluses on your hearts, flaps on your ears! Deliberately ignoring the Holy Spirit, you're just like your ancestors.

51 You stiff-necked people, with uncircumcised hearts and ears! You are just like your fathers: You always resist the Holy Spirit!

52 Was there ever a prophet who didn't get the same treatment? Your ancestors killed anyone who dared talk about the coming of the Just One. And you've kept up the family tradition--traitors and murderers, all of you.

52 Was there ever a prophet your fathers did not persecute? They even killed those who predicted the coming of the Righteous One. And now you have betrayed and murdered him--

53 You had God's Law handed to you by angels--gift-wrapped!--and you squandered it!"

53 you who have received the law that was put into effect through angels but have not obeyed it."

54 At that point they went wild, a rioting mob of catcalls and whistles and invective.

54 When they heard this, they were furious and gnashed their teeth at him.

55 But Stephen, full of the Holy Spirit, hardly noticed--he only had eyes for God, whom he saw in all his glory with Jesus standing at his side.

55 But Stephen, full of the Holy Spirit, looked up to heaven and saw the glory of God, and Jesus standing at the right hand of God.

56 He said, "Oh! I see heaven wide open and the Son of Man standing at God's side!"

56 Look, he said, "I see heaven open and the Son of Man standing at the right hand of God."

57 Yelling and hissing, the mob drowned him out. Now in full stampede,

57 At this they covered their ears and, yelling at the top of their voices, they all rushed at him,

- 58 they dragged him out of town and pelted him with rocks. The ringleaders took off their coats and asked a young man named Saul to watch them.
- 58 dragged him out of the city and began to stone him. Meanwhile, the witnesses laid their clothes at the feet of a young man named Saul.
- 59 As the rocks rained down, Stephen prayed, "Master Jesus, take my life."
- 59 While they were stoning him, Stephen prayed, "Lord Jesus, receive my spirit."
- 60 Then he knelt down, praying loud enough for everyone to hear, "Master, don't blame them for this sin"--his last words. Then he died. Saul was right there, congratulating the killers.
- 60 Then he fell on his knees and cried out, "Lord, do not hold this sin against them." When he had said this, he fell asleep.

Acts 8

MSG

NIV

- 1 That set off a terrific persecution of the church in Jerusalem. The believers were all scattered throughout Judea and Samaria. All, that is, but the apostles.
- 1 And Saul was there, giving approval to his death. On that day a great persecution broke out against the church at Jerusalem, and all except the apostles were scattered throughout Judea and Samaria.
- 2 Good and brave men buried Stephen, giving him a solemn funeral--not many dry eyes that day!
- 2 Godly men buried Stephen and mourned deeply for him.
- 3 And Saul just went wild, devastating the church, entering house after house after house, dragging men and women off to jail.
- 3 But Saul began to destroy the church. Going from house to house, he dragged off men and women and put them in prison.
- 4 Forced to leave home base, the Christians all became missionaries. Wherever they were scattered, they preached the Message about Jesus.
- 4 Those who had been scattered preached the word wherever they went.
- 5 Going down to a Samaritan city, Philip proclaimed the Message of the Messiah.

- 5 Philip went down to a city in Samaria and proclaimed the Christ there.
- 6 When the people heard what he had to say and saw the miracles, the clear signs of God's action, they hung on his every word.
- 6 When the crowds heard Philip and saw the miraculous signs he did, they all paid close attention to what he said.
- 7 Many who could neither stand nor walk were healed that day. The evil spirits protested loudly as they were sent on their way.
- 7 With shrieks, evil spirits came out of many, and many paralytics and cripples were healed.
- 8 And what joy in the city!
- 8 So there was great joy in that city.
- 9 Previous to Philip's arrival, a certain Simon had practiced magic in the city, posing as a famous man and dazzling all the Samaritans with his wizardry.
- 9 Now for some time a man named Simon had practiced sorcery in the city and amazed all the people of Samaria. He boasted that he was someone great,
- 10 He had them all, from little children to old men, eating out of his hand. They all thought he had supernatural powers, and called him "the Great Wizard."
- 10 and all the people, both high and low, gave him their attention and exclaimed, "This man is the divine power known as the Great Power."
- 11 He had been around a long time and everyone was more or less in awe of him.
- 11 They followed him because he had amazed them for a long time with his magic.
- 12 But when Philip came to town announcing the news of God's kingdom and proclaiming the name of Jesus Christ, they forgot Simon and were baptized, becoming believers right and left!
- 12 But when they believed Philip as he preached the good news of the kingdom of God and the name of Jesus Christ, they were baptized, both men and women.
- 13 Even Simon himself believed and was baptized. From that moment he was like Philip's shadow, so fascinated with all the God-signs and miracles that he wouldn't leave Philip's side.

- 13 Simon himself believed and was baptized. And he followed Philip everywhere, astonished by the great signs and miracles he saw.
- 14 When the apostles in Jerusalem received the report that Samaria had accepted God's Message, they sent Peter and John down
- 14 When the apostles in Jerusalem heard that Samaria had accepted the word of God, they sent Peter and John to them.
- 15 to pray for them to receive the Holy Spirit.
- 15 When they arrived, they prayed for them that they might receive the Holy Spirit,
- 16 Up to this point they had only been baptized in the name of the Master Jesus; the Holy Spirit hadn't yet fallen on them.
- 16 because the Holy Spirit had not yet come upon any of them; they had simply been baptized into the name of the Lord Jesus.
- 17 Then the apostles laid their hands on them and they did receive the Holy Spirit.
- 17 Then Peter and John placed their hands on them, and they received the Holy Spirit.
- 18 When Simon saw that the apostles by merely laying on hands conferred the Spirit, he pulled out his money, excited,
- 18 When Simon saw that the Spirit was given at the laying on of the apostles' hands, he offered them money
- 19 and said, "Sell me your secret! Show me how you did that! How much do you want? Name your price!"
- 19 and said, "Give me also this ability so that everyone on whom I lay my hands may receive the Holy Spirit."
- 20 Peter said, "To hell with your money! And you along with it. Why, that's unthinkable--trying to buy God's gift!
- 20 Peter answered: "May your money perish with you, because you thought you could buy the gift of God with money!
- 21 You'll never be part of what God is doing by striking bargains and offering bribes.
- 21 You have no part or share in this ministry, because your heart is not right before God.
- 22 Change your ways--and now! Ask the Master to forgive you for trying to use God to make money.

22 Repent of this wickedness and pray to the Lord. Perhaps he will forgive you for having such a thought in your heart.

23 I can see this is an old habit with you; you reek with money-lust."

23 For I see that you are full of bitterness and captive to sin."

24 "Oh!" said Simon, "pray for me! Pray to the Master that nothing like that will ever happen to me!"

24 Then Simon answered, "Pray to the Lord for me so that nothing you have said may happen to me."

25 And with that, the apostles were on their way, continuing to witness and spread the Message of God's salvation, preaching in every Samaritan town they passed through on their return to Jerusalem.

25 When they had testified and proclaimed the word of the Lord, Peter and John returned to Jerusalem, preaching the gospel in many Samaritan villages.

26 Later God's angel spoke to Philip: "At noon today I want you to walk over to that desolate road that goes from Jerusalem down to Gaza."

26 Now an angel of the Lord said to Philip, "Go south to the road--the desert road--that goes down from Jerusalem to Gaza."

27 He got up and went. He met an Ethiopian eunuch coming down the road. The eunuch had been on a pilgrimage to Jerusalem and was returning to Ethiopia, where he was minister in charge of all the finances of Candace, queen of the Ethiopians.

27 So he started out, and on his way he met an Ethiopian eunuch, an important official in charge of all the treasury of Candace, queen of the Ethiopians. This man had gone to Jerusalem to worship,

28 He was riding in a chariot and reading the prophet Isaiah.

28 and on his way home was sitting in his chariot reading the book of Isaiah the prophet.

29 The Spirit told Philip, "Climb into the chariot."

29 The Spirit told Philip, "Go to that chariot and stay near it."

30 Running up alongside, Philip heard the eunuch reading Isaiah and asked, "Do you understand what you're reading?"

30 Then Philip ran up to the chariot and heard the man reading Isaiah the prophet. "Do you understand what you are reading?" Philip asked.

31 He answered, "How can I without some help?" and invited Philip into the chariot with him.

31 How can I, he said, "unless someone explains it to me?" So he invited Philip to come up and sit with him.

32 The passage he was reading was this: As a sheep led to slaughter, and quiet as a lamb being sheared, He was silent, saying nothing.

32 The eunuch was reading this passage of Scripture: "He was led like a sheep to the slaughter, and as a lamb before the shearer is silent, so he did not open his mouth.

33 He was mocked and put down, never got a fair trial. But who now can count his kin since he's been taken from the earth?

33 In his humiliation he was deprived of justice. Who can speak of his descendants? For his life was taken from the earth."

34 The eunuch said, "Tell me, who is the prophet talking about: himself or some other?"

34 The eunuch asked Philip, "Tell me, please, who is the prophet talking about, himself or someone else?"

35 Philip grabbed his chance. Using this passage as his text, he preached Jesus to him.

35 Then Philip began with that very passage of Scripture and told him the good news about Jesus.

36 As they continued down the road, they came to a stream of water. The eunuch said, "Here's water. Why can't I be baptized?"

36 As they traveled along the road, they came to some water and the eunuch said, "Look, here is water. Why shouldn't I be baptized?"

37 (OMITTED TEXT)

38 He ordered the chariot to stop. They both went down to the water, and Philip baptized him on the spot.

38 And he gave orders to stop the chariot. Then both Philip and the eunuch went down into the water and Philip baptized him.

39 When they came up out of the water, the Spirit of God suddenly took Philip off, and that was the last the eunuch saw of him. But he didn't mind. He had what he'd come for and went on down the road as happy as he could be.

39 When they came up out of the water, the Spirit of the Lord suddenly took Philip away, and the eunuch did not see him again, but went on his way rejoicing.

- 40 Philip showed up in Azotus and continued north, preaching the Message in all the villages along that route until he arrived at Caesarea.
- 40 Philip, however, appeared at Azotus and traveled about, preaching the gospel in all the towns until he reached Caesarea.

Acts 9

MSG

NIV

- 1 All this time Saul was breathing down the necks of the Master's disciples, out for the kill. He went to the Chief Priest
- 1 Meanwhile, Saul was still breathing out murderous threats against the Lord's disciples. He went to the high priest
- 2 and got arrest warrants to take to the meeting places in Damascus so that if he found anyone there belonging to the Way, whether men or women, he could arrest them and bring them to Jerusalem.
- 2 and asked him for letters to the synagogues in Damascus, so that if he found any there who belonged to the Way, whether men or women, he might take them as prisoners to Jerusalem.
- 3 He set off. When he got to the outskirts of Damascus, he was suddenly dazed by a blinding flash of light.
- 3 As he neared Damascus on his journey, suddenly a light from heaven flashed around him.
- 4 As he fell to the ground, he heard a voice: "Saul, Saul, why are you out to get me?"
- 4 He fell to the ground and heard a voice say to him, "Saul, Saul, why do you persecute me?"
- 5 He said, "Who are you, Master?" "I am Jesus, the One you're hunting down.
- 5 Who are you, Lord? Saul asked. "I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting," he replied.
- 6 I want you to get up and enter the city. In the city you'll be told what to do next."
- 6 Now get up and go into the city, and you will be told what you must do.
- 7 His companions stood there dumbstruck--they could hear the sound, but couldn't see anyone--

- 7 The men traveling with Saul stood there speechless; they heard the sound but did not see anyone.
- 8 while Saul, picking himself up off the ground, found himself stone blind. They had to take him by the hand and lead him into Damascus.
- 8 Saul got up from the ground, but when he opened his eyes he could see nothing. So they led him by the hand into Damascus.
- 9 He continued blind for three days. He ate nothing, drank nothing.
- 9 For three days he was blind, and did not eat or drink anything.
- 10 There was a disciple in Damascus by the name of Ananias. The Master spoke to him in a vision: "Ananias." "Yes, Master?" he answered.
- 10 In Damascus there was a disciple named Ananias. The Lord called to him in a vision, "Ananias!" "Yes, Lord," he answered.
- 11 "Get up and go over to Straight Avenue. Ask at the house of Judas for a man from Tarsus. His name is Saul. He's there praying.
- 11 The Lord told him, "Go to the house of Judas on Straight Street and ask for a man from Tarsus named Saul, for he is praying.
- 12 He has just had a dream in which he saw a man named Ananias enter the house and lay hands on him so he could see again."
- 12 In a vision he has seen a man named Ananias come and place his hands on him to restore his sight."
- 13 Ananias protested, "Master, you can't be serious. Everybody's talking about this man and the terrible things he's been doing, his reign of terror against your people in Jerusalem!
- 13 Lord, Ananias answered, "I have heard many reports about this man and all the harm he has done to your saints in Jerusalem.
- 14 And now he's shown up here with papers from the Chief Priest that give him license to do the same to us."
- 14 And he has come here with authority from the chief priests to arrest all who call on your name."
- 15 But the Master said, "Don't argue. Go! I have picked him as my personal representative to Gentiles and kings and Jews.
- 15 But the Lord said to Ananias, "Go! This man is my chosen instrument to carry my name before the Gentiles and their kings and before the people of Israel.
- 16 And now I'm about to show him what he's in for--the hard suffering that goes with this job."

- 16 I will show him how much he must suffer for my name."
- 17 So Ananias went and found the house, placed his hands on blind Saul, and said, "Brother Saul, the Master sent me, the same Jesus you saw on your way here. He sent me so you could see again and be filled with the Holy Spirit."
- 17 Then Ananias went to the house and entered it. Placing his hands on Saul, he said, "Brother Saul, the Lord--Jesus, who appeared to you on the road as you were coming here--has sent me so that you may see again and be filled with the Holy Spirit."
- 18 No sooner were the words out of his mouth than something like scales fell from Saul's eyes--he could see again! He got to his feet, was baptized,
- 18 Immediately, something like scales fell from Saul's eyes, and he could see again. He got up and was baptized,
- 19 and sat down with them to a hearty meal. Saul spent a few days getting acquainted with the Damascus disciples,
- 19 and after taking some food, he regained his strength. Saul spent several days with the disciples in Damascus.
- 20 but then went right to work, wasting no time, preaching in the meeting places that this Jesus was the Son of God.
- 20 At once he began to preach in the synagogues that Jesus is the Son of God.
- 21 They were caught off guard by this and, not at all sure they could trust him, they kept saying, "Isn't this the man who wreaked havoc in Jerusalem among the believers? And didn't he come here to do the same thing--arrest us and drag us off to jail in Jerusalem for sentencing by the high priests?"
- 21 All those who heard him were astonished and asked, "Isn't he the man who raised havoc in Jerusalem among those who call on this name? And hasn't he come here to take them as prisoners to the chief priests?"
- 22 But their suspicions didn't slow Saul down for even a minute. His momentum was up now and he plowed straight into the opposition, disarming the Damascus Jews and trying to show them that this Jesus was the Messiah.
- 22 Yet Saul grew more and more powerful and baffled the Jews living in Damascus by proving that Jesus is the Christ.

23 After this had gone on quite a long time, some Jews conspired to kill him,

23 After many days had gone by, the Jews conspired to kill him,

24 but Saul got wind of it. They were watching the city gates around the clock so they could kill him.

24 but Saul learned of their plan. Day and night they kept close watch on the city gates in order to kill him.

25 Then one night the disciples engineered his escape by lowering him over the wall in a basket.

25 But his followers took him by night and lowered him in a basket through an opening in the wall.

26 Back in Jerusalem he tried to join the disciples, but they were all afraid of him. They didn't trust him one bit.

26 When he came to Jerusalem, he tried to join the disciples, but they were all afraid of him, not believing that he really was a disciple.

27 Then Barnabas took him under his wing. He introduced him to the apostles and stood up for him, told them how Saul had seen and spoken to the Master on the Damascus Road and how in Damascus itself he had laid his life on the line with his bold preaching in Jesus' name.

27 But Barnabas took him and brought him to the apostles. He told them how Saul on his journey had seen the Lord and that the Lord had spoken to him, and how in Damascus he had preached fearlessly in the name of Jesus.

28 After that he was accepted as one of them, going in and out of Jerusalem with no questions asked, uninhibited as he preached in the Master's name.

28 So Saul stayed with them and moved about freely in Jerusalem, speaking boldly in the name of the Lord.

29 But then he ran afoul of a group called Hellenists--he had been engaged in a running argument with them--who plotted his murder.

29 He talked and debated with the Grecian Jews, but they tried to kill him.

30 When his friends learned of the plot, they got him out of town, took him to Caesarea, and then shipped him off to Tarsus.

30 When the brothers learned of this, they took him down to Caesarea and sent him off to Tarsus.

- 31 Things calmed down after that and the church had smooth sailing for a while. All over the country--Judea, Samaria, Galilee--the church grew. They were permeated with a deep sense of reverence for God. The Holy Spirit was with them, strengthening them. They prospered wonderfully.
- 31 Then the church throughout Judea, Galilee and Samaria enjoyed a time of peace. It was strengthened; and encouraged by the Holy Spirit, it grew in numbers, living in the fear of the Lord.
- 32 Peter went off on a mission to visit all the churches. In the course of his travels he arrived in Lydda and met with the believers there.
- 32 As Peter traveled about the country, he went to visit the saints in Lydda.
- 33 He came across a man--his name was Aeneas--who had been in bed eight years paralyzed.
- 33 There he found a man named Aeneas, a paralytic who had been bedridden for eight years.
- 34 Peter said, "Aeneas, Jesus Christ heals you. Get up and make your bed!" And he did it--jumped right out of bed.
- 34 Aeneas, Peter said to him, "Jesus Christ heals you. Get up and take care of your mat." Immediately Aeneas got up.
- 35 Everybody who lived in Lydda and Sharon saw him walking around and woke up to the fact that God was alive and active among them.
- 35 All those who lived in Lydda and Sharon saw him and turned to the Lord.
- 36 Down the road a way in Joppa there was a disciple named Tabitha, "Gazelle" in our language. She was well-known for doing good and helping out.
- 36 In Joppa there was a disciple named Tabitha (which, when translated, is Dorcas), who was always doing good and helping the poor.
- 37 During the time Peter was in the area she became sick and died. Her friends prepared her body for burial and put her in a cool room.
- 37 About that time she became sick and died, and her body was washed and placed in an upstairs room.
- 38 Some of the disciples had heard that Peter was visiting in nearby Lydda and sent two men to ask if he would be so kind as to come over.
- 38 Lydda was near Joppa; so when the disciples heard that Peter was in Lydda, they sent two men to him and urged him, "Please come at once!"

- 39 Peter got right up and went with them. They took him into the room where Tabitha's body was laid out. Her old friends, most of them widows, were in the room mourning. They showed Peter pieces of clothing the Gazelle had made while she was with them.
- 39 Peter went with them, and when he arrived he was taken upstairs to the room. All the widows stood around him, crying and showing him the robes and other clothing that Dorcas had made while she was still with them.
- 40 Peter put the widows all out of the room. He knelt and prayed. Then he spoke directly to the body: "Tabitha, get up." She opened her eyes. When she saw Peter, she sat up.
- 40 Peter sent them all out of the room; then he got down on his knees and prayed. Turning toward the dead woman, he said, "Tabitha, get up." She opened her eyes, and seeing Peter she sat up.
- 41 He took her hand and helped her up. Then he called in the believers and widows, and presented her to them alive.
- 41 He took her by the hand and helped her to her feet. Then he called the believers and the widows and presented her to them alive.
- 42 When this became known all over Joppa, many put their trust in the Master.
- 42 This became known all over Joppa, and many people believed in the Lord.
- 43 Peter stayed on a long time in Joppa as a guest of Simon the Tanner.
- 43 Peter stayed in Joppa for some time with a tanner named Simon.

Acts 10

MSG

NIV

- 1 There was a man named Cornelius who lived in Caesarea, captain of the Italian Guard stationed there.
- 1 At Caesarea there was a man named Cornelius, a centurion in what was known as the Italian Regiment.
- 2 He was a thoroughly good man. He had led everyone in his house to live worshipfully before God, was always helping people in need, and had the habit of prayer.

- 2 He and all his family were devout and God-fearing; he gave generously to those in need and prayed to God regularly.
- 3 One day about three o'clock in the afternoon he had a vision. An angel of God, as real as his next-door neighbor, came in and said, "Cornelius."
- 3 One day at about three in the afternoon he had a vision. He distinctly saw an angel of God, who came to him and said, "Cornelius!"
- 4 Cornelius stared hard, wondering if he was seeing things. Then he said, "What do you want, sir?" The angel said, "Your prayers and neighborly acts have brought you to God's attention.
- 4 Cornelius stared at him in fear. "What is it, Lord?" he asked. The angel answered, "Your prayers and gifts to the poor have come up as a memorial offering before God.
- 5 Here's what you are to do. Send men to Joppa to get Simon, the one everyone calls Peter.
- 5 Now send men to Joppa to bring back a man named Simon who is called Peter.
- 6 He is staying with Simon the Tanner, whose house is down by the sea."
- 6 He is staying with Simon the tanner, whose house is by the sea."
- 7 As soon as the angel was gone, Cornelius called two servants and one particularly devout soldier from the guard.
- 7 When the angel who spoke to him had gone, Cornelius called two of his servants and a devout soldier who was one of his attendants.
- 8 He went over with them in great detail everything that had just happened, and then sent them off to Joppa.
- 8 He told them everything that had happened and sent them to Joppa.
- 9 The next day as the three travelers were approaching the town, Peter went out on the balcony to pray. It was about noon.
- 9 About noon the following day as they were on their journey and approaching the city, Peter went up on the roof to pray.
- 10 Peter got hungry and started thinking about lunch. While lunch was being prepared, he fell into a trance.
- 10 He became hungry and wanted something to eat, and while the meal was being prepared, he fell into a trance.
- 11 He saw the skies open up. Something that looked like a huge blanket lowered by ropes at its four corners settled on the ground.

- 11 He saw heaven opened and something like a large sheet being let down to earth by its four corners.
- 12 Every kind of animal and reptile and bird you could think of was on it.
- 12 It contained all kinds of four-footed animals, as well as reptiles of the earth and birds of the air.
- 13 Then a voice came: "Go to it, Peter--kill and eat."
- 13 Then a voice told him, "Get up, Peter. Kill and eat."
- 14 Peter said, "Oh, no, Lord. I've never so much as tasted food that was not kosher."
- 14 Surely not, Lord! Peter replied. "I have never eaten anything impure or unclean."
- 15 The voice came a second time: "If God says it's okay, it's okay."
- 15 The voice spoke to him a second time, "Do not call anything impure that God has made clean."
- 16 This happened three times, and then the blanket was pulled back up into the skies.
- 16 This happened three times, and immediately the sheet was taken back to heaven.
- 17 As Peter, puzzled, sat there trying to figure out what it all meant, the men sent by Cornelius showed up at Simon's front door.
- 17 While Peter was wondering about the meaning of the vision, the men sent by Cornelius found out where Simon's house was and stopped at the gate.
- 18 They called in, asking if there was a Simon, also called Peter, staying there.
- 18 They called out, asking if Simon who was known as Peter was staying there.
- 19 Peter, lost in thought, didn't hear them, so the Spirit whispered to him, "Three men are knocking at the door looking for you."
- 19 While Peter was still thinking about the vision, the Spirit said to him, "Simon, three men are looking for you."
- 20 Get down there and go with them. Don't ask any questions. I sent them to get you."
- 20 So get up and go downstairs. Do not hesitate to go with them, for I have sent them."

- 21 Peter went down and said to the men, "I think I'm the man you're looking for. What's up?"
- 21 Peter went down and said to the men, "I'm the one you're looking for. Why have you come?"
- 22 They said, "Captain Cornelius, a God-fearing man well-known for his fair play--ask any Jew in this part of the country--was commanded by a holy angel to get you and bring you to his house so he could hear what you had to say."
- 22 The men replied, "We have come from Cornelius the centurion. He is a righteous and God-fearing man, who is respected by all the Jewish people. A holy angel told him to have you come to his house so that he could hear what you have to say."
- 23 Peter invited them in and made them feel at home. The next morning he got up and went with them. Some of his friends from Joppa went along.
- 23 Then Peter invited the men into the house to be his guests. The next day Peter started out with them, and some of the brothers from Joppa went along.
- 24 A day later they entered Caesarea. Cornelius was expecting them and had his relatives and close friends waiting with him.
- 24 The following day he arrived in Caesarea. Cornelius was expecting them and had called together his relatives and close friends.
- 25 The minute Peter came through the door, Cornelius was up on his feet greeting him--and then down on his face worshiping him!
- 25 As Peter entered the house, Cornelius met him and fell at his feet in reverence.
- 26 Peter pulled him up and said, "None of that--I'm a man and only a man, no different from you."
- 26 But Peter made him get up. "Stand up," he said, "I am only a man myself."
- 27 Talking things over, they went on into the house, where Cornelius introduced Peter to everyone who had come.
- 27 Talking with him, Peter went inside and found a large gathering of people.
- 28 Peter addressed them, "You know, I'm sure that this is highly irregular. Jews just don't do this--visit and relax with people of another race. But God has just shown me that no race is better than any other."

- 28 He said to them: "You are well aware that it is against our law for a Jew to associate with a Gentile or visit him. But God has shown me that I should not call any man impure or unclean.
- 29 So the minute I was sent for, I came, no questions asked. But now I'd like to know why you sent for me."
- 29 So when I was sent for, I came without raising any objection. May I ask why you sent for me?"
- 30 Cornelius said, "Four days ago at about this time, midafternoon, I was home praying. Suddenly there was a man right in front of me, flooding the room with light.
- 30 Cornelius answered: "Four days ago I was in my house praying at this hour, at three in the afternoon. Suddenly a man in shining clothes stood before me
- 31 He said, 'Cornelius, your daily prayers and neighborly acts have brought you to God's attention.
- 31 and said, 'Cornelius, God has heard your prayer and remembered your gifts to the poor.
- 32 I want you to send to Joppa to get Simon, the one they call Peter. He's staying with Simon the Tanner down by the sea.'
- 32 Send to Joppa for Simon who is called Peter. He is a guest in the home of Simon the tanner, who lives by the sea.'
- 33 "So I did it--I sent for you. And you've been good enough to come. And now we're all here in God's presence, ready to listen to whatever the Master put in your heart to tell us."
- 33 So I sent for you immediately, and it was good of you to come. Now we are all here in the presence of God to listen to everything the Lord has commanded you to tell us."
- 34 Peter fairly exploded with his good news: "It's God's own truth, nothing could be plainer: God plays no favorites!
- 34 Then Peter began to speak: "I now realize how true it is that God does not show favoritism
- 35 It makes no difference who you are or where you're from--if you want God and are ready to do as he says, the door is open.
- 35 but accepts men from every nation who fear him and do what is right.
- 36 The Message he sent to the children of Israel--that through Jesus Christ everything is being put together again--well, he's doing it everywhere,

among everyone.

36 You know the message God sent to the people of Israel, telling the good news of peace through Jesus Christ, who is Lord of all.

37 "You know the story of what happened in Judea. It began in Galilee after John preached a total life-change.

37 You know what has happened throughout Judea, beginning in Galilee after the baptism that John preached--

38 Then Jesus arrived from Nazareth, anointed by God with the Holy Spirit, ready for action. He went through the country helping people and healing everyone who was beaten down by the Devil. He was able to do all this because God was with him.

38 how God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and power, and how he went around doing good and healing all who were under the power of the devil, because God was with him.

39 "And we saw it, saw it all, everything he did in the land of the Jews and in Jerusalem where they killed him, hung him from a cross.

39 We are witnesses of everything he did in the country of the Jews and in Jerusalem. They killed him by hanging him on a tree,

40 But in three days God had him up, alive, and out where he could be seen.

40 but God raised him from the dead on the third day and caused him to be seen.

41 Not everyone saw him--he wasn't put on public display. Witnesses had been carefully handpicked by God beforehand--us! We were the ones, there to eat and drink with him after he came back from the dead.

41 He was not seen by all the people, but by witnesses whom God had already chosen--by us who ate and drank with him after he rose from the dead.

42 He commissioned us to announce this in public, to bear solemn witness that he is in fact the One whom God destined as Judge of the living and dead.

42 He commanded us to preach to the people and to testify that he is the one whom God appointed as judge of the living and the dead.

43 But we're not alone in this. Our witness that he is the means to forgiveness of sins is backed up by the witness of all the prophets."

- 43 All the prophets testify about him that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name."
- 44 No sooner were these words out of Peter's mouth than the Holy Spirit came on the listeners.
- 44 While Peter was still speaking these words, the Holy Spirit came on all who heard the message.
- 45 The believing Jews who had come with Peter couldn't believe it, couldn't believe that the gift of the Holy Spirit was poured out on "outsider" Gentiles,
- 45 The circumcised believers who had come with Peter were astonished that the gift of the Holy Spirit had been poured out even on the Gentiles.
- 46 but there it was--they heard them speaking in tongues, heard them praising God. Then Peter said,
- 46 For they heard them speaking in tongues and praising God. Then Peter said,
- 47 "Do I hear any objections to baptizing these friends with water? They've received the Holy Spirit exactly as we did."
- 47 Can anyone keep these people from being baptized with water? They have received the Holy Spirit just as we have.
- 48 Hearing no objections, he ordered that they be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ. Then they asked Peter to stay on for a few days.
- 48 So he ordered that they be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ. Then they asked Peter to stay with them for a few days.

Acts 11

MSG

NIV

- 1 The news traveled fast and in no time the leaders and friends back in Jerusalem heard about it--heard that the non-Jewish "outsiders" were now "in."
- 1 The apostles and the brothers throughout Judea heard that the Gentiles also had received the word of God.
- 2 When Peter got back to Jerusalem, some of his old associates, concerned about circumcision, called him on the carpet:

- 2 So when Peter went up to Jerusalem, the circumcised believers criticized him
- 3 "What do you think you're doing rubbing shoulders with that crowd, eating what is prohibited and ruining our good name?"
- 3 and said, "You went into the house of uncircumcised men and ate with them."
- 4 So Peter, starting from the beginning, laid it out for them step-by-step:
- 4 Peter began and explained everything to them precisely as it had happened:
- 5 "Recently I was in the town of Joppa praying. I fell into a trance and saw a vision: Something like a huge blanket, lowered by ropes at its four corners, came down out of heaven and settled on the ground in front of me.
- 5 I was in the city of Joppa praying, and in a trance I saw a vision. I saw something like a large sheet being let down from heaven by its four corners, and it came down to where I was.
- 6 Milling around on the blanket were farm animals, wild animals, reptiles, birds--you name it, it was there. Fascinated, I took it all in.
- 6 I looked into it and saw four-footed animals of the earth, wild beasts, reptiles, and birds of the air.
- 7 "Then I heard a voice: 'Go to it, Peter--kill and eat.'
- 7 Then I heard a voice telling me, 'Get up, Peter. Kill and eat.'
- 8 I said, 'Oh, no, Master. I've never so much as tasted food that wasn't kosher.'
- 8 I replied, 'Surely not, Lord! Nothing impure or unclean has ever entered my mouth.'
- 9 The voice spoke again: 'If God says it's okay, it's okay.'
- 9 The voice spoke from heaven a second time, 'Do not call anything impure that God has made clean.'
- 10 This happened three times, and then the blanket was pulled back up into the sky.
- 10 This happened three times, and then it was all pulled up to heaven again.
- 11 "Just then three men showed up at the house where I was staying, sent from Caesarea to get me.

- 11 Right then three men who had been sent to me from Caesarea stopped at the house where I was staying.
- 12 The Spirit told me to go with them, no questions asked. So I went with them, I and six friends, to the man who had sent for me.
- 12 The Spirit told me to have no hesitation about going with them. These six brothers also went with me, and we entered the man's house.
- 13 He told us how he had seen an angel right in his own house, real as his next-door neighbor, saying, 'Send to Joppa and get Simon, the one they call Peter.
- 13 He told us how he had seen an angel appear in his house and say, 'Send to Joppa for Simon who is called Peter.
- 14 He'll tell you something that will save your life--in fact, you and everyone you care for.'
- 14 He will bring you a message through which you and all your household will be saved.'
- 15 "So I started in, talking. Before I'd spoken half a dozen sentences, the Holy Spirit fell on them just as he did on us the first time.
- 15 As I began to speak, the Holy Spirit came on them as he had come on us at the beginning.
- 16 I remembered Jesus' words: 'John baptized with water; you will be baptized with the Holy Spirit.'
- 16 Then I remembered what the Lord had said: 'John baptized with water, but you will be baptized with the Holy Spirit.'
- 17 So I ask you: If God gave the same exact gift to them as to us when we believed in the Master Jesus Christ, how could I object to God?"
- 17 So if God gave them the same gift as he gave us, who believed in the Lord Jesus Christ, who was I to think that I could oppose God?"
- 18 Hearing it all laid out like that, they quieted down. And then, as it sank in, they started praising God. "It's really happened! God has broken through to the other nations, opened them up to Life!"
- 18 When they heard this, they had no further objections and praised God, saying, "So then, God has granted even the Gentiles repentance unto life."
- 19 Those who had been scattered by the persecution triggered by Stephen's death traveled as far as Phoenicia, Cyprus, and Antioch, but they were still only speaking and dealing with their fellow Jews.

- 19 Now those who had been scattered by the persecution in connection with Stephen traveled as far as Phoenicia, Cyprus and Antioch, telling the message only to Jews.
- 20 Then some of the men from Cyprus and Cyrene who had come to Antioch started talking to Greeks, giving them the Message of the Master Jesus.
- 20 Some of them, however, men from Cyprus and Cyrene, went to Antioch and began to speak to Greeks also, telling them the good news about the Lord Jesus.
- 21 God was pleased with what they were doing and put his stamp of approval on it--quite a number of the Greeks believed and turned to the Master.
- 21 The Lord's hand was with them, and a great number of people believed and turned to the Lord.
- 22 When the church in Jerusalem got wind of this, they sent Barnabas to Antioch to check on things.
- 22 News of this reached the ears of the church at Jerusalem, and they sent Barnabas to Antioch.
- 23 As soon as he arrived, he saw that God was behind and in it all. He threw himself in with them, got behind them, urging them to stay with it the rest of their lives.
- 23 When he arrived and saw the evidence of the grace of God, he was glad and encouraged them all to remain true to the Lord with all their hearts.
- 24 He was a good man that way, enthusiastic and confident in the Holy Spirit's ways. The community grew large and strong in the Master.
- 24 He was a good man, full of the Holy Spirit and faith, and a great number of people were brought to the Lord.
- 25 Then Barnabas went on to Tarsus to look for Saul.
- 25 Then Barnabas went to Tarsus to look for Saul,
- 26 He found him and brought him back to Antioch. They were there a whole year, meeting with the church and teaching a lot of people. It was in Antioch that the disciples were for the first time called Christians.
- 26 and when he found him, he brought him to Antioch. So for a whole year Barnabas and Saul met with the church and taught great numbers of people. The disciples were called Christians first at Antioch.

- 27 It was about this same time that some prophets came to Antioch from Jerusalem.
- 27 During this time some prophets came down from Jerusalem to Antioch.
- 28 One of them named Agabus stood up one day and, prompted by the Spirit, warned that a severe famine was about to devastate the country. (The famine eventually came during the rule of Claudius.)
- 28 One of them, named Agabus, stood up and through the Spirit predicted that a severe famine would spread over the entire Roman world. (This happened during the reign of Claudius.)
- 29 So the disciples decided that each of them would send whatever they could to their fellow Christians in Judea to help out.
- 29 The disciples, each according to his ability, decided to provide help for the brothers living in Judea.
- 30 They sent Barnabas and Saul to deliver the collection to the leaders in Jerusalem.
- 30 This they did, sending their gift to the elders by Barnabas and Saul.

Acts 12

MSG

NIV

- 1 That's when King Herod got it into his head to go after some of the church members.
- 1 It was about this time that King Herod arrested some who belonged to the church, intending to persecute them.
- 2 He murdered James, John's brother.
- 2 He had James, the brother of John, put to death with the sword.
- 3 When he saw how much it raised his popularity ratings with the Jews, he arrested Peter--all this during Passover Week, mind you--
- 3 When he saw that this pleased the Jews, he proceeded to seize Peter also. This happened during the Feast of Unleavened Bread.
- 4 and had him thrown in jail, putting four squads of four soldiers each to guard him. He was planning a public lynching after Passover.
- 4 After arresting him, he put him in prison, handing him over to be guarded by four squads of four soldiers each. Herod intended to bring him out for public trial after the Passover.

- 5 All the time that Peter was under heavy guard in the jailhouse, the church prayed for him most strenuously.
- 5 So Peter was kept in prison, but the church was earnestly praying to God for him.
- 6 Then the time came for Herod to bring him out for the kill. That night, even though shackled to two soldiers, one on either side, Peter slept like a baby. And there were guards at the door keeping their eyes on the place. Herod was taking no chances!
- 6 The night before Herod was to bring him to trial, Peter was sleeping between two soldiers, bound with two chains, and sentries stood guard at the entrance.
- 7 Suddenly there was an angel at his side and light flooding the room. The angel shook Peter and got him up: "Hurry!" The handcuffs fell off his wrists.
- 7 Suddenly an angel of the Lord appeared and a light shone in the cell. He struck Peter on the side and woke him up. "Quick, get up!" he said, and the chains fell off Peter's wrists.
- 8 The angel said, "Get dressed. Put on your shoes." Peter did it. Then, "Grab your coat and let's get out of here."
- 8 Then the angel said to him, "Put on your clothes and sandals." And Peter did so. "Wrap your cloak around you and follow me," the angel told him.
- 9 Peter followed him, but didn't believe it was really an angel--he thought he was dreaming.
- 9 Peter followed him out of the prison, but he had no idea that what the angel was doing was really happening; he thought he was seeing a vision.
- 10 Past the first guard and then the second, they came to the iron gate that led into the city. It swung open before them on its own, and they were out on the street, free as the breeze. At the first intersection the angel left him, going his own way.
- 10 They passed the first and second guards and came to the iron gate leading to the city. It opened for them by itself, and they went through it. When they had walked the length of one street, suddenly the angel left him.
- 11 That's when Peter realized it was no dream. "I can't believe it--this really happened! The Master sent his angel and rescued me from Herod's

vicious little production and the spectacle the Jewish mob was looking forward to."

11 Then Peter came to himself and said, "Now I know without a doubt that the Lord sent his angel and rescued me from Herod's clutches and from everything the Jewish people were anticipating."

12 Still shaking his head, amazed, he went to Mary's house, the Mary who was John Mark's mother. The house was packed with praying friends.

12 When this had dawned on him, he went to the house of Mary the mother of John, also called Mark, where many people had gathered and were praying.

13 When he knocked on the door to the courtyard, a young woman named Rhoda came to see who it was.

13 Peter knocked at the outer entrance, and a servant girl named Rhoda came to answer the door.

14 But when she recognized his voice--Peter's voice!--she was so excited and eager to tell everyone Peter was there that she forgot to open the door and left him standing in the street.

14 When she recognized Peter's voice, she was so overjoyed she ran back without opening it and exclaimed, "Peter is at the door!"

15 But they wouldn't believe her, dismissing her, dismissing her report. "You're crazy," they said. She stuck by her story, insisting. They still wouldn't believe her and said, "It must be his angel."

15 You're out of your mind, they told her. When she kept insisting that it was so, they said, "It must be his angel."

16 All this time poor Peter was standing out in the street, knocking away. Finally they opened up and saw him--and went wild!

16 But Peter kept on knocking, and when they opened the door and saw him, they were astonished.

17 Peter put his hands up and calmed them down. He described how the Master had gotten him out of jail, then said, "Tell James and the brothers what's happened." He left them and went off to another place.

17 Peter motioned with his hand for them to be quiet and described how the Lord had brought him out of prison. "Tell James and the brothers about this," he said, and then he left for another place.

18 At daybreak the jail was in an uproar. "Where is Peter? What's happened to Peter?"

- 18 In the morning, there was no small commotion among the soldiers as to what had become of Peter.
- 19 When Herod sent for him and they could neither produce him nor explain why not, he ordered their execution: "Off with their heads!" Fed up with Judea and Jews, he went for a vacation to Caesarea.
- 19 After Herod had a thorough search made for him and did not find him, he cross-examined the guards and ordered that they be executed. Then Herod went from Judea to Caesarea and stayed there a while.
- 20 But things went from bad to worse for Herod. Now people from Tyre and Sidon put him on the warpath. But they got Blastus, King Herod's right-hand man, to put in a good word for them and got a delegation together to iron things out. Because they were dependent on Judea for food supplies, they couldn't afford to let this go on too long.
- 20 He had been quarreling with the people of Tyre and Sidon; they now joined together and sought an audience with him. Having secured the support of Blastus, a trusted personal servant of the king, they asked for peace, because they depended on the king's country for their food supply.
- 21 On the day set for their meeting, Herod, robed in pomposity, took his place on the throne and regaled them with a lot of hot air.
- 21 On the appointed day Herod, wearing his royal robes, sat on his throne and delivered a public address to the people.
- 22 The people played their part to the hilt and shouted flatteries: "The voice of God! The voice of God!"
- 22 They shouted, "This is the voice of a god, not of a man."
- 23 That was the last straw. God had had enough of Herod's arrogance and sent an angel to strike him down. Herod had given God no credit for anything. Down he went. Rotten to the core, a maggoty old man if there ever was one, he died.
- 23 Immediately, because Herod did not give praise to God, an angel of the Lord struck him down, and he was eaten by worms and died.
- 24 Meanwhile, the ministry of God's Word grew by leaps and bounds.
- 24 But the word of God continued to increase and spread.
- 25 Barnabas and Saul, once they had delivered the relief offering to the church in Jerusalem, went back to Antioch. This time they took John with them, the one they called Mark.

25 When Barnabas and Saul had finished their mission, they returned from Jerusalem, taking with them John, also called Mark.

Acts 13

MSG

NIV

- 1 The congregation in Antioch was blessed with a number of prophet-preachers and teachers: Barnabas, Simon, nicknamed Niger, Lucius the Cyrenian, Manaen, an advisor to the ruler Herod, Saul.
- 1 In the church at Antioch there were prophets and teachers: Barnabas, Simeon called Niger, Lucius of Cyrene, Manaen (who had been brought up with Herod the tetrarch) and Saul.
- 2 One day as they were worshiping God--they were also fasting as they waited for guidance--the Holy Spirit spoke: "Take Barnabas and Saul and commission them for the work I have called them to do."
- 2 While they were worshiping the Lord and fasting, the Holy Spirit said, "Set apart for me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them."
- 3 So they commissioned them. In that circle of intensity and obedience, of fasting and praying, they laid hands on their heads and sent them off.
- 3 So after they had fasted and prayed, they placed their hands on them and sent them off.
- 4 Sent off on their new assignment by the Holy Spirit, Barnabas and Saul went down to Seleucia and caught a ship for Cyprus.
- 4 The two of them, sent on their way by the Holy Spirit, went down to Seleucia and sailed from there to Cyprus.
- 5 The first thing they did when they put in at Salamis was preach God's Word in the Jewish meeting places. They had John along to help out as needed.
- 5 When they arrived at Salamis, they proclaimed the word of God in the Jewish synagogues. John was with them as their helper.
- 6 They traveled the length of the island, and at Paphos came upon a Jewish wizard
- 6 They traveled through the whole island until they came to Paphos. There they met a Jewish sorcerer and false prophet named Bar-Jesus,

- 7 who had worked himself into the confidence of the governor, Sergius Paulus, an intelligent man not easily taken in by charlatans. The wizard's name was Bar-Jesus. He was as crooked as a corkscrew. The governor invited Barnabas and Saul in, wanting to hear God's Word firsthand from them.
- 7 who was an attendant of the proconsul, Sergius Paulus. The proconsul, an intelligent man, sent for Barnabas and Saul because he wanted to hear the word of God.
- 8 But Dr. Know-It-All (that's the wizard's name in plain English) stirred up a ruckus, trying to divert the governor from becoming a believer.
- 8 But Elymas the sorcerer (for that is what his name means) opposed them and tried to turn the proconsul from the faith.
- 9 But Saul (or Paul), full of the Holy Spirit and looking him straight in the eye, said,
- 9 Then Saul, who was also called Paul, filled with the Holy Spirit, looked straight at Elymas and said,
- 10 "You bag of wind, you parody of a devil--why, you stay up nights inventing schemes to cheat people out of God.
- 10 You are a child of the devil and an enemy of everything that is right! You are full of all kinds of deceit and trickery. Will you never stop perverting the right ways of the Lord?
- 11 But now you've come up against God himself, and your game is up. You're about to go blind--no sunlight for you for a good long stretch." He was plunged immediately into a shadowy mist and stumbled around, begging people to take his hand and show him the way.
- 11 Now the hand of the Lord is against you. You are going to be blind, and for a time you will be unable to see the light of the sun." Immediately mist and darkness came over him, and he groped about, seeking someone to lead him by the hand.
- 12 When the governor saw what happened, he became a believer, full of enthusiasm over what they were saying about the Master.
- 12 When the proconsul saw what had happened, he believed, for he was amazed at the teaching about the Lord.
- 13 From Paphos, Paul and company put out to sea, sailing on to Perga in Pamphylia. That's where John called it quits and went back to Jerusalem.

- 13 From Paphos, Paul and his companions sailed to Perga in Pamphylia, where John left them to return to Jerusalem.
- 14 From Perga the rest of them traveled on to Antioch in Pisidia. On the Sabbath they went to the meeting place and took their places.
- 14 From Perga they went on to Pisidian Antioch. On the Sabbath they entered the synagogue and sat down.
- 15 After the reading of the Scriptures--God's Law and the Prophets--the president of the meeting asked them, "Friends, do you have anything you want to say? A word of encouragement, perhaps?"
- 15 After the reading from the Law and the Prophets, the synagogue rulers sent word to them, saying, "Brothers, if you have a message of encouragement for the people, please speak."
- 16 Paul stood up, paused and took a deep breath, then said, "Fellow Israelites and friends of God, listen.
- 16 Standing up, Paul motioned with his hand and said: "Men of Israel and you Gentiles who worship God, listen to me!
- 17 God took a special interest in our ancestors, pulled our people who were beaten down in Egyptian exile to their feet, and led them out of there in grand style.
- 17 The God of the people of Israel chose our fathers; he made the people prosper during their stay in Egypt, with mighty power he led them out of that country,
- 18 He took good care of them for nearly forty years in that godforsaken wilderness
- 18 he endured their conduct for about forty years in the desert,
- 19 and then, having wiped out seven enemies who stood in the way, gave them the land of Canaan for their very own--
- 19 he overthrew seven nations in Canaan and gave their land to his people as their inheritance.
- 20 a span in all of about four hundred fifty years. "Up to the time of Samuel the prophet, God provided judges to lead them.
- 20 All this took about 450 years. "After this, God gave them judges until the time of Samuel the prophet.
- 21 But then they asked for a king, and God gave them Saul, son of Kish, out of the tribe of Benjamin. After Saul had ruled forty years,

- 21 Then the people asked for a king, and he gave them Saul son of Kish, of the tribe of Benjamin, who ruled forty years.
- 22 God removed him from office and put King David in his place, with this commendation: 'I've searched the land and found this David, son of Jesse. He's a man whose heart beats to my heart, a man who will do what I tell him.'
- 22 After removing Saul, he made David their king. He testified concerning him: 'I have found David son of Jesse a man after my own heart; he will do everything I want him to do.'
- 23 "From out of David's descendants God produced a Savior for Israel, Jesus, exactly as he promised--
- 23 From this man's descendants God has brought to Israel the Savior Jesus, as he promised.
- 24 but only after John had thoroughly alerted the people to his arrival by preparing them for a total life-change.
- 24 Before the coming of Jesus, John preached repentance and baptism to all the people of Israel.
- 25 As John was finishing up his work, he said, 'Did you think I was the One? No, I'm not the One. But the One you've been waiting for all these years is just around the corner, about to appear. And I'm about to disappear.'
- 25 As John was completing his work, he said: 'Who do you think I am? I am not that one. No, but he is coming after me, whose sandals I am not worthy to untie.'
- 26 "Dear brothers and sisters, children of Abraham, and friends of God, this message of salvation has been precisely targeted to you.
- 26 Brothers, children of Abraham, and you God-fearing Gentiles, it is to us that this message of salvation has been sent.
- 27 The citizens and rulers in Jerusalem didn't recognize who he was and condemned him to death.
- 27 The people of Jerusalem and their rulers did not recognize Jesus, yet in condemning him they fulfilled the words of the prophets that are read every Sabbath.
- 28 They couldn't find a good reason, but demanded that Pilate execute him anyway.

- 28 Though they found no proper ground for a death sentence, they asked Pilate to have him executed.
- 29 They did just what the prophets said they would do, but had no idea they were following to the letter the script of the prophets, even though those same prophets are read every Sabbath in their meeting places. "After they had done everything the prophets said they would do, they took him down from the cross and buried him.
- 29 When they had carried out all that was written about him, they took him down from the tree and laid him in a tomb.
- 30 And then God raised him from death.
- 30 But God raised him from the dead,
- 31 There is no disputing that--he appeared over and over again many times and places to those who had known him well in the Galilean years, and these same people continue to give witness that he is alive.
- 31 and for many days he was seen by those who had traveled with him from Galilee to Jerusalem. They are now his witnesses to our people.
- 32 "And we're here today bringing you good news: the Message that what God promised the fathers
- 32 We tell you the good news: What God promised our fathers
- 33 has come true for the children--for us! He raised Jesus, exactly as described in the second Psalm: My Son! My very own Son! Today I celebrate you!
- 33 he has fulfilled for us, their children, by raising up Jesus. As it is written in the second Psalm: " 'You are my Son; today I have become your Father. '
- 34 "When he raised him from the dead, he did it for good--no going back to that rot and decay for him. That's why Isaiah said, 'I'll give to all of you David's guaranteed blessings.'
- 34 The fact that God raised him from the dead, never to decay, is stated in these words: " 'I will give you the holy and sure blessings promised to David.'
- 35 So also the psalmist's prayer: 'You'll never let your Holy One see death's rot and decay.'
- 35 So it is stated elsewhere: " 'You will not let your Holy One see decay.'
- 36 "David, of course, having completed the work God set out for him, has been in the grave, dust and ashes, a long time now.

36 For when David had served God's purpose in his own generation, he fell asleep; he was buried with his fathers and his body decayed.

37 But the One God raised up--no dust and ashes for him!

37 But the one whom God raised from the dead did not see decay.

38 I want you to know, my very dear friends, that it is on account of this resurrected Jesus that the forgiveness of your sins can be promised.

38 Therefore, my brothers, I want you to know that through Jesus the forgiveness of sins is proclaimed to you.

39 He accomplishes, in those who believe, everything that the Law of Moses could never make good on. But everyone who believes in this raised-up Jesus is declared good and right and whole before God.

39 Through him everyone who believes is justified from everything you could not be justified from by the law of Moses.

40 "Don't take this lightly. You don't want the prophet's sermon to describe you:

40 Take care that what the prophets have said does not happen to you:

41 Watch out, cynics; Look hard--watch your world fall to pieces. I'm doing something right before your eyes That you won't believe, though it's staring you in the face."

41 'Look, you scoffers, wonder and perish, for I am going to do something in your days that you would never believe, even if someone told you.'

42 When the service was over, Paul and Barnabas were invited back to preach again the next Sabbath.

42 As Paul and Barnabas were leaving the synagogue, the people invited them to speak further about these things on the next Sabbath.

43 As the meeting broke up, a good many Jews and converts to Judaism went along with Paul and Barnabas, who urged them in long conversations to stick with what they'd started, this living in and by God's grace.

43 When the congregation was dismissed, many of the Jews and devout converts to Judaism followed Paul and Barnabas, who talked with them and urged them to continue in the grace of God.

44 When the next Sabbath came around, practically the whole city showed up to hear the Word of God.

44 On the next Sabbath almost the whole city gathered to hear the word of the Lord.

45 Some of the Jews, seeing the crowds, went wild with jealousy and tore into Paul, contradicting everything he was saying, making an ugly scene.

45 When the Jews saw the crowds, they were filled with jealousy and talked abusively against what Paul was saying.

46 But Paul and Barnabas didn't back down. Standing their ground they said, "It was required that God's Word be spoken first of all to you, the Jews. But seeing that you want no part of it--you've made it quite clear that you have no taste or inclination for eternal life--the door is open to all the outsiders. And we're on our way through it,

46 Then Paul and Barnabas answered them boldly: "We had to speak the word of God to you first. Since you reject it and do not consider yourselves worthy of eternal life, we now turn to the Gentiles.

47 following orders, doing what God commanded when he said, I've set you up as light to all nations. You'll proclaim salvation to the four winds and seven seas!"

47 For this is what the Lord has commanded us: " 'I have made you a light for the Gentiles, that you may bring salvation to the ends of the earth.' "

48 When the non-Jewish outsiders heard this, they could hardly believe their good fortune. All who were marked out for real life put their trust in God--they honored God's Word by receiving that life.

48 When the Gentiles heard this, they were glad and honored the word of the Lord; and all who were appointed for eternal life believed.

49 And this Message of salvation spread like wildfire all through the region.

49 The word of the Lord spread through the whole region.

50 Some of the Jews convinced the most respected women and leading men of the town that their precious way of life was about to be destroyed. Alarmed, they turned on Paul and Barnabas and forced them to leave.

50 But the Jews incited the God-fearing women of high standing and the leading men of the city. They stirred up persecution against Paul and Barnabas, and expelled them from their region.

51 Paul and Barnabas shrugged their shoulders and went on to the next town, Iconium,

51 So they shook the dust from their feet in protest against them and went to Iconium.

52 brimming with joy and the Holy Spirit, two happy disciples.
52 And the disciples were filled with joy and with the Holy Spirit.

Acts 14

MSG

NIV

- 1 When they got to Iconium they went, as they always did, to the meeting place of the Jews and gave their message. The Message convinced both Jews and non-Jews--and not just a few, either.
- 1 At Iconium Paul and Barnabas went as usual into the Jewish synagogue. There they spoke so effectively that a great number of Jews and Gentiles believed.
- 2 But the unbelieving Jews worked up a whispering campaign against Paul and Barnabas, sowing mistrust and suspicion in the minds of the people in the street.
- 2 But the Jews who refused to believe stirred up the Gentiles and poisoned their minds against the brothers.
- 3 The two apostles were there a long time, speaking freely, openly, and confidently as they presented the clear evidence of God's gifts, God corroborating their work with miracles and wonders.
- 3 So Paul and Barnabas spent considerable time there, speaking boldly for the Lord, who confirmed the message of his grace by enabling them to do miraculous signs and wonders.
- 4 But then there was a split in public opinion, some siding with the Jews, some with the apostles.
- 4 The people of the city were divided; some sided with the Jews, others with the apostles.
- 5 One day, learning that both the Jews and non-Jews had been organized by their leaders to beat them up,
- 5 There was a plot afoot among the Gentiles and Jews, together with their leaders, to mistreat them and stone them.
- 6 they escaped as best they could to the next towns--Lyconia, Lystra, Derbe, and that neighborhood--
- 6 But they found out about it and fled to the Lycaonian cities of Lystra and Derbe and to the surrounding country,

- 7 but then were right back at it again, getting out the Message.
- 7 where they continued to preach the good news.
- 8 There was a man in Lystra who couldn't walk. He sat there, crippled since the day of his birth.
- 8 In Lystra there sat a man crippled in his feet, who was lame from birth and had never walked.
- 9 He heard Paul talking, and Paul, looking him in the eye, saw that he was ripe for God's work, ready to believe.
- 9 He listened to Paul as he was speaking. Paul looked directly at him, saw that he had faith to be healed
- 10 So he said, loud enough for everyone to hear, "Up on your feet!" The man was up in a flash--jumped up and walked around as if he'd been walking all his life.
- 10 and called out, "Stand up on your feet!" At that, the man jumped up and began to walk.
- 11 When the crowd saw what Paul had done, they went wild, calling out in their Lyconian dialect, "The gods have come down! These men are gods!"
- 11 When the crowd saw what Paul had done, they shouted in the Lycaonian language, "The gods have come down to us in human form!"
- 12 They called Barnabas "Zeus" and Paul "Hermes" (since Paul did most of the speaking).
- 12 Barnabas they called Zeus, and Paul they called Hermes because he was the chief speaker.
- 13 The priest of the local Zeus shrine got up a parade--bulls and banners and people lined right up to the gates, ready for the ritual of sacrifice.
- 13 The priest of Zeus, whose temple was just outside the city, brought bulls and wreaths to the city gates because he and the crowd wanted to offer sacrifices to them.
- 14 When Barnabas and Paul finally realized what was going on, they stopped them. Waving their arms, they interrupted the parade, calling out,
- 14 But when the apostles Barnabas and Paul heard of this, they tore their clothes and rushed out into the crowd, shouting:
- 15 "What do you think you're doing! We're not gods! We are men just like you, and we're here to bring you the Message, to persuade you to

abandon these silly god-superstitions and embrace God himself, the living God. We don't make God; he makes us, and all of this--sky, earth, sea, and everything in them.

15 Men, why are you doing this? We too are only men, human like you. We are bringing you good news, telling you to turn from these worthless things to the living God, who made heaven and earth and sea and everything in them.

16 "In the generations before us, God let all the different nations go their own way.

16 In the past, he let all nations go their own way.

17 But even then he didn't leave them without a clue, for he made a good creation, poured down rain and gave bumper crops. When your bellies were full and your hearts happy, there was evidence of good beyond your doing."

17 Yet he has not left himself without testimony: He has shown kindness by giving you rain from heaven and crops in their seasons; he provides you with plenty of food and fills your hearts with joy."

18 Talking fast and hard like this, they prevented them from carrying out the sacrifice that would have honored them as gods--but just barely.

18 Even with these words, they had difficulty keeping the crowd from sacrificing to them.

19 Then some Jews from Antioch and Iconium caught up with them and turned the fickle crowd against them. They beat Paul unconscious, dragged him outside the town and left him for dead.

19 Then some Jews came from Antioch and Iconium and won the crowd over. They stoned Paul and dragged him outside the city, thinking he was dead.

20 But as the disciples gathered around him, he came to and got up. He went back into town and the next day left with Barnabas for Derbe.

20 But after the disciples had gathered around him, he got up and went back into the city. The next day he and Barnabas left for Derbe.

21 After proclaiming the Message in Derbe and establishing a strong core of disciples, they retraced their steps to Lystra, then Iconium, and then Antioch,

21 They preached the good news in that city and won a large number of disciples. Then they returned to Lystra, Iconium and Antioch,

- 22 putting muscle and sinew in the lives of the disciples, urging them to stick with what they had begun to believe and not quit, making it clear to them that it wouldn't be easy: "Anyone signing up for the kingdom of God has to go through plenty of hard times."
- 22 strengthening the disciples and encouraging them to remain true to the faith. "We must go through many hardships to enter the kingdom of God," they said.
- 23 Paul and Barnabas handpicked leaders in each church. After praying--their prayers intensified by fasting--they presented these new leaders to the Master to whom they had entrusted their lives.
- 23 Paul and Barnabas appointed elders for them in each church and, with prayer and fasting, committed them to the Lord, in whom they had put their trust.
- 24 Working their way back through Pisidia, they came to Pamphylia
- 24 After going through Pisidia, they came into Pamphylia,
- 25 and preached in Perga. Finally, they made it to Attalia
- 25 and when they had preached the word in Perga, they went down to Attalia.
- 26 and caught a ship back to Antioch, where it had all started--launched by God's grace and now safely home by God's grace. A good piece of work.
- 26 From Attalia they sailed back to Antioch, where they had been committed to the grace of God for the work they had now completed.
- 27 On arrival, they got the church together and reported on their trip, telling in detail how God had used them to throw the door of faith wide open so people of all nations could come streaming in.
- 27 On arriving there, they gathered the church together and reported all that God had done through them and how he had opened the door of faith to the Gentiles.
- 28 Then they settled down for a long, leisurely visit with the disciples.
- 28 And they stayed there a long time with the disciples.

Acts 15

MSG

NIV

- 1 It wasn't long before some Jews showed up from Judea insisting that everyone be circumcised: "If you're not circumcised in the Mosaic fashion, you can't be saved."
- 1 Some men came down from Judea to Antioch and were teaching the brothers: "Unless you are circumcised, according to the custom taught by Moses, you cannot be saved."
- 2 Paul and Barnabas were up on their feet at once in fierce protest. The church decided to resolve the matter by sending Paul, Barnabas, and a few others to put it before the apostles and leaders in Jerusalem.
- 2 This brought Paul and Barnabas into sharp dispute and debate with them. So Paul and Barnabas were appointed, along with some other believers, to go up to Jerusalem to see the apostles and elders about this question.
- 3 After they were sent off and on their way, they told everyone they met as they traveled through Phoenicia and Samaria about the breakthrough to the Gentile outsiders. Everyone who heard the news cheered--it was terrific news!
- 3 The church sent them on their way, and as they traveled through Phoenicia and Samaria, they told how the Gentiles had been converted. This news made all the brothers very glad.
- 4 When they got to Jerusalem, Paul and Barnabas were graciously received by the whole church, including the apostles and leaders. They reported on their recent journey and how God had used them to open things up to the outsiders.
- 4 When they came to Jerusalem, they were welcomed by the church and the apostles and elders, to whom they reported everything God had done through them.
- 5 Some Pharisees stood up to say their piece. They had become believers, but continued to hold to the hard party line of the Pharisees. "You have to circumcise the pagan converts," they said. "You must make them keep the Law of Moses."

- 5 Then some of the believers who belonged to the party of the Pharisees stood up and said, "The Gentiles must be circumcised and required to obey the law of Moses."
- 6 The apostles and leaders called a special meeting to consider the matter.
- 6 The apostles and elders met to consider this question.
- 7 The arguments went on and on, back and forth, getting more and more heated. Then Peter took the floor: "Friends, you well know that from early on God made it quite plain that he wanted the pagans to hear the Message of this good news and embrace it--and not in any secondhand or roundabout way, but firsthand, straight from my mouth.
- 7 After much discussion, Peter got up and addressed them: "Brothers, you know that some time ago God made a choice among you that the Gentiles might hear from my lips the message of the gospel and believe.
- 8 And God, who can't be fooled by any pretense on our part but always knows a person's thoughts, gave them the Holy Spirit exactly as he gave him to us.
- 8 God, who knows the heart, showed that he accepted them by giving the Holy Spirit to them, just as he did to us.
- 9 He treated the outsiders exactly as he treated us, beginning at the very center of who they were and working from that center outward, cleaning up their lives as they trusted and believed him.
- 9 He made no distinction between us and them, for he purified their hearts by faith.
- 10 "So why are you now trying to out-god God, loading these new believers down with rules that crushed our ancestors and crushed us, too?
- 10 Now then, why do you try to test God by putting on the necks of the disciples a yoke that neither we nor our fathers have been able to bear?
- 11 Don't we believe that we are saved because the Master Jesus amazingly and out of sheer generosity moved to save us just as he did those from beyond our nation? So what are we arguing about?"
- 11 No! We believe it is through the grace of our Lord Jesus that we are saved, just as they are."
- 12 There was dead silence. No one said a word. With the room quiet, Barnabas and Paul reported matter-of-factly on the miracles and wonders God had done among the other nations through their ministry.

- 12 The whole assembly became silent as they listened to Barnabas and Paul telling about the miraculous signs and wonders God had done among the Gentiles through them.
- 13 The silence deepened; you could hear a pin drop. James broke the silence. "Friends, listen.
- 13 When they finished, James spoke up: "Brothers, listen to me.
- 14 Simeon has told us the story of how God at the very outset made sure that racial outsiders were included.
- 14 Simon has described to us how God at first showed his concern by taking from the Gentiles a people for himself.
- 15 This is in perfect agreement with the words of the prophets:
- 15 The words of the prophets are in agreement with this, as it is written:
- 16 After this, I'm coming back; I'll rebuild David's ruined house; I'll put all the pieces together again; I'll make it look like new
- 16 'After this I will return and rebuild David's fallen tent. Its ruins I will rebuild, and I will restore it,
- 17 So outsiders who seek will find, so they'll have a place to come to, All the pagan peoples included in what I'm doing. "God said it and now he's doing it.
- 17 that the remnant of men may seek the Lord, and all the Gentiles who bear my name, says the Lord, who does these things'
- 18 It's no afterthought; he's always known he would do this.
- 18 that have been known for ages.
- 19 "So here is my decision: We're not going to unnecessarily burden non-Jewish people who turn to the Master.
- 19 It is my judgment, therefore, that we should not make it difficult for the Gentiles who are turning to God.
- 20 We'll write them a letter and tell them, 'Be careful to not get involved in activities connected with idols, to guard the morality of sex and marriage, to not serve food offensive to Jewish Christians--blood, for instance.'
- 20 Instead we should write to them, telling them to abstain from food polluted by idols, from sexual immorality, from the meat of strangled animals and from blood.
- 21 This is basic wisdom from Moses, preached and honored for centuries now in city after city as we have met and kept the Sabbath."

- 21 For Moses has been preached in every city from the earliest times and is read in the synagogues on every Sabbath."
- 22 Everyone agreed: apostles, leaders, all the people. They picked Judas (nicknamed Barsabbas) and Silas--they both carried considerable weight in the church--and sent them to Antioch with Paul and Barnabas
- 22 Then the apostles and elders, with the whole church, decided to choose some of their own men and send them to Antioch with Paul and Barnabas. They chose Judas (called Barsabbas) and Silas, two men who were leaders among the brothers.
- 23 with this letter: From the apostles and leaders, your friends, to our friends in Antioch, Syria, and Cilicia: Hello!
- 23 With them they sent the following letter: The apostles and elders, your brothers, To the Gentile believers in Antioch, Syria and Cilicia: Greetings.
- 24 We heard that some men from our church went to you and said things that confused and upset you. Mind you, they had no authority from us; we didn't send them.
- 24 We have heard that some went out from us without our authorization and disturbed you, troubling your minds by what they said.
- 25 We have agreed unanimously to pick representatives and send them to you with our good friends Barnabas and Paul.
- 25 So we all agreed to choose some men and send them to you with our dear friends Barnabas and Paul--
- 26 We picked men we knew you could trust, Judas and Silas--they've looked death in the face time and again for the sake of our Master Jesus Christ.
- 26 men who have risked their lives for the name of our Lord Jesus Christ.
- 27 We've sent them to confirm in a face-to-face meeting with you what we've written.
- 27 Therefore we are sending Judas and Silas to confirm by word of mouth what we are writing.
- 28 It seemed to the Holy Spirit and to us that you should not be saddled with any crushing burden, but be responsible only for these bare necessities:
- 28 It seemed good to the Holy Spirit and to us not to burden you with anything beyond the following requirements:

- 29 Be careful not to get involved in activities connected with idols; avoid serving food offensive to Jewish Christians (blood, for instance); and guard the morality of sex and marriage. These guidelines are sufficient to keep relations congenial between us. And God be with you!
- 29 You are to abstain from food sacrificed to idols, from blood, from the meat of strangled animals and from sexual immorality. You will do well to avoid these things. Farewell.
- 30 And so off they went to Antioch. On arrival, they gathered the church and read the letter.
- 30 The men were sent off and went down to Antioch, where they gathered the church together and delivered the letter.
- 31 The people were greatly relieved and pleased.
- 31 The people read it and were glad for its encouraging message.
- 32 Judas and Silas, good preachers both of them, strengthened their new friends with many words of courage and hope.
- 32 Judas and Silas, who themselves were prophets, said much to encourage and strengthen the brothers.
- 33 Then it was time to go home. They were sent off by their new friends with laughter and embraces all around to report back to those who had sent them.
- 33 After spending some time there, they were sent off by the brothers with the blessing of peace to return to those who had sent them.
- 34 (OMITTED TEXT)
- 35 Paul and Barnabas stayed on in Antioch, teaching and preaching the Word of God. But they weren't alone. There were a number of teachers and preachers at that time in Antioch.
- 35 But Paul and Barnabas remained in Antioch, where they and many others taught and preached the word of the Lord.
- 36 After a few days of this, Paul said to Barnabas, "Let's go back and visit all our friends in each of the towns where we preached the Word of God. Let's see how they're doing."
- 36 Some time later Paul said to Barnabas, "Let us go back and visit the brothers in all the towns where we preached the word of the Lord and see how they are doing."
- 37 Barnabas wanted to take John along, the John nicknamed Mark.

37 Barnabas wanted to take John, also called Mark, with them,
38 But Paul wouldn't have him; he wasn't about to take along a quitter who,
as soon as the going got tough, had jumped ship on them in Pamphylia.
38 but Paul did not think it wise to take him, because he had deserted them
in Pamphylia and had not continued with them in the work.
39 Tempers flared, and they ended up going their separate ways: Barnabas
took Mark and sailed for Cyprus;
39 They had such a sharp disagreement that they parted company.
Barnabas took Mark and sailed for Cyprus,
40 Paul chose Silas and, offered up by their friends to the grace of the
Master,
40 but Paul chose Silas and left, commended by the brothers to the grace of
the Lord.
41 went to Syria and Cilicia to build up muscle and sinew in those
congregations.
41 He went through Syria and Cilicia, strengthening the churches.

Acts 16

MSG

NIV

1 Paul came first to Derbe, then Lystra. He found a disciple there by the
name of Timothy, son of a devout Jewish mother and Greek father.
1 He came to Derbe and then to Lystra, where a disciple named Timothy
lived, whose mother was a Jewess and a believer, but whose father was a
Greek.
2 Friends in Lystra and Iconium all said what a fine young man he was.
2 The brothers at Lystra and Iconium spoke well of him.
3 Paul wanted to recruit him for their mission, but first took him aside and
circumcised him so he wouldn't offend the Jews who lived in those parts.
They all knew that his father was Greek.
3 Paul wanted to take him along on the journey, so he circumcised him
because of the Jews who lived in that area, for they all knew that his
father was a Greek.
4 As they traveled from town to town, they presented the simple guidelines
the Jerusalem apostles and leaders had come up with.

- 4 As they traveled from town to town, they delivered the decisions reached by the apostles and elders in Jerusalem for the people to obey.
- 5 That turned out to be most helpful. Day after day the congregations became stronger in faith and larger in size.
- 5 So the churches were strengthened in the faith and grew daily in numbers.
- 6 They went to Phrygia, and then on through the region of Galatia. Their plan was to turn west into Asia province, but the Holy Spirit blocked that route.
- 6 Paul and his companions traveled throughout the region of Phrygia and Galatia, having been kept by the Holy Spirit from preaching the word in the province of Asia.
- 7 So they went to Mysia and tried to go north to Bithynia, but the Spirit of Jesus wouldn't let them go there either.
- 7 When they came to the border of Mysia, they tried to enter Bithynia, but the Spirit of Jesus would not allow them to.
- 8 Proceeding on through Mysia, they went down to the seaport Troas.
- 8 So they passed by Mysia and went down to Troas.
- 9 That night Paul had a dream: A Macedonian stood on the far shore and called across the sea, "Come over to Macedonia and help us!"
- 9 During the night Paul had a vision of a man of Macedonia standing and begging him, "Come over to Macedonia and help us."
- 10 The dream gave Paul his map. We went to work at once getting things ready to cross over to Macedonia. All the pieces had come together. We knew now for sure that God had called us to preach the good news to the Europeans.
- 10 After Paul had seen the vision, we got ready at once to leave for Macedonia, concluding that God had called us to preach the gospel to them.
- 11 Putting out from the harbor at Troas, we made a straight run for Samothrace. The next day we tied up at New City
- 11 From Troas we put out to sea and sailed straight for Samothrace, and the next day on to Neapolis.
- 12 and walked from there to Philippi, the main city in that part of Macedonia and, even more importantly, a Roman colony. We lingered there several days.

- 12 From there we traveled to Philippi, a Roman colony and the leading city of that district of Macedonia. And we stayed there several days.
- 13 On the Sabbath, we left the city and went down along the river where we had heard there was to be a prayer meeting. We took our place with the women who had gathered there and talked with them.
- 13 On the Sabbath we went outside the city gate to the river, where we expected to find a place of prayer. We sat down and began to speak to the women who had gathered there.
- 14 One woman, Lydia, was from Thyatira and a dealer in expensive textiles, known to be a God-fearing woman. As she listened with intensity to what was being said, the Master gave her a trusting heart--and she believed!
- 14 One of those listening was a woman named Lydia, a dealer in purple cloth from the city of Thyatira, who was a worshiper of God. The Lord opened her heart to respond to Paul's message.
- 15 After she was baptized, along with everyone in her household, she said in a surge of hospitality, "If you're confident that I'm in this with you and believe in the Master truly, come home with me and be my guests." We hesitated, but she wouldn't take no for an answer.
- 15 When she and the members of her household were baptized, she invited us to her home. "If you consider me a believer in the Lord," she said, "come and stay at my house." And she persuaded us.
- 16 One day, on our way to the place of prayer, a slave girl ran into us. She was a psychic and, with her fortunetelling, made a lot of money for the people who owned her.
- 16 Once when we were going to the place of prayer, we were met by a slave girl who had a spirit by which she predicted the future. She earned a great deal of money for her owners by fortune- telling.
- 17 She started following Paul around, calling everyone's attention to us by yelling out, "These men are working for the Most High God. They're laying out the road of salvation for you!"
- 17 This girl followed Paul and the rest of us, shouting, "These men are servants of the Most High God, who are telling you the way to be saved."
- 18 She did this for a number of days until Paul, finally fed up with her, turned and commanded the spirit that possessed her, "Out! In the name

of Jesus Christ, get out of her!" And it was gone, just like that.

18 She kept this up for many days. Finally Paul became so troubled that he turned around and said to the spirit, "In the name of Jesus Christ I command you to come out of her!" At that moment the spirit left her.

19 When her owners saw that their lucrative little business was suddenly bankrupt, they went after Paul and Silas, roughed them up and dragged them into the market square. Then the police arrested them

19 When the owners of the slave girl realized that their hope of making money was gone, they seized Paul and Silas and dragged them into the marketplace to face the authorities.

20 and pulled them into a court with the accusation, "These men are disturbing the peace--dangerous Jewish agitators

20 They brought them before the magistrates and said, "These men are Jews, and are throwing our city into an uproar

21 subverting our Roman law and order."

21 by advocating customs unlawful for us Romans to accept or practice."

22 By this time the crowd had turned into a restless mob out for blood. The judges went along with the mob, had Paul and Silas's clothes ripped off and ordered a public beating.

22 The crowd joined in the attack against Paul and Silas, and the magistrates ordered them to be stripped and beaten.

23 After beating them black and blue, they threw them into jail, telling the jailkeeper to put them under heavy guard so there would be no chance of escape.

23 After they had been severely flogged, they were thrown into prison, and the jailer was commanded to guard them carefully.

24 He did just that--threw them into the maximum security cell in the jail and clamped leg irons on them.

24 Upon receiving such orders, he put them in the inner cell and fastened their feet in the stocks.

25 Along about midnight, Paul and Silas were at prayer and singing a robust hymn to God. The other prisoners couldn't believe their ears.

25 About midnight Paul and Silas were praying and singing hymns to God, and the other prisoners were listening to them.

26 Then, without warning, a huge earthquake! The jailhouse tottered, every door flew open, all the prisoners were loose.

- 26 Suddenly there was such a violent earthquake that the foundations of the prison were shaken. At once all the prison doors flew open, and everybody's chains came loose.
- 27 Startled from sleep, the jailer saw all the doors swinging loose on their hinges. Assuming that all the prisoners had escaped, he pulled out his sword and was about to do himself in, figuring he was as good as dead anyway,
- 27 The jailer woke up, and when he saw the prison doors open, he drew his sword and was about to kill himself because he thought the prisoners had escaped.
- 28 when Paul stopped him: "Don't do that! We're all still here! Nobody's run away!"
- 28 But Paul shouted, "Don't harm yourself! We are all here!"
- 29 The jailer got a torch and ran inside. Badly shaken, he collapsed in front of Paul and Silas.
- 29 The jailer called for lights, rushed in and fell trembling before Paul and Silas.
- 30 He led them out of the jail and asked, "Sirs, what do I have to do to be saved, to really live?"
- 30 He then brought them out and asked, "Sirs, what must I do to be saved?"
- 31 They said, "Put your entire trust in the Master Jesus. Then you'll live as you were meant to live--and everyone in your house included!"
- 31 They replied, "Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved--you and your household."
- 32 They went on to spell out in detail the story of the Master--the entire family got in on this part.
- 32 Then they spoke the word of the Lord to him and to all the others in his house.
- 33 They never did get to bed that night. The jailer made them feel at home, dressed their wounds, and then--he couldn't wait till morning!--was baptized, he and everyone in his family.
- 33 At that hour of the night the jailer took them and washed their wounds; then immediately he and all his family were baptized.
- 34 There in his home, he had food set out for a festive meal. It was a night to remember: He and his entire family had put their trust in God; everyone in the house was in on the celebration.

- 34 The jailer brought them into his house and set a meal before them; he was filled with joy because he had come to believe in God--he and his whole family.
- 35 At daybreak, the court judges sent officers with the instructions, "Release these men."
- 35 When it was daylight, the magistrates sent their officers to the jailer with the order: "Release those men."
- 36 The jailer gave Paul the message, "The judges sent word that you're free to go on your way. Congratulations! Go in peace!"
- 36 The jailer told Paul, "The magistrates have ordered that you and Silas be released. Now you can leave. Go in peace."
- 37 But Paul wouldn't budge. He told the officers, "They beat us up in public and threw us in jail, Roman citizens in good standing! And now they want to get us out of the way on the sly without anyone knowing? Nothing doing! If they want us out of here, let them come themselves and lead us out in broad daylight."
- 37 But Paul said to the officers: "They beat us publicly without a trial, even though we are Roman citizens, and threw us into prison. And now do they want to get rid of us quietly? No! Let them come themselves and escort us out."
- 38 When the officers reported this, the judges panicked. They had no idea that Paul and Silas were Roman citizens.
- 38 The officers reported this to the magistrates, and when they heard that Paul and Silas were Roman citizens, they were alarmed.
- 39 They hurried over and apologized, personally escorted them from the jail, and then asked them if they wouldn't please leave the city.
- 39 They came to appease them and escorted them from the prison, requesting them to leave the city.
- 40 Walking out of the jail, Paul and Silas went straight to Lydia's house, saw their friends again, encouraged them in the faith, and only then went on their way.
- 40 After Paul and Silas came out of the prison, they went to Lydia's house, where they met with the brothers and encouraged them. Then they left.

Acts 17

MSG

NIV

- 1 They took the road south through Amphipolis and Apollonia to Thessalonica, where there was a community of Jews.
- 1 When they had passed through Amphipolis and Apollonia, they came to Thessalonica, where there was a Jewish synagogue.
- 2 Paul went to their meeting place, as he usually did when he came to a town, and for three Sabbaths running he preached to them from the Scriptures.
- 2 As his custom was, Paul went into the synagogue, and on three Sabbath days he reasoned with them from the Scriptures,
- 3 He opened up the texts so they understood what they'd been reading all their lives: that the Messiah absolutely had to be put to death and raised from the dead--there were no other options--and that "this Jesus I'm introducing you to is that Messiah."
- 3 explaining and proving that the Christ had to suffer and rise from the dead. "This Jesus I am proclaiming to you is the Christ, " he said.
- 4 Some of them were won over and joined ranks with Paul and Silas, among them a great many God-fearing Greeks and a considerable number of women from the aristocracy.
- 4 Some of the Jews were persuaded and joined Paul and Silas, as did a large number of God- fearing Greeks and not a few prominent women.
- 5 But the hard-line Jews became furious over the conversions. Mad with jealousy, they rounded up a bunch of brawlers off the streets and soon had an ugly mob terrorizing the city as they hunted down Paul and Silas. They broke into Jason's house, thinking that Paul and Silas were there.
- 5 But the Jews were jealous; so they rounded up some bad characters from the marketplace, formed a mob and started a riot in the city. They rushed to Jason's house in search of Paul and Silas in order to bring them out to the crowd.
- 6 When they couldn't find them, they collared Jason and his friends instead and dragged them before the city fathers, yelling hysterically, "These people are out to destroy the world, and now they've shown up on our doorstep, attacking everything we hold dear!
- 6 But when they did not find them, they dragged Jason and some other brothers before the city officials, shouting: "These men who have caused

- trouble all over the world have now come here,
- 7 And Jason is hiding them, these traitors and turncoats who say Jesus is king and Caesar is nothing!"
- 7 and Jason has welcomed them into his house. They are all defying Caesar's decrees, saying that there is another king, one called Jesus."
- 8 The city fathers and the crowd of people were totally alarmed by what they heard.
- 8 When they heard this, the crowd and the city officials were thrown into turmoil.
- 9 They made Jason and his friends post heavy bail and let them go while they investigated the charges.
- 9 Then they made Jason and the others post bond and let them go.
- 10 That night, under cover of darkness, their friends got Paul and Silas out of town as fast as they could. They sent them to Berea, where they again met with the Jewish community.
- 10 As soon as it was night, the brothers sent Paul and Silas away to Berea. On arriving there, they went to the Jewish synagogue.
- 11 They were treated a lot better there than in Thessalonica. The Jews received Paul's message with enthusiasm and met with him daily, examining the Scriptures to see if they supported what he said.
- 11 Now the Bereans were of more noble character than the Thessalonians, for they received the message with great eagerness and examined the Scriptures every day to see if what Paul said was true.
- 12 A lot of them became believers, including many Greeks who were prominent in the community, women and men of influence.
- 12 Many of the Jews believed, as did also a number of prominent Greek women and many Greek men.
- 13 But it wasn't long before reports got back to the Thessalonian hard-line Jews that Paul was at it again, preaching the Word of God, this time in Berea. They lost no time responding, and created a mob scene there, too.
- 13 When the Jews in Thessalonica learned that Paul was preaching the word of God at Berea, they went there too, agitating the crowds and stirring them up.
- 14 With the help of his friends, Paul gave them the slip--caught a boat and put out to sea. Silas and Timothy stayed behind.

- 14 The brothers immediately sent Paul to the coast, but Silas and Timothy stayed at Berea.
- 15 The men who helped Paul escape got him as far as Athens and left him there. Paul sent word back with them to Silas and Timothy: "Come as quickly as you can!"
- 15 The men who escorted Paul brought him to Athens and then left with instructions for Silas and Timothy to join him as soon as possible.
- 16 The longer Paul waited in Athens for Silas and Timothy, the angrier he got--all those idols! The city was a junkyard of idols.
- 16 While Paul was waiting for them in Athens, he was greatly distressed to see that the city was full of idols.
- 17 He discussed it with the Jews and other like-minded people at their meeting place. And every day he went out on the streets and talked with anyone who happened along.
- 17 So he reasoned in the synagogue with the Jews and the God-fearing Greeks, as well as in the marketplace day by day with those who happened to be there.
- 18 He got to know some of the Epicurean and Stoic intellectuals pretty well through these conversations. Some of them dismissed him with sarcasm: "What an airhead!" But others, listening to him go on about Jesus and the resurrection, were intrigued: "That's a new slant on the gods. Tell us more."
- 18 A group of Epicurean and Stoic philosophers began to dispute with him. Some of them asked, "What is this babbler trying to say?" Others remarked, "He seems to be advocating foreign gods." They said this because Paul was preaching the good news about Jesus and the resurrection.
- 19 These people got together and asked him to make a public presentation over at the Areopagus, where things were a little quieter. They said, "This is a new one on us. We've never heard anything quite like it. Where did you come up with this anyway?"
- 19 Then they took him and brought him to a meeting of the Areopagus, where they said to him, "May we know what this new teaching is that you are presenting?"
- 20 Explain it so we can understand."

- 20 You are bringing some strange ideas to our ears, and we want to know what they mean."
- 21 Downtown Athens was a great place for gossip. There were always people hanging around, natives and tourists alike, waiting for the latest tidbit on most anything.
- 21 (All the Athenians and the foreigners who lived there spent their time doing nothing but talking about and listening to the latest ideas.)
- 22 So Paul took his stand in the open space at the Areopagus and laid it out for them. "It is plain to see that you Athenians take your religion seriously.
- 22 Paul then stood up in the meeting of the Areopagus and said: "Men of Athens! I see that in every way you are very religious.
- 23 When I arrived here the other day, I was fascinated with all the shrines I came across. And then I found one inscribed, TO THE GOD NOBODY KNOWS. I'm here to introduce you to this God so you can worship intelligently, know who you're dealing with.
- 23 For as I walked around and looked carefully at your objects of worship, I even found an altar with this inscription: TO AN UNKNOWN GOD. Now what you worship as something unknown I am going to proclaim to you.
- 24 "The God who made the world and everything in it, this Master of sky and land, doesn't live in custom-made shrines
- 24 The God who made the world and everything in it is the Lord of heaven and earth and does not live in temples built by hands.
- 25 or need the human race to run errands for him, as if he couldn't take care of himself. He makes the creatures; the creatures don't make him.
- 25 And he is not served by human hands, as if he needed anything, because he himself gives all men life and breath and everything else.
- 26 Starting from scratch, he made the entire human race and made the earth hospitable, with plenty of time and space for living
- 26 From one man he made every nation of men, that they should inhabit the whole earth; and he determined the times set for them and the exact places where they should live.
- 27 so we could seek after God, and not just grope around in the dark but actually find him. He doesn't play hide-and-seek with us. He's not remote; he's near.

- 27 God did this so that men would seek him and perhaps reach out for him and find him, though he is not far from each one of us.
- 28 We live and move in him, can't get away from him! One of your poets said it well: 'We're the God-created.'
- 28 'For in him we live and move and have our being.' As some of your own poets have said, 'We are his offspring.'
- 29 Well, if we are the God-created, it doesn't make a lot of sense to think we could hire a sculptor to chisel a god out of stone for us, does it?
- 29 Therefore since we are God's offspring, we should not think that the divine being is like gold or silver or stone--an image made by man's design and skill.
- 30 "God overlooks it as long as you don't know any better--but that time is past. The unknown is now known, and he's calling for a radical life-change.
- 30 In the past God overlooked such ignorance, but now he commands all people everywhere to repent.
- 31 He has set a day when the entire human race will be judged and everything set right. And he has already appointed the judge, confirming him before everyone by raising him from the dead."
- 31 For he has set a day when he will judge the world with justice by the man he has appointed. He has given proof of this to all men by raising him from the dead."
- 32 At the phrase "raising him from the dead," the listeners split: Some laughed at him and walked off making jokes; others said, "Let's do this again. We want to hear more."
- 32 When they heard about the resurrection of the dead, some of them sneered, but others said, "We want to hear you again on this subject."
- 33 But that was it for the day, and Paul left.
- 33 At that, Paul left the Council.
- 34 There were still others, it turned out, who were convinced then and there, and stuck with Paul--among them Dionysius the Areopagite and a woman named Damaris.
- 34 A few men became followers of Paul and believed. Among them was Dionysius, a member of the Areopagus, also a woman named Damaris, and a number of others.

Acts 18

MSG

NIV

- 1 After Athens, Paul went to Corinth.
- 1 After this, Paul left Athens and went to Corinth.
- 2 That is where he discovered Aquila, a Jew born in Pontus, and his wife, Priscilla. They had just arrived from Italy, part of the general expulsion of Jews from Rome ordered by Claudius.
- 2 There he met a Jew named Aquila, a native of Pontus, who had recently come from Italy with his wife Priscilla, because Claudius had ordered all the Jews to leave Rome. Paul went to see them,
- 3 Paul moved in with them, and they worked together at their common trade of tentmaking.
- 3 and because he was a tentmaker as they were, he stayed and worked with them.
- 4 But every Sabbath he was at the meeting place, doing his best to convince both Jews and Greeks about Jesus.
- 4 Every Sabbath he reasoned in the synagogue, trying to persuade Jews and Greeks.
- 5 When Silas and Timothy arrived from Macedonia, Paul was able to give all his time to preaching and teaching, doing everything he could to persuade the Jews that Jesus was in fact God's Messiah.
- 5 When Silas and Timothy came from Macedonia, Paul devoted himself exclusively to preaching, testifying to the Jews that Jesus was the Christ.
- 6 But no such luck. All they did was argue contentiously and contradict him at every turn. Totally exasperated, Paul had finally had it with them and gave it up as a bad job. "Have it your way, then," he said. "You've made your bed; now lie in it. From now on I'm spending my time with the other nations."
- 6 But when the Jews opposed Paul and became abusive, he shook out his clothes in protest and said to them, "Your blood be on your own heads! I am clear of my responsibility. From now on I will go to the Gentiles."
- 7 He walked out and went to the home of Titius Justus, a God-fearing man who lived right next to the Jews' meeting place.

- 7 Then Paul left the synagogue and went next door to the house of Titius Justus, a worshiper of God.
- 8 But Paul's efforts with the Jews weren't a total loss, for Crispus, the meeting-place president, put his trust in the Master. His entire family believed with him. In the course of listening to Paul, a great many Corinthians believed and were baptized.
- 8 Crispus, the synagogue ruler, and his entire household believed in the Lord; and many of the Corinthians who heard him believed and were baptized.
- 9 One night the Master spoke to Paul in a dream: "Keep it up, and don't let anyone intimidate or silence you.
- 9 One night the Lord spoke to Paul in a vision: "Do not be afraid; keep on speaking, do not be silent.
- 10 No matter what happens, I'm with you and no one is going to be able to hurt you. You have no idea how many people I have on my side in this city."
- 10 For I am with you, and no one is going to attack and harm you, because I have many people in this city."
- 11 That was all he needed to stick it out. He stayed another year and a half, faithfully teaching the Word of God to the Corinthians.
- 11 So Paul stayed for a year and a half, teaching them the word of God.
- 12 But when Gallio was governor of Achaia province, the Jews got up a campaign against Paul, hauled him into court,
- 12 While Gallio was proconsul of Achaia, the Jews made a united attack on Paul and brought him into court.
- 13 and filed charges: "This man is seducing people into acts of worship that are illegal."
- 13 This man, they charged, "is persuading the people to worship God in ways contrary to the law."
- 14 Just as Paul was about to defend himself, Gallio interrupted and said to the Jews, "If this was a matter of criminal conduct, I would gladly hear you out.
- 14 Just as Paul was about to speak, Gallio said to the Jews, "If you Jews were making a complaint about some misdemeanor or serious crime, it would be reasonable for me to listen to you.

- 15 But it sounds to me like one more Jewish squabble, another of your endless hairsplitting quarrels over religion. Take care of it on your own time. I can't be bothered with this nonsense,"
- 15 But since it involves questions about words and names and your own law--settle the matter yourselves. I will not be a judge of such things."
- 16 and he cleared them out of the courtroom.
- 16 So he had them ejected from the court.
- 17 Now the street rabble turned on Sosthenes, the new meeting-place president, and beat him up in plain sight of the court. Gallio didn't raise a finger. He could not have cared less.
- 17 Then they all turned on Sosthenes the synagogue ruler and beat him in front of the court. But Gallio showed no concern whatever.
- 18 Paul stayed a while longer in Corinth, but then it was time to take leave of his friends. Saying his good-byes, he sailed for Syria, Priscilla and Aquila with him. Before boarding the ship in the harbor town of Cenchrea, he had his head shaved as part of a vow he had taken.
- 18 Paul stayed on in Corinth for some time. Then he left the brothers and sailed for Syria, accompanied by Priscilla and Aquila. Before he sailed, he had his hair cut off at Cenchrea because of a vow he had taken.
- 19 They landed in Ephesus, where Priscilla and Aquila got off and stayed. Paul left the ship briefly to go to the meeting place and preach to the Jews.
- 19 They arrived at Ephesus, where Paul left Priscilla and Aquila. He himself went into the synagogue and reasoned with the Jews.
- 20 They wanted him to stay longer, but he said he couldn't.
- 20 When they asked him to spend more time with them, he declined.
- 21 But after saying good-bye, he promised, "I'll be back, God willing."
From Ephesus
- 21 But as he left, he promised, "I will come back if it is God's will." Then he set sail from Ephesus.
- 22 he sailed to Caesarea. He greeted the assembly of Christians there, and then went on to Antioch, completing the journey.
- 22 When he landed at Caesarea, he went up and greeted the church and then went down to Antioch.
- 23 After spending a considerable time with the Antioch Christians, Paul set off again for Galatia and Phrygia, retracing his old tracks, one town after

another, putting fresh heart into the disciples.

23 After spending some time in Antioch, Paul set out from there and traveled from place to place throughout the region of Galatia and Phrygia, strengthening all the disciples.

24 A man named Apollos came to Ephesus. He was a Jew, born in Alexandria, Egypt, and a terrific speaker, eloquent and powerful in his preaching of the Scriptures.

24 Meanwhile a Jew named Apollos, a native of Alexandria, came to Ephesus. He was a learned man, with a thorough knowledge of the Scriptures.

25 He was well-educated in the way of the Master and fiery in his enthusiasm. Apollos was accurate in everything he taught about Jesus up to a point, but he only went as far as the baptism of John.

25 He had been instructed in the way of the Lord, and he spoke with great fervor and taught about Jesus accurately, though he knew only the baptism of John.

26 He preached with power in the meeting place. When Priscilla and Aquila heard him, they took him aside and told him the rest of the story.

26 He began to speak boldly in the synagogue. When Priscilla and Aquila heard him, they invited him to their home and explained to him the way of God more adequately.

27 When Apollos decided to go on to Achaia province, his Ephesian friends gave their blessing and wrote a letter of recommendation for him, urging the disciples there to welcome him with open arms. The welcome paid off: Apollos turned out to be a great help to those who had become believers through God's immense generosity.

27 When Apollos wanted to go to Achaia, the brothers encouraged him and wrote to the disciples there to welcome him. On arriving, he was a great help to those who by grace had believed.

28 He was particularly effective in public debate with the Jews as he brought out proof after convincing proof from the Scriptures that Jesus was in fact God's Messiah.

28 For he vigorously refuted the Jews in public debate, proving from the Scriptures that Jesus was the Christ.

Acts 19

MSG

NIV

- 1 Now, it happened that while Apollos was away in Corinth, Paul made his way down through the mountains, came to Ephesus, and happened on some disciples there.
- 1 While Apollos was at Corinth, Paul took the road through the interior and arrived at Ephesus. There he found some disciples
- 2 The first thing he said was, "Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed? Did you take God into your mind only, or did you also embrace him with your heart? Did he get inside you?" "We've never even heard of that--a Holy Spirit? God within us?"
- 2 and asked them, "Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed?" They answered, "No, we have not even heard that there is a Holy Spirit."
- 3 "How were you baptized, then?" asked Paul. "In John's baptism."
- 3 So Paul asked, "Then what baptism did you receive?" "John's baptism," they replied.
- 4 "That explains it," said Paul. "John preached a baptism of radical life-change so that people would be ready to receive the One coming after him, who turned out to be Jesus. If you've been baptized in John's baptism, you're ready now for the real thing, for Jesus."
- 4 Paul said, "John's baptism was a baptism of repentance. He told the people to believe in the one coming after him, that is, in Jesus."
- 5 And they were. As soon as they heard of it, they were baptized in the name of the Master Jesus.
- 5 On hearing this, they were baptized into the name of the Lord Jesus.
- 6 Paul put his hands on their heads and the Holy Spirit entered them. From that moment on, they were praising God in tongues and talking about God's actions.
- 6 When Paul placed his hands on them, the Holy Spirit came on them, and they spoke in tongues and prophesied.
- 7 Altogether there were about twelve people there that day.
- 7 There were about twelve men in all.
- 8 Paul then went straight to the meeting place. He had the run of the place for three months, doing his best to make the things of the kingdom of

God real and convincing to them.

- 8 Paul entered the synagogue and spoke boldly there for three months, arguing persuasively about the kingdom of God.
- 9 But then resistance began to form as some of them began spreading evil rumors through the congregation about the Christian way of life. So Paul left, taking the disciples with him, and set up shop in the school of Tyrannus, holding class there daily.
- 9 But some of them became obstinate; they refused to believe and publicly maligned the Way. So Paul left them. He took the disciples with him and had discussions daily in the lecture hall of Tyrannus.
- 10 He did this for two years, giving everyone in the province of Asia, Jews as well as Greeks, ample opportunity to hear the Message of the Master.
- 10 This went on for two years, so that all the Jews and Greeks who lived in the province of Asia heard the word of the Lord.
- 11 God did powerful things through Paul, things quite out of the ordinary.
- 11 God did extraordinary miracles through Paul,
- 12 The word got around and people started taking pieces of clothing--handkerchiefs and scarves and the like--that had touched Paul's skin and then touching the sick with them. The touch did it--they were healed and whole.
- 12 so that even handkerchiefs and aprons that had touched him were taken to the sick, and their illnesses were cured and the evil spirits left them.
- 13 Some itinerant Jewish exorcists who happened to be in town at the time tried their hand at what they assumed to be Paul's "game." They pronounced the name of the Master Jesus over victims of evil spirits, saying, "I command you by the Jesus preached by Paul!"
- 13 Some Jews who went around driving out evil spirits tried to invoke the name of the Lord Jesus over those who were demon- possessed. They would say, "In the name of Jesus, whom Paul preaches, I command you to come out."
- 14 The seven sons of a certain Sceva, a Jewish high priest, were trying to do this on a man
- 14 Seven sons of Sceva, a Jewish chief priest, were doing this.
- 15 when the evil spirit talked back: "I know Jesus and I've heard of Paul, but who are you?"

- 15 One day the evil spirit answered them, "Jesus I know, and I know about Paul, but who are you?"
- 16 Then the possessed man went berserk--jumped the exorcists, beat them up, and tore off their clothes. Naked and bloody, they got away as best they could.
- 16 Then the man who had the evil spirit jumped on them and overpowered them all. He gave them such a beating that they ran out of the house naked and bleeding.
- 17 It was soon news all over Ephesus among both Jews and Greeks. The realization spread that God was in and behind this. Curiosity about Paul developed into reverence for the Master Jesus.
- 17 When this became known to the Jews and Greeks living in Ephesus, they were all seized with fear, and the name of the Lord Jesus was held in high honor.
- 18 Many of those who thus believed came out of the closet and made a clean break with their secret sorceries.
- 18 Many of those who believed now came and openly confessed their evil deeds.
- 19 All kinds of witches and warlocks came out of the woodwork with their books of spells and incantations and made a huge bonfire of them. Someone estimated their worth at fifty thousand silver coins.
- 19 A number who had practiced sorcery brought their scrolls together and burned them publicly. When they calculated the value of the scrolls, the total came to fifty thousand drachmas.
- 20 In such ways it became evident that the Word of the Master was now sovereign and prevailed in Ephesus.
- 20 In this way the word of the Lord spread widely and grew in power.
- 21 After all this had come to a head, Paul decided it was time to move on to Macedonia and Achaia provinces, and from there to Jerusalem. "Then," he said, "I'm off to Rome. I've got to see Rome!"
- 21 After all this had happened, Paul decided to go to Jerusalem, passing through Macedonia and Achaia. "After I have been there," he said, "I must visit Rome also."
- 22 He sent two of his assistants, Timothy and Erastus, on to Macedonia while he stayed for a while and wrapped things up in Asia.

- 22 He sent two of his helpers, Timothy and Erastus, to Macedonia, while he stayed in the province of Asia a little longer.
- 23 But before he got away, a huge ruckus occurred over what was now being referred to as "the Way."
- 23 About that time there arose a great disturbance about the Way.
- 24 A certain silversmith, Demetrius, conducted a brisk trade in the manufacture of shrines to the goddess Artemis, employing a number of artisans in his business.
- 24 A silversmith named Demetrius, who made silver shrines of Artemis, brought in no little business for the craftsmen.
- 25 He rounded up his workers and others similarly employed and said, "Men, you well know that we have a good thing going here--
- 25 He called them together, along with the workmen in related trades, and said: "Men, you know we receive a good income from this business.
- 26 and you've seen how Paul has barged in and discredited what we're doing by telling people that there's no such thing as a god made with hands. A lot of people are going along with him, not only here in Ephesus but all through Asia province.
- 26 And you see and hear how this fellow Paul has convinced and led astray large numbers of people here in Ephesus and in practically the whole province of Asia. He says that man-made gods are no gods at all.
- 27 "Not only is our little business in danger of falling apart, but the temple of our famous goddess Artemis will certainly end up a pile of rubble as her glorious reputation fades to nothing. And this is no mere local matter--the whole world worships our Artemis!"
- 27 There is danger not only that our trade will lose its good name, but also that the temple of the great goddess Artemis will be discredited, and the goddess herself, who is worshiped throughout the province of Asia and the world, will be robbed of her divine majesty."
- 28 That set them off in a frenzy. They ran into the street yelling, "Great Artemis of the Ephesians!
- 28 When they heard this, they were furious and began shouting: "Great is Artemis of the Ephesians!"
- 29 Great Artemis of the Ephesians!" They put the whole city in an uproar, stampeding into the stadium, and grabbing two of Paul's associates on the way, the Macedonians Gaius and Aristarchus.

- 29 Soon the whole city was in an uproar. The people seized Gaius and Aristarchus, Paul's traveling companions from Macedonia, and rushed as one man into the theater.
- 30 Paul wanted to go in, too, but the disciples wouldn't let him.
- 30 Paul wanted to appear before the crowd, but the disciples would not let him.
- 31 Prominent religious leaders in the city who had become friendly to Paul concurred: "By no means go near that mob!"
- 31 Even some of the officials of the province, friends of Paul, sent him a message begging him not to venture into the theater.
- 32 Some were yelling one thing, some another. Most of them had no idea what was going on or why they were there.
- 32 The assembly was in confusion: Some were shouting one thing, some another. Most of the people did not even know why they were there.
- 33 As the Jews pushed Alexander to the front to try to gain control, different factions clamored to get him on their side. But he brushed them off and quieted the mob with an impressive sweep of his arms.
- 33 The Jews pushed Alexander to the front, and some of the crowd shouted instructions to him. He motioned for silence in order to make a defense before the people.
- 34 But the moment he opened his mouth and they knew he was a Jew, they shouted him down: "Great Artemis of the Ephesians! Great Artemis of the Ephesians!"--on and on and on, for over two hours.
- 34 But when they realized he was a Jew, they all shouted in unison for about two hours: "Great is Artemis of the Ephesians!"
- 35 Finally, the town clerk got the mob quieted down and said, "Fellow citizens, is there anyone anywhere who doesn't know that our dear city Ephesus is protector of glorious Artemis and her sacred stone image that fell straight out of heaven?"
- 35 The city clerk quieted the crowd and said: "Men of Ephesus, doesn't all the world know that the city of Ephesus is the guardian of the temple of the great Artemis and of her image, which fell from heaven?"
- 36 Since this is beyond contradiction, you had better get hold of yourselves. This is conduct unworthy of Artemis.
- 36 Therefore, since these facts are undeniable, you ought to be quiet and not do anything rash.

- 37 These men you've dragged in here have done nothing to harm either our temple or our goddess.
- 37 You have brought these men here, though they have neither robbed temples nor blasphemed our goddess.
- 38 "So if Demetrius and his guild of artisans have a complaint, they can take it to court and make all the accusations they want.
- 38 If, then, Demetrius and his fellow craftsmen have a grievance against anybody, the courts are open and there are proconsuls. They can press charges.
- 39 If anything else is bothering you, bring it to the regularly scheduled town meeting and let it be settled there.
- 39 If there is anything further you want to bring up, it must be settled in a legal assembly.
- 40 There is no excuse for what's happened today. We're putting our city in serious danger. Rome, remember, does not look kindly on rioters."
- 40 As it is, we are in danger of being charged with rioting because of today's events. In that case we would not be able to account for this commotion, since there is no reason for it."
- 41 With that, he sent them home.
- 41 After he had said this, he dismissed the assembly.

Acts 20

MSG

NIV

- 1 With things back to normal, Paul called the disciples together and encouraged them to keep up the good work in Ephesus. Then, saying his good-byes, he left for Macedonia.
- 1 When the uproar had ended, Paul sent for the disciples and, after encouraging them, said good-by and set out for Macedonia.
- 2 Traveling through the country, passing from one gathering to another, he gave constant encouragement, lifting their spirits and charging them with fresh hope. Then he came to Greece
- 2 He traveled through that area, speaking many words of encouragement to the people, and finally arrived in Greece,

- 3 and stayed on for three months. Just as he was about to sail for Syria, the Jews cooked up a plot against him. So he went the other way, by land back through Macedonia, and gave them the slip.
- 3 where he stayed three months. Because the Jews made a plot against him just as he was about to sail for Syria, he decided to go back through Macedonia.
- 4 His companions for the journey were Sopater, son of Pyrrhus, from Berea; Aristarchus and Secundus, both Thessalonians; Gaius from Derbe; Timothy; and the two from western Asia, Tychicus and Trophimus.
- 4 He was accompanied by Sopater son of Pyrrhus from Berea, Aristarchus and Secundus from Thessalonica, Gaius from Derbe, Timothy also, and Tychicus and Trophimus from the province of Asia.
- 5 They went on ahead and waited for us in Troas.
- 5 These men went on ahead and waited for us at Troas.
- 6 Meanwhile, we stayed in Philippi for Passover Week, and then set sail. Within five days we were again in Troas and stayed a week.
- 6 But we sailed from Philippi after the Feast of Unleavened Bread, and five days later joined the others at Troas, where we stayed seven days.
- 7 We met on Sunday to worship and celebrate the Master's Supper. Paul addressed the congregation. Our plan was to leave first thing in the morning, but Paul talked on, way past midnight.
- 7 On the first day of the week we came together to break bread. Paul spoke to the people and, because he intended to leave the next day, kept on talking until midnight.
- 8 We were meeting in a well-lighted upper room.
- 8 There were many lamps in the upstairs room where we were meeting.
- 9 A young man named Eutychus was sitting in an open window. As Paul went on and on, Eutychus fell sound asleep and toppled out the third-story window. When they picked him up, he was dead.
- 9 Seated in a window was a young man named Eutychus, who was sinking into a deep sleep as Paul talked on and on. When he was sound asleep, he fell to the ground from the third story and was picked up dead.
- 10 Paul went down, stretched himself on him, and hugged him hard. "No more crying," he said. "There's life in him yet."

- 10 Paul went down, threw himself on the young man and put his arms around him. "Don't be alarmed," he said. "He's alive!"
- 11 Then Paul got up and served the Master's Supper. And went on telling stories of the faith until dawn! On that note, they left--Paul going one way,
- 11 Then he went upstairs again and broke bread and ate. After talking until daylight, he left.
- 12 the congregation another, leading the boy off alive, and full of life themselves.
- 12 The people took the young man home alive and were greatly comforted.
- 13 In the meantime, the rest of us had gone on ahead to the ship and sailed for Assos, where we planned to pick up Paul. Paul wanted to walk there, and so had made these arrangements earlier.
- 13 We went on ahead to the ship and sailed for Assos, where we were going to take Paul aboard. He had made this arrangement because he was going there on foot.
- 14 Things went according to plan: We met him in Assos, took him on board, and sailed to Mitylene.
- 14 When he met us at Assos, we took him aboard and went on to Mitylene.
- 15 The next day we put in opposite Chios, Samos a day later, and then Miletus.
- 15 The next day we set sail from there and arrived off Kios. The day after that we crossed over to Samos, and on the following day arrived at Miletus.
- 16 Paul had decided to bypass Ephesus so that he wouldn't be held up in Asia province. He was in a hurry to get to Jerusalem in time for the Feast of Pentecost, if at all possible.
- 16 Paul had decided to sail past Ephesus to avoid spending time in the province of Asia, for he was in a hurry to reach Jerusalem, if possible, by the day of Pentecost.
- 17 From Miletus he sent to Ephesus for the leaders of the congregation.
- 17 From Miletus, Paul sent to Ephesus for the elders of the church.
- 18 When they arrived, he said, "You know that from day one of my arrival in Asia I was with you totally--
- 18 When they arrived, he said to them: "You know how I lived the whole time I was with you, from the first day I came into the province of Asia.

19 laying my life on the line, serving the Master no matter what, putting up with no end of scheming by Jews who wanted to do me in.

19 I served the Lord with great humility and with tears, although I was severely tested by the plots of the Jews.

20 I didn't skimp or trim in any way. Every truth and encouragement that could have made a difference to you, you got. I taught you out in public and I taught you in your homes,

20 You know that I have not hesitated to preach anything that would be helpful to you but have taught you publicly and from house to house.

21 urging Jews and Greeks alike to a radical life-change before God and an equally radical trust in our Master Jesus.

21 I have declared to both Jews and Greeks that they must turn to God in repentance and have faith in our Lord Jesus.

22 "But there is another urgency before me now. I feel compelled to go to Jerusalem. I'm completely in the dark about what will happen when I get there.

22 And now, compelled by the Spirit, I am going to Jerusalem, not knowing what will happen to me there.

23 I do know that it won't be any picnic, for the Holy Spirit has let me know repeatedly and clearly that there are hard times and imprisonment ahead.

23 I only know that in every city the Holy Spirit warns me that prison and hardships are facing me.

24 But that matters little. What matters most to me is to finish what God started: the job the Master Jesus gave me of letting everyone I meet know all about this incredibly extravagant generosity of God.

24 However, I consider my life worth nothing to me, if only I may finish the race and complete the task the Lord Jesus has given me--the task of testifying to the gospel of God's grace.

25 "And so this is good-bye. You're not going to see me again, nor I you, you whom I have gone among for so long proclaiming the news of God's inaugurated kingdom.

25 Now I know that none of you among whom I have gone about preaching the kingdom will ever see me again.

26 I've done my best for you, given you my all,

26 Therefore, I declare to you today that I am innocent of the blood of all men.

27 held back nothing of God's will for you.

27 For I have not hesitated to proclaim to you the whole will of God.

28 "Now it's up to you. Be on your toes--both for yourselves and your congregation of sheep. The Holy Spirit has put you in charge of these people--God's people they are--to guard and protect them. God himself thought they were worth dying for.

28 Keep watch over yourselves and all the flock of which the Holy Spirit has made you overseers. Be shepherds of the church of God, which he bought with his own blood.

29 "I know that as soon as I'm gone, vicious wolves are going to show up and rip into this flock, men

29 I know that after I leave, savage wolves will come in among you and will not spare the flock.

30 from your very own ranks twisting words so as to seduce disciples into following them instead of Jesus.

30 Even from your own number men will arise and distort the truth in order to draw away disciples after them.

31 So stay awake and keep up your guard. Remember those three years I kept at it with you, never letting up, pouring my heart out with you, one after another.

31 So be on your guard! Remember that for three years I never stopped warning each of you night and day with tears.

32 "Now I'm turning you over to God, our marvelous God whose gracious Word can make you into what he wants you to be and give you everything you could possibly need in this community of holy friends.

32 Now I commit you to God and to the word of his grace, which can build you up and give you an inheritance among all those who are sanctified.

33 "I've never, as you so well know, had any taste for wealth or fashion.

33 I have not coveted anyone's silver or gold or clothing.

34 With these bare hands I took care of my own basic needs and those who worked with me.

34 You yourselves know that these hands of mine have supplied my own needs and the needs of my companions.

- 35 In everything I've done, I have demonstrated to you how necessary it is to work on behalf of the weak and not exploit them. You'll not likely go wrong here if you keep remembering that our Master said, 'You're far happier giving than getting.'"
- 35 In everything I did, I showed you that by this kind of hard work we must help the weak, remembering the words the Lord Jesus himself said: 'It is more blessed to give than to receive.' "
- 36 Then Paul went down on his knees, all of them kneeling with him, and prayed.
- 36 When he had said this, he knelt down with all of them and prayed.
- 37 And then a river of tears. Much clinging to Paul, not wanting to let him go.
- 37 They all wept as they embraced him and kissed him.
- 38 They knew they would never see him again--he had told them quite plainly. The pain cut deep. Then, bravely, they walked him down to the ship.
- 38 What grieved them most was his statement that they would never see his face again. Then they accompanied him to the ship.

Acts 21

MSG

NIV

- 1 And so, with the tearful good-byes behind us, we were on our way. We made a straight run to Cos, the next day reached Rhodes, and then Patara.
- 1 After we had torn ourselves away from them, we put out to sea and sailed straight to Cos. The next day we went to Rhodes and from there to Patara.
- 2 There we found a ship going direct to Phoenicia, got on board, and set sail.
- 2 We found a ship crossing over to Phoenicia, went on board and set sail.
- 3 Cyprus came into view on our left, but was soon out of sight as we kept on course for Syria, and eventually docked in the port of Tyre. While the cargo was being unloaded,

- 3 After sighting Cyprus and passing to the south of it, we sailed on to Syria. We landed at Tyre, where our ship was to unload its cargo.
- 4 we looked up the local disciples and stayed with them seven days. Their message to Paul, from insight given by the Spirit, was "Don't go to Jerusalem."
- 4 Finding the disciples there, we stayed with them seven days. Through the Spirit they urged Paul not to go on to Jerusalem.
- 5 When our time was up, they escorted us out of the city to the docks. Everyone came along--men, women, children. They made a farewell party of the occasion! We all knelt together on the beach and prayed.
- 5 But when our time was up, we left and continued on our way. All the disciples and their wives and children accompanied us out of the city, and there on the beach we knelt to pray.
- 6 Then, after another round of saying good-bye, we climbed on board the ship while they drifted back to their homes.
- 6 After saying good-bye to each other, we went aboard the ship, and they returned home.
- 7 A short run from Tyre to Ptolemais completed the voyage. We greeted our Christian friends there and stayed with them a day.
- 7 We continued our voyage from Tyre and landed at Ptolemais, where we greeted the brothers and stayed with them for a day.
- 8 In the morning we went on to Caesarea and stayed with Philip the Evangelist, one of "the Seven."
- 8 Leaving the next day, we reached Caesarea and stayed at the house of Philip the evangelist, one of the Seven.
- 9 Philip had four virgin daughters who prophesied.
- 9 He had four unmarried daughters who prophesied.
- 10 After several days of visiting, a prophet from Judea by the name of Agabus came down to see us.
- 10 After we had been there a number of days, a prophet named Agabus came down from Judea.
- 11 He went right up to Paul, took Paul's belt, and, in a dramatic gesture, tied himself up, hands and feet. He said, "This is what the Holy Spirit says: The Jews in Jerusalem are going to tie up the man who owns this belt just like this and hand him over to godless unbelievers."

- 11 Coming over to us, he took Paul's belt, tied his own hands and feet with it and said, "The Holy Spirit says, 'In this way the Jews of Jerusalem will bind the owner of this belt and will hand him over to the Gentiles.' "
- 12 When we heard that, we and everyone there that day begged Paul not to be stubborn and persist in going to Jerusalem.
- 12 When we heard this, we and the people there pleaded with Paul not to go up to Jerusalem.
- 13 But Paul wouldn't budge: "Why all this hysteria? Why do you insist on making a scene and making it even harder for me? You're looking at this backwards. The issue in Jerusalem is not what they do to me, whether arrest or murder, but what the Master Jesus does through my obedience. Can't you see that?"
- 13 Then Paul answered, "Why are you weeping and breaking my heart? I am ready not only to be bound, but also to die in Jerusalem for the name of the Lord Jesus."
- 14 We saw that we weren't making even a dent in his resolve, and gave up. "It's in God's hands now," we said. "Master, you handle it."
- 14 When he would not be dissuaded, we gave up and said, "The Lord's will be done."
- 15 It wasn't long before we had our luggage together and were on our way to Jerusalem.
- 15 After this, we got ready and went up to Jerusalem.
- 16 Some of the disciples from Caesarea went with us and took us to the home of Mnason, who received us warmly as his guests. A native of Cyprus, he had been among the earliest disciples.
- 16 Some of the disciples from Caesarea accompanied us and brought us to the home of Mnason, where we were to stay. He was a man from Cyprus and one of the early disciples.
- 17 In Jerusalem, our friends, glad to see us, received us with open arms.
- 17 When we arrived at Jerusalem, the brothers received us warmly.
- 18 The first thing next morning, we took Paul to see James. All the church leaders were there.
- 18 The next day Paul and the rest of us went to see James, and all the elders were present.
- 19 After a time of greeting and small talk, Paul told the story, detail by detail, of what God had done among the Gentiles through his ministry.

- 19 Paul greeted them and reported in detail what God had done among the Gentiles through his ministry.
- 20 They listened with delight and gave God the glory. They had a story to tell, too: "And just look at what's been happening here--thousands upon thousands of God-fearing Jews have become believers in Jesus! But there's also a problem because they are more zealous than ever in observing the laws of Moses.
- 20 When they heard this, they praised God. Then they said to Paul: "You see, brother, how many thousands of Jews have believed, and all of them are zealous for the law.
- 21 They've been told that you advise believing Jews who live surrounded by Gentiles to go light on Moses, telling them that they don't need to circumcise their children or keep up the old traditions. This isn't sitting at all well with them.
- 21 They have been informed that you teach all the Jews who live among the Gentiles to turn away from Moses, telling them not to circumcise their children or live according to our customs.
- 22 "We're worried about what will happen when they discover you're in town. There's bound to be trouble. So here is what we want you to do:
- 22 What shall we do? They will certainly hear that you have come,
- 23 There are four men from our company who have taken a vow involving ritual purification, but have no money to pay the expenses.
- 23 so do what we tell you. There are four men with us who have made a vow.
- 24 Join these men in their vows and pay their expenses. Then it will become obvious to everyone that there is nothing to the rumors going around about you and that you are in fact scrupulous in your reverence for the laws of Moses.
- 24 Take these men, join in their purification rites and pay their expenses, so that they can have their heads shaved. Then everybody will know there is no truth in these reports about you, but that you yourself are living in obedience to the law.
- 25 "In asking you to do this, we're not going back on our agreement regarding Gentiles who have become believers. We continue to hold fast to what we wrote in that letter, namely, to be careful not to get involved

- in activities connected with idols; to avoid serving food offensive to Jewish Christians; to guard the morality of sex and marriage."
- 25 As for the Gentile believers, we have written to them our decision that they should abstain from food sacrificed to idols, from blood, from the meat of strangled animals and from sexual immorality."
- 26 So Paul did it--took the men, joined them in their vows, and paid their way. The next day he went to the Temple to make it official and stay there until the proper sacrifices had been offered and completed for each of them.
- 26 The next day Paul took the men and purified himself along with them. Then he went to the temple to give notice of the date when the days of purification would end and the offering would be made for each of them.
- 27 When the seven days of their purification were nearly up, some Jews from around Ephesus spotted him in the Temple. At once they turned the place upside-down. They grabbed Paul
- 27 When the seven days were nearly over, some Jews from the province of Asia saw Paul at the temple. They stirred up the whole crowd and seized him,
- 28 and started yelling at the top of their lungs, "Help! You Israelites, help! This is the man who is going all over the world telling lies against us and our religion and this place. He's even brought Greeks in here and defiled this holy place."
- 28 shouting, "Men of Israel, help us! This is the man who teaches all men everywhere against our people and our law and this place. And besides, he has brought Greeks into the temple area and defiled this holy place."
- 29 (What had happened was that they had seen Paul and Trophimus, the Ephesian Greek, walking together in the city and had just assumed that he had also taken him to the Temple and shown him around.)
- 29 (They had previously seen Trophimus the Ephesian in the city with Paul and assumed that Paul had brought him into the temple area.)
- 30 Soon the whole city was in an uproar, people running from everywhere to the Temple to get in on the action. They grabbed Paul, dragged him outside, and locked the Temple gates so he couldn't get back in and gain sanctuary.
- 30 The whole city was aroused, and the people came running from all directions. Seizing Paul, they dragged him from the temple, and

- immediately the gates were shut.
- 31 As they were trying to kill him, word came to the captain of the guard, "A riot! The whole city's boiling over!"
- 31 While they were trying to kill him, news reached the commander of the Roman troops that the whole city of Jerusalem was in an uproar.
- 32 He acted swiftly. His soldiers and centurions ran to the scene at once. As soon as the mob saw the captain and his soldiers, they quit beating Paul.
- 32 He at once took some officers and soldiers and ran down to the crowd. When the rioters saw the commander and his soldiers, they stopped beating Paul.
- 33 The captain came up and put Paul under arrest. He first ordered him handcuffed, and then asked who he was and what he had done.
- 33 The commander came up and arrested him and ordered him to be bound with two chains. Then he asked who he was and what he had done.
- 34 All he got from the crowd were shouts, one yelling this, another that. It was impossible to tell one word from another in the mob hysteria, so the captain ordered Paul taken to the military barracks.
- 34 Some in the crowd shouted one thing and some another, and since the commander could not get at the truth because of the uproar, he ordered that Paul be taken into the barracks.
- 35 But when they got to the Temple steps, the mob became so violent that the soldiers had to carry Paul.
- 35 When Paul reached the steps, the violence of the mob was so great he had to be carried by the soldiers.
- 36 As they carried him away, the crowd followed, shouting, "Kill him! Kill him!"
- 36 The crowd that followed kept shouting, "Away with him!"
- 37 When they got to the barracks and were about to go in, Paul said to the captain, "Can I say something to you?" He answered, "Oh, I didn't know you spoke Greek."
- 37 As the soldiers were about to take Paul into the barracks, he asked the commander, "May I say something to you?" "Do you speak Greek?" he replied.
- 38 I thought you were the Egyptian who not long ago started a riot here, and then hid out in the desert with his four thousand thugs."

- 38 Aren't you the Egyptian who started a revolt and led four thousand terrorists out into the desert some time ago?
- 39 Paul said, "No, I'm a Jew, born in Tarsus. And I'm a citizen still of that influential city. I have a simple request: Let me speak to the crowd."
- 39 Paul answered, "I am a Jew, from Tarsus in Cilicia, a citizen of no ordinary city. Please let me speak to the people."
- 40 Standing on the barracks steps, Paul turned and held his arms up. A hush fell over the crowd as Paul began to speak. He spoke in Hebrew.
- 40 Having received the commander's permission, Paul stood on the steps and motioned to the crowd. When they were all silent, he said to them in Aramaic:

Acts 22

MSG

NIV

- 1 "My dear brothers and fathers, listen carefully to what I have to say before you jump to conclusions about me."
- 1 Brothers and fathers, listen now to my defense.
- 2 When they heard him speaking Hebrew, they grew even quieter. No one wanted to miss a word of this. He continued,
- 2 When they heard him speak to them in Aramaic, they became very quiet. Then Paul said:
- 3 "I am a good Jew, born in Tarsus in the province of Cilicia, but educated here in Jerusalem under the exacting eye of Rabbi Gamaliel, thoroughly instructed in our religious traditions. And I've always been passionately on God's side, just as you are right now.
- 3 I am a Jew, born in Tarsus of Cilicia, but brought up in this city. Under Gamaliel I was thoroughly trained in the law of our fathers and was just as zealous for God as any of you are today.
- 4 "I went after anyone connected with this 'Way,' went at them hammer and tongs, ready to kill for God. I rounded up men and women right and left and had them thrown in prison.
- 4 I persecuted the followers of this Way to their death, arresting both men and women and throwing them into prison,

- 5 You can ask the Chief Priest or anyone in the High Council to verify this; they all knew me well. Then I went off to our brothers in Damascus, armed with official documents authorizing me to hunt down the Christians there, arrest them, and bring them back to Jerusalem for sentencing.
- 5 as also the high priest and all the Council can testify. I even obtained letters from them to their brothers in Damascus, and went there to bring these people as prisoners to Jerusalem to be punished.
- 6 "As I arrived on the outskirts of Damascus about noon, a blinding light blazed out of the skies
- 6 About noon as I came near Damascus, suddenly a bright light from heaven flashed around me.
- 7 and I fell to the ground, dazed. I heard a voice: 'Saul, Saul, why are you out to get me?'
- 7 I fell to the ground and heard a voice say to me, 'Saul! Saul! Why do you persecute me?'
- 8 "'Who are you, Master?' I asked. "He said, 'I am Jesus the Nazarene, the One you're hunting down.'
- 8 'Who are you, Lord?' I asked. 'I am Jesus of Nazareth, whom you are persecuting,' he replied.
- 9 My companions saw the light, but they didn't hear the conversation.
- 9 My companions saw the light, but they did not understand the voice of him who was speaking to me.
- 10 "Then I said, 'What do I do now, Master?' "He said, 'Get to your feet and enter Damascus. There you'll be told everything that's been set out for you to do.'
- 10 'What shall I do, Lord?' I asked. 'Get up,' the Lord said, 'and go into Damascus. There you will be told all that you have been assigned to do.'
- 11 And so we entered Damascus, but nothing like the entrance I had planned--I was blind as a bat and my companions had to lead me in by the hand.
- 11 My companions led me by the hand into Damascus, because the brilliance of the light had blinded me.
- 12 "And that's when I met Ananias, a man with a sterling reputation in observing our laws--the Jewish community in Damascus is unanimous on that score.

- 12 A man named Ananias came to see me. He was a devout observer of the law and highly respected by all the Jews living there.
- 13 He came and put his arm on my shoulder. 'Look up,' he said. I looked, and found myself looking right into his eyes--I could see again!
- 13 He stood beside me and said, 'Brother Saul, receive your sight!' And at that very moment I was able to see him.
- 14 "Then he said, 'The God of our ancestors has handpicked you to be briefed on his plan of action. You've actually seen the Righteous Innocent and heard him speak.
- 14 Then he said: 'The God of our fathers has chosen you to know his will and to see the Righteous One and to hear words from his mouth.
- 15 You are to be a key witness to everyone you meet of what you've seen and heard.
- 15 You will be his witness to all men of what you have seen and heard.
- 16 So what are you waiting for? Get up and get yourself baptized, scrubbed clean of those sins and personally acquainted with God.'
- 16 And now what are you waiting for? Get up, be baptized and wash your sins away, calling on his name.'
- 17 "Well, it happened just as Ananias said. After I was back in Jerusalem and praying one day in the Temple, lost in the presence of God,
- 17 When I returned to Jerusalem and was praying at the temple, I fell into a trance
- 18 I saw him, saw God's Righteous Innocent, and heard him say to me, 'Hurry up! Get out of here as quickly as you can. None of the Jews here in Jerusalem are going to accept what you say about me.'
- 18 and saw the Lord speaking. 'Quick!' he said to me. 'Leave Jerusalem immediately, because they will not accept your testimony about me.'
- 19 "At first I objected: 'Who has better credentials? They all know how obsessed I was with hunting out those who believed in you, beating them up in the meeting places and throwing them in jail.
- 19 'Lord,' I replied, 'these men know that I went from one synagogue to another to imprison and beat those who believe in you.
- 20 And when your witness Stephen was murdered, I was right there, holding the coats of the murderers and cheering them on. And now they see me totally converted. What better qualification could I have?'

- 20 And when the blood of your martyr Stephen was shed, I stood there giving my approval and guarding the clothes of those who were killing him.'
- 21 "But he said, 'Don't argue. Go. I'm sending you on a long journey to outsiders Gentiles.'"
- 21 Then the Lord said to me, 'Go; I will send you far away to the Gentiles.'
- 22 The people in the crowd had listened attentively up to this point, but now they broke loose, shouting out, "Kill him! He's an insect! Stomp on him!"
- 22 The crowd listened to Paul until he said this. Then they raised their voices and shouted, "Rid the earth of him! He's not fit to live!"
- 23 They shook their fists. They filled the air with curses.
- 23 As they were shouting and throwing off their cloaks and flinging dust into the air,
- 24 That's when the captain intervened and ordered Paul taken into the barracks. By now the captain was thoroughly exasperated. He decided to interrogate Paul under torture in order to get to the bottom of this, to find out what he had done that provoked this outraged violence.
- 24 the commander ordered Paul to be taken into the barracks. He directed that he be flogged and questioned in order to find out why the people were shouting at him like this.
- 25 As they spread-eagled him with thongs, getting him ready for the whip, Paul said to the centurion standing there, "Is this legal: torturing a Roman citizen without a fair trial?"
- 25 As they stretched him out to flog him, Paul said to the centurion standing there, "Is it legal for you to flog a Roman citizen who hasn't even been found guilty?"
- 26 When the centurion heard that, he went directly to the captain. "Do you realize what you've done? This man is a Roman citizen!"
- 26 When the centurion heard this, he went to the commander and reported it. "What are you going to do?" he asked. "This man is a Roman citizen."
- 27 The captain came back and took charge. "Is what I hear right? You're a Roman citizen?" Paul said, "I certainly am."
- 27 The commander went to Paul and asked, "Tell me, are you a Roman citizen?" "Yes, I am," he answered.

- 28 The captain was impressed. "I paid a huge sum for my citizenship. How much did it cost you?" "Nothing," said Paul. "It cost me nothing. I was free from the day of my birth."
- 28 Then the commander said, "I had to pay a big price for my citizenship." "But I was born a citizen," Paul replied.
- 29 That put a stop to the interrogation. And it put the fear of God into the captain. He had put a Roman citizen in chains and come within a whisker of putting him under torture!
- 29 Those who were about to question him withdrew immediately. The commander himself was alarmed when he realized that he had put Paul, a Roman citizen, in chains.
- 30 The next day, determined to get to the root of the trouble and know for sure what was behind the Jewish accusation, the captain released Paul and ordered a meeting of the high priests and the High Council to see what they could make of it. Paul was led in and took his place before them.
- 30 The next day, since the commander wanted to find out exactly why Paul was being accused by the Jews, he released him and ordered the chief priests and all the Sanhedrin to assemble. Then he brought Paul and had him stand before them.

Acts 23

MSG

NIV

- 1 Paul surveyed the members of the council with a steady gaze, and then said his piece: "Friends, I've lived with a clear conscience before God all my life, up to this very moment."
- 1 Paul looked straight at the Sanhedrin and said, "My brothers, I have fulfilled my duty to God in all good conscience to this day."
- 2 That set the Chief Priest Ananias off. He ordered his aides to slap Paul in the face.
- 2 At this the high priest Ananias ordered those standing near Paul to strike him on the mouth.
- 3 Paul shot back, "God will slap you down! What a fake you are! You sit there and judge me by the Law and then break the Law by ordering me

slapped around!"

- 3 Then Paul said to him, "God will strike you, you whitewashed wall! You sit there to judge me according to the law, yet you yourself violate the law by commanding that I be struck!"
- 4 The aides were scandalized: "How dare you talk to God's Chief Priest like that!"
- 4 Those who were standing near Paul said, "You dare to insult God's high priest?"
- 5 Paul acted surprised. "How was I to know he was Chief Priest? He doesn't act like a Chief Priest. You're right, the Scripture does say, 'Don't speak abusively to a ruler of the people.' Sorry."
- 5 Paul replied, "Brothers, I did not realize that he was the high priest; for it is written: 'Do not speak evil about the ruler of your people.' "
- 6 Paul, knowing some of the council was made up of Sadducees and others of Pharisees and how they hated each other, decided to exploit their antagonism: "Friends, I am a stalwart Pharisee from a long line of Pharisees. It's because of my Pharisee convictions--the hope and resurrection of the dead--that I've been hauled into this court."
- 6 Then Paul, knowing that some of them were Sadducees and the others Pharisees, called out in the Sanhedrin, "My brothers, I am a Pharisee, the son of a Pharisee. I stand on trial because of my hope in the resurrection of the dead."
- 7 The moment he said this, the council split right down the middle, Pharisees and Sadducees going at each other in heated argument.
- 7 When he said this, a dispute broke out between the Pharisees and the Sadducees, and the assembly was divided.
- 8 Sadducees have nothing to do with a resurrection or angels or even a spirit. If they can't see it, they don't believe it. Pharisees believe it all.
- 8 (The Sadducees say that there is no resurrection, and that there are neither angels nor spirits, but the Pharisees acknowledge them all.)
- 9 And so a huge and noisy quarrel broke out. Then some of the religion scholars on the Pharisee side shouted down the others: "We don't find anything wrong with this man! And what if a spirit has spoken to him? Or maybe an angel? What if it turns out we're fighting against God?"
- 9 There was a great uproar, and some of the teachers of the law who were Pharisees stood up and argued vigorously. "We find nothing wrong with

- this man," they said. "What if a spirit or an angel has spoken to him?"
- 10 That was fuel on the fire. The quarrel flamed up and became so violent the captain was afraid they would tear Paul apart, limb from limb. He ordered the soldiers to get him out of there and escort him back to the safety of the barracks.
- 10 The dispute became so violent that the commander was afraid Paul would be torn to pieces by them. He ordered the troops to go down and take him away from them by force and bring him into the barracks.
- 11 That night the Master appeared to Paul: "It's going to be all right. Everything is going to turn out for the best. You've been a good witness for me here in Jerusalem. Now you're going to be my witness in Rome!"
- 11 The following night the Lord stood near Paul and said, "Take courage! As you have testified about me in Jerusalem, so you must also testify in Rome."
- 12 Next day the Jews worked up a plot against Paul. They took a solemn oath that they would neither eat nor drink until they had killed him.
- 12 The next morning the Jews formed a conspiracy and bound themselves with an oath not to eat or drink until they had killed Paul.
- 13 Over forty of them ritually bound themselves to this murder pact
- 13 More than forty men were involved in this plot.
- 14 and presented themselves to the high priests and religious leaders. "We've bound ourselves by a solemn oath to eat nothing until we have killed Paul.
- 14 They went to the chief priests and elders and said, "We have taken a solemn oath not to eat anything until we have killed Paul.
- 15 But we need your help. Send a request from the council to the captain to bring Paul back so that you can investigate the charges in more detail. We'll do the rest. Before he gets anywhere near you, we'll have killed him. You won't be involved."
- 15 Now then, you and the Sanhedrin petition the commander to bring him before you on the pretext of wanting more accurate information about his case. We are ready to kill him before he gets here."
- 16 Paul's nephew, his sister's son, overheard them plotting the ambush. He went immediately to the barracks and told Paul.
- 16 But when the son of Paul's sister heard of this plot, he went into the barracks and told Paul.

- 17 Paul called over one of the centurions and said, "Take this young man to the captain. He has something important to tell him."
- 17 Then Paul called one of the centurions and said, "Take this young man to the commander; he has something to tell him."
- 18 The centurion brought him to the captain and said, "The prisoner Paul asked me to bring this young man to you. He said he has something urgent to tell you."
- 18 So he took him to the commander. The centurion said, "Paul, the prisoner, sent for me and asked me to bring this young man to you because he has something to tell you."
- 19 The captain took him by the arm and led him aside privately. "What is it? What do you have to tell me?"
- 19 The commander took the young man by the hand, drew him aside and asked, "What is it you want to tell me?"
- 20 Paul's nephew said, "The Jews have worked up a plot against Paul. They're going to ask you to bring Paul to the council first thing in the morning on the pretext that they want to investigate the charges against him in more detail."
- 20 He said: "The Jews have agreed to ask you to bring Paul before the Sanhedrin tomorrow on the pretext of wanting more accurate information about him."
- 21 But it's a trick to get him out of your safekeeping so they can murder him. Right now there are more than forty men lying in ambush for him. They've all taken a vow to neither eat nor drink until they've killed him. The ambush is set--all they're waiting for is for you to send him over."
- 21 Don't give in to them, because more than forty of them are waiting in ambush for him. They have taken an oath not to eat or drink until they have killed him. They are ready now, waiting for your consent to their request."
- 22 The captain dismissed the nephew with a warning: "Don't breathe a word of this to a soul."
- 22 The commander dismissed the young man and cautioned him, "Don't tell anyone that you have reported this to me."
- 23 The captain called up two centurions. "Get two hundred soldiers ready to go immediately to Caesarea. Also seventy cavalry and two hundred light infantry. I want them ready to march by nine o'clock tonight."

- 23 Then he called two of his centurions and ordered them, "Get ready a detachment of two hundred soldiers, seventy horsemen and two hundred spearmen to go to Caesarea at nine tonight.
- 24 And you'll need a couple of mules for Paul and his gear. We're going to present this man safe and sound to Governor Felix."
- 24 Provide mounts for Paul so that he may be taken safely to Governor Felix."
- 25 Then he wrote this letter:
- 25 He wrote a letter as follows:
- 26 From Claudius Lysias, to the Most Honorable Governor Felix: Greetings!
- 26 Claudius Lysias, To His Excellency, Governor Felix: Greetings.
- 27 I rescued this man from a Jewish mob. They had seized him and were about to kill him when I learned that he was a Roman citizen. So I sent in my soldiers.
- 27 This man was seized by the Jews and they were about to kill him, but I came with my troops and rescued him, for I had learned that he is a Roman citizen.
- 28 Wanting to know what he had done wrong, I had him brought before their council.
- 28 I wanted to know why they were accusing him, so I brought him to their Sanhedrin.
- 29 It turned out to be a squabble turned vicious over some of their religious differences, but nothing remotely criminal.
- 29 I found that the accusation had to do with questions about their law, but there was no charge against him that deserved death or imprisonment.
- 30 The next thing I knew, they had cooked up a plot to murder him. I decided that for his own safety I'd better get him out of here in a hurry. So I'm sending him to you. I'm informing his accusers that he's now under your jurisdiction.
- 30 When I was informed of a plot to be carried out against the man, I sent him to you at once. I also ordered his accusers to present to you their case against him.
- 31 The soldiers, following orders, took Paul that same night to safety in Antipatris.

- 31 So the soldiers, carrying out their orders, took Paul with them during the night and brought him as far as Antipatris.
- 32 In the morning the soldiers returned to their barracks in Jerusalem, sending Paul on to Caesarea under guard of the cavalry.
- 32 The next day they let the cavalry go on with him, while they returned to the barracks.
- 33 The cavalry entered Caesarea and handed Paul and the letter over to the governor.
- 33 When the cavalry arrived in Caesarea, they delivered the letter to the governor and handed Paul over to him.
- 34 After reading the letter, the governor asked Paul what province he came from and was told "Cilicia."
- 34 The governor read the letter and asked what province he was from. Learning that he was from Cilicia,
- 35 Then he said, "I'll take up your case when your accusers show up." He ordered him locked up for the meantime in King Herod's official quarters.
- 35 he said, "I will hear your case when your accusers get here." Then he ordered that Paul be kept under guard in Herod's palace.

Acts 24

MSG

NIV

- 1 Within five days, the Chief Priest Ananias arrived with a contingent of leaders, along with Tertullus, a trial lawyer. They presented the governor with their case against Paul.
- 1 Five days later the high priest Ananias went down to Caesarea with some of the elders and a lawyer named Tertullus, and they brought their charges against Paul before the governor.
- 2 When Paul was called before the court, Tertullus spoke for the prosecution: "Most Honorable Felix, we are most grateful in all times and places for your wise and gentle rule.
- 2 When Paul was called in, Tertullus presented his case before Felix: "We have enjoyed a long period of peace under you, and your foresight has brought about reforms in this nation.

- 3 We are much aware that it is because of you and you alone that we enjoy all this peace and gain daily profit from your reforms.
- 3 Everywhere and in every way, most excellent Felix, we acknowledge this with profound gratitude.
- 4 I'm not going to tire you out with a long speech. I beg your kind indulgence in listening to me. I'll be quite brief.
- 4 But in order not to weary you further, I would request that you be kind enough to hear us briefly.
- 5 "We've found this man time and again disturbing the peace, stirring up riots against Jews all over the world, the ringleader of a seditious sect called Nazarenes.
- 5 We have found this man to be a troublemaker, stirring up riots among the Jews all over the world. He is a ringleader of the Nazarene sect
- 6 He's a real bad apple, I must say. We caught him trying to defile our holy Temple and arrested him.
- 6 and even tried to desecrate the temple; so we seized him.
- 7 (OMITTED TEXT)
- 8 You'll be able to verify all these accusations when you examine him yourself."
- 8 By examining him yourself you will be able to learn the truth about all these charges we are bringing against him."
- 9 The Jews joined in: "Hear, hear! That's right!"
- 9 The Jews joined in the accusation, asserting that these things were true.
- 10 The governor motioned to Paul that it was now his turn. Paul said, "I count myself fortunate to be defending myself before you, Governor, knowing how fair-minded you've been in judging us all these years.
- 10 When the governor motioned for him to speak, Paul replied: "I know that for a number of years you have been a judge over this nation; so I gladly make my defense.
- 11 I've been back in the country only twelve days--you can check out these dates easily enough. I came with the express purpose of worshiping in Jerusalem on Pentecost, and I've been minding my own business the whole time.
- 11 You can easily verify that no more than twelve days ago I went up to Jerusalem to worship.

- 12 Nobody can say they saw me arguing in the Temple or working up a crowd in the streets.
- 12 My accusers did not find me arguing with anyone at the temple, or stirring up a crowd in the synagogues or anywhere else in the city.
- 13 Not one of their charges can be backed up with evidence or witnesses.
- 13 And they cannot prove to you the charges they are now making against me.
- 14 "But I do freely admit this: In regard to the Way, which they malign as a dead-end street, I serve and worship the very same God served and worshiped by all our ancestors and embrace everything written in all our Scriptures.
- 14 However, I admit that I worship the God of our fathers as a follower of the Way, which they call a sect. I believe everything that agrees with the Law and that is written in the Prophets,
- 15 And I admit to living in hopeful anticipation that God will raise the dead, both the good and the bad. If that's my crime, my accusers are just as guilty as I am.
- 15 and I have the same hope in God as these men, that there will be a resurrection of both the righteous and the wicked.
- 16 "Believe me, I do my level best to keep a clear conscience before God and my neighbors in everything I do.
- 16 So I strive always to keep my conscience clear before God and man.
- 17 I've been out of the country for a number of years and now I'm back. While I was away, I took up a collection for the poor and brought that with me, along with offerings for the Temple.
- 17 After an absence of several years, I came to Jerusalem to bring my people gifts for the poor and to present offerings.
- 18 It was while making those offerings that they found me quietly at my prayers in the Temple. There was no crowd, there was no disturbance.
- 18 I was ceremonially clean when they found me in the temple courts doing this. There was no crowd with me, nor was I involved in any disturbance.
- 19 It was some Jews from around Ephesus who started all this trouble. And you'll notice they're not here today. They're cowards, too cowardly to accuse me in front of you.

- 19 But there are some Jews from the province of Asia, who ought to be here before you and bring charges if they have anything against me.
- 20 "So ask these others what crime they've caught me in. Don't let them hide behind this smooth-talking Tertullus.
- 20 Or these who are here should state what crime they found in me when I stood before the Sanhedrin--
- 21 The only thing they have on me is that one sentence I shouted out in the council: 'It's because I believe in the resurrection that I've been hauled into this court!' Does that sound to you like grounds for a criminal case?"
- 21 unless it was this one thing I shouted as I stood in their presence: 'It is concerning the resurrection of the dead that I am on trial before you today.' "
- 22 Felix shilly-shallied. He knew far more about the Way than he let on, and could have settled the case then and there. But uncertain of his best move politically, he played for time. "When Captain Lysias comes down, I'll decide your case."
- 22 Then Felix, who was well acquainted with the Way, adjourned the proceedings. "When Lysias the commander comes," he said, "I will decide your case."
- 23 He gave orders to the centurion to keep Paul in custody, but to more or less give him the run of the place and not prevent his friends from helping him.
- 23 He ordered the centurion to keep Paul under guard but to give him some freedom and permit his friends to take care of his needs.
- 24 A few days later Felix and his wife, Drusilla, who was Jewish, sent for Paul and listened to him talk about a life of believing in Jesus Christ.
- 24 Several days later Felix came with his wife Drusilla, who was a Jewess. He sent for Paul and listened to him as he spoke about faith in Christ Jesus.
- 25 As Paul continued to insist on right relations with God and his people, about a life of moral discipline and the coming Judgment, Felix felt things getting a little too close for comfort and dismissed him. "That's enough for today. I'll call you back when it's convenient."
- 25 As Paul discoursed on righteousness, self- control and the judgment to come, Felix was afraid and said, "That's enough for now! You may leave. When I find it convenient, I will send for you."

- 26 At the same time he was secretly hoping that Paul would offer him a substantial bribe. These conversations were repeated frequently.
- 26 At the same time he was hoping that Paul would offer him a bribe, so he sent for him frequently and talked with him.
- 27 After two years of this, Felix was replaced by Porcius Festus. Still playing up to the Jews and ignoring justice, Felix left Paul in prison.
- 27 When two years had passed, Felix was succeeded by Porcius Festus, but because Felix wanted to grant a favor to the Jews, he left Paul in prison.

Acts 25

MSG

NIV

- 1 Three days after Festus arrived in Caesarea to take up his duties as governor, he went up to Jerusalem.
- 1 Three days after arriving in the province, Festus went up from Caesarea to Jerusalem,
- 2 The high priests and top leaders renewed their vendetta against Paul.
- 2 where the chief priests and Jewish leaders appeared before him and presented the charges against Paul.
- 3 They asked Festus if he wouldn't please do them a favor by sending Paul to Jerusalem to respond to their charges. A lie, of course--they had revived their old plot to set an ambush and kill him along the way.
- 3 They urgently requested Festus, as a favor to them, to have Paul transferred to Jerusalem, for they were preparing an ambush to kill him along the way.
- 4 Festus answered that Caesarea was the proper jurisdiction for Paul, and that he himself was going back there in a few days.
- 4 Festus answered, "Paul is being held at Caesarea, and I myself am going there soon.
- 5 "You're perfectly welcome," he said, "to go back with me then and accuse him of whatever you think he's done wrong."
- 5 Let some of your leaders come with me and press charges against the man there, if he has done anything wrong."
- 6 About eight or ten days later, Festus returned to Caesarea. The next morning he took his place in the courtroom and had Paul brought in.

- 6 After spending eight or ten days with them, he went down to Caesarea, and the next day he convened the court and ordered that Paul be brought before him.
- 7 The minute he walked in, the Jews who had come down from Jerusalem were all over him, hurling the most extreme accusations, none of which they could prove.
- 7 When Paul appeared, the Jews who had come down from Jerusalem stood around him, bringing many serious charges against him, which they could not prove.
- 8 Then Paul took the stand and said simply, "I've done nothing wrong against the Jewish religion, or the Temple, or Caesar. Period."
- 8 Then Paul made his defense: "I have done nothing wrong against the law of the Jews or against the temple or against Caesar."
- 9 Festus, though, wanted to get on the good side of the Jews and so said, "How would you like to go up to Jerusalem, and let me conduct your trial there?"
- 9 Festus, wishing to do the Jews a favor, said to Paul, "Are you willing to go up to Jerusalem and stand trial before me there on these charges?"
- 10 Paul answered, "I'm standing at this moment before Caesar's bar of justice, where I have a perfect right to stand. And I'm going to keep standing here. I've done nothing wrong to the Jews, and you know it as well as I do.
- 10 Paul answered: "I am now standing before Caesar's court, where I ought to be tried. I have not done any wrong to the Jews, as you yourself know very well.
- 11 If I've committed a crime and deserve death, name the day. I can face it. But if there's nothing to their accusations--and you know there isn't--nobody can force me to go along with their nonsense. We've fooled around here long enough. I appeal to Caesar."
- 11 If, however, I am guilty of doing anything deserving death, I do not refuse to die. But if the charges brought against me by these Jews are not true, no one has the right to hand me over to them. I appeal to Caesar!"
- 12 Festus huddled with his advisors briefly and then gave his verdict: "You've appealed to Caesar; you'll go to Caesar!"
- 12 After Festus had conferred with his council, he declared: "You have appealed to Caesar. To Caesar you will go!"

- 13 A few days later King Agrippa and his wife, Bernice, visited Caesarea to welcome Festus to his new post.
- 13 A few days later King Agrippa and Bernice arrived at Caesarea to pay their respects to Festus.
- 14 After several days, Festus brought up Paul's case to the king. "I have a man on my hands here, a prisoner left by Felix.
- 14 Since they were spending many days there, Festus discussed Paul's case with the king. He said: "There is a man here whom Felix left as a prisoner.
- 15 When I was in Jerusalem, the high priests and Jewish leaders brought a bunch of accusations against him and wanted me to sentence him to death.
- 15 When I went to Jerusalem, the chief priests and elders of the Jews brought charges against him and asked that he be condemned.
- 16 I told them that wasn't the way we Romans did things. Just because a man is accused, we don't throw him out to the dogs. We make sure the accused has a chance to face his accusers and defend himself of the charges.
- 16 I told them that it is not the Roman custom to hand over any man before he has faced his accusers and has had an opportunity to defend himself against their charges.
- 17 So when they came down here I got right on the case. I took my place in the courtroom and put the man on the stand.
- 17 When they came here with me, I did not delay the case, but convened the court the next day and ordered the man to be brought in.
- 18 "The accusers came at him from all sides,
- 18 When his accusers got up to speak, they did not charge him with any of the crimes I had expected.
- 19 but their accusations turned out to be nothing more than arguments about their religion and a dead man named Jesus, who the prisoner claimed was alive.
- 19 Instead, they had some points of dispute with him about their own religion and about a dead man named Jesus who Paul claimed was alive.
- 20 Since I'm a newcomer here and don't understand everything involved in cases like this, I asked if he'd be willing to go to Jerusalem and be tried there.

- 20 I was at a loss how to investigate such matters; so I asked if he would be willing to go to Jerusalem and stand trial there on these charges.
- 21 Paul refused and demanded a hearing before His Majesty in our highest court. So I ordered him returned to custody until I could send him to Caesar in Rome."
- 21 When Paul made his appeal to be held over for the Emperor's decision, I ordered him held until I could send him to Caesar."
- 22 Agrippa said, "I'd like to see this man and hear his story." "Good," said Festus. "We'll bring him in first thing in the morning and you'll hear it for yourself."
- 22 Then Agrippa said to Festus, "I would like to hear this man myself." He replied, "Tomorrow you will hear him."
- 23 The next day everybody who was anybody in Caesarea found his way to the Great Hall, along with the top military brass. Agrippa and Bernice made a flourishing grand entrance and took their places. Festus then ordered Paul brought in.
- 23 The next day Agrippa and Bernice came with great pomp and entered the audience room with the high ranking officers and the leading men of the city. At the command of Festus, Paul was brought in.
- 24 Festus said, "King Agrippa and distinguished guests, take a good look at this man. A bunch of Jews petitioned me first in Jerusalem, and later here, to do away with him. They have been most vehement in demanding his execution.
- 24 Festus said: "King Agrippa, and all who are present with us, you see this man! The whole Jewish community has petitioned me about him in Jerusalem and here in Caesarea, shouting that he ought not to live any longer.
- 25 I looked into it and decided that he had committed no crime. He requested a trial before Caesar and I agreed to send him to Rome.
- 25 I found he had done nothing deserving of death, but because he made his appeal to the Emperor I decided to send him to Rome.
- 26 But what am I going to write to my master, Caesar? All the charges made by the Jews were fabrications, and I've uncovered nothing else. "That's why I've brought him before this company, and especially you, King Agrippa: so we can come up with something in the nature of a charge that will hold water.

26 But I have nothing definite to write to His Majesty about him. Therefore I have brought him before all of you, and especially before you, King Agrippa, so that as a result of this investigation I may have something to write.

27 For it seems to me silly to send a prisoner all that way for a trial and not be able to document what he did wrong."

27 For I think it is unreasonable to send on a prisoner without specifying the charges against him."

Acts 26

MSG

NIV

1 Agrippa spoke directly to Paul: "Go ahead--tell us about yourself." Paul took the stand and told his story.

1 Then Agrippa said to Paul, "You have permission to speak for yourself." So Paul motioned with his hand and began his defense:

2 "I can't think of anyone, King Agrippa, before whom I'd rather be answering all these Jewish accusations than you,

2 King Agrippa, I consider myself fortunate to stand before you today as I make my defense against all the accusations of the Jews,

3 knowing how well you are acquainted with Jewish ways and all our family quarrels.

3 and especially so because you are well acquainted with all the Jewish customs and controversies. Therefore, I beg you to listen to me patiently.

4 "From the time of my youth, my life has been lived among my own people in Jerusalem.

4 The Jews all know the way I have lived ever since I was a child, from the beginning of my life in my own country, and also in Jerusalem.

5 Practically every Jew in town who watched me grow up--and if they were willing to stick their necks out they'd tell you in person--knows that I lived as a strict Pharisee, the most demanding branch of our religion.

5 They have known me for a long time and can testify, if they are willing, that according to the strictest sect of our religion, I lived as a Pharisee.

6 It's because I believed it and took it seriously,

- 6 And now it is because of my hope in what God has promised our fathers that I am on trial today.
- 7 committed myself heart and soul to what God promised my ancestors--the identical hope, mind you, that the twelve tribes have lived for night and day all these centuries--it's because I have held on to this tested and tried hope that I'm being called on the carpet by the Jews. They should be the ones standing trial here, not me!
- 7 This is the promise our twelve tribes are hoping to see fulfilled as they earnestly serve God day and night. O king, it is because of this hope that the Jews are accusing me.
- 8 For the life of me, I can't see why it's a criminal offense to believe that God raises the dead.
- 8 Why should any of you consider it incredible that God raises the dead?
- 9 "I admit that I didn't always hold to this position. For a time I thought it was my duty to oppose this Jesus of Nazareth with all my might.
- 9 I too was convinced that I ought to do all that was possible to oppose the name of Jesus of Nazareth.
- 10 Backed with the full authority of the high priests, I threw these believers--I had no idea they were God's people!--into the Jerusalem jail right and left, and whenever it came to a vote, I voted for their execution.
- 10 And that is just what I did in Jerusalem. On the authority of the chief priests I put many of the saints in prison, and when they were put to death, I cast my vote against them.
- 11 I stormed through their meeting places, bullying them into cursing Jesus, a one-man terror obsessed with obliterating these people. And then I started on the towns outside Jerusalem.
- 11 Many a time I went from one synagogue to another to have them punished, and I tried to force them to blaspheme. In my obsession against them, I even went to foreign cities to persecute them.
- 12 "One day on my way to Damascus, armed as always with papers from the high priests authorizing my action,
- 12 On one of these journeys I was going to Damascus with the authority and commission of the chief priests.
- 13 right in the middle of the day a blaze of light, light outshining the sun, poured out of the sky on me and my companions. Oh, King, it was so bright!

- 13 About noon, O king, as I was on the road, I saw a light from heaven, brighter than the sun, blazing around me and my companions.
- 14 We fell flat on our faces. Then I heard a voice in Hebrew: 'Saul, Saul, why are you out to get me? Why do you insist on going against the grain?'
- 14 We all fell to the ground, and I heard a voice saying to me in Aramaic, 'Saul, Saul, why do you persecute me? It is hard for you to kick against the goads.'
- 15 "I said, 'Who are you, Master?' "The voice answered, 'I am Jesus, the One you're hunting down like an animal.
- 15 Then I asked, 'Who are you, Lord?' 'I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting,' the Lord replied.
- 16 But now, up on your feet--I have a job for you. I've handpicked you to be a servant and witness to what's happened today, and to what I am going to show you.
- 16 ' Now get up and stand on your feet. I have appeared to you to appoint you as a servant and as a witness of what you have seen of me and what I will show you.
- 17 "'I'm sending you off
- 17 I will rescue you from your own people and from the Gentiles. I am sending you to them
- 18 to open the eyes of the outsiders so they can see the difference between dark and light, and choose light, see the difference between Satan and God, and choose God. I'm sending you off to present my offer of sins forgiven, and a place in the family, inviting them into the company of those who begin real living by believing in me.'
- 18 to open their eyes and turn them from darkness to light, and from the power of Satan to God, so that they may receive forgiveness of sins and a place among those who are sanctified by faith in me.'
- 19 "What could I do, King Agrippa? I couldn't just walk away from a vision like that! I became an obedient believer on the spot.
- 19 So then, King Agrippa, I was not disobedient to the vision from heaven.
- 20 I started preaching this life-change--this radical turn to God and everything it meant in everyday life--right there in Damascus, went on to Jerusalem and the surrounding countryside, and from there to the whole world.

- 20 First to those in Damascus, then to those in Jerusalem and in all Judea, and to the Gentiles also, I preached that they should repent and turn to God and prove their repentance by their deeds.
- 21 "It's because of this 'whole world' dimension that the Jews grabbed me in the Temple that day and tried to kill me. They want to keep God for themselves.
- 21 That is why the Jews seized me in the temple courts and tried to kill me.
- 22 But God has stood by me, just as he promised, and I'm standing here saying what I've been saying to anyone, whether king or child, who will listen. And everything I'm saying is completely in line with what the prophets and Moses said would happen:
- 22 But I have had God's help to this very day, and so I stand here and testify to small and great alike. I am saying nothing beyond what the prophets and Moses said would happen--
- 23 One, the Messiah must die; two, raised from the dead, he would be the first rays of God's daylight shining on people far and near, people both godless and God-fearing."
- 23 that the Christ would suffer and, as the first to rise from the dead, would proclaim light to his own people and to the Gentiles."
- 24 That was too much for Festus. He interrupted with a shout: "Paul, you're crazy! You've read too many books, spent too much time staring off into space! Get a grip on yourself, get back in the real world!"
- 24 At this point Festus interrupted Paul's defense. "You are out of your mind, Paul!" he shouted. "Your great learning is driving you insane."
- 25 But Paul stood his ground. "With all respect, Festus, Your Honor, I'm not crazy. I'm both accurate and sane in what I'm saying.
- 25 I am not insane, most excellent Festus, Paul replied. "What I am saying is true and reasonable.
- 26 The King knows what I'm talking about. I'm sure that nothing of what I've said sounds crazy to him. He's known all about it for a long time. You must realize that this wasn't done behind the scenes.
- 26 The king is familiar with these things, and I can speak freely to him. I am convinced that none of this has escaped his notice, because it was not done in a corner.
- 27 You believe the prophets, don't you, King Agrippa? Don't answer that--I know you believe."

- 27 King Agrippa, do you believe the prophets? I know you do."
- 28 But Agrippa did answer: "Keep this up much longer and you'll make a Christian out of me!"
- 28 Then Agrippa said to Paul, "Do you think that in such a short time you can persuade me to be a Christian?"
- 29 Paul, still in chains, said, "That's what I'm praying for, whether now or later, and not only you but everyone listening today, to become like me--except, of course, for this prison jewelry!"
- 29 Paul replied, "Short time or long--I pray God that not only you but all who are listening to me today may become what I am, except for these chains."
- 30 The king and the governor, along with Bernice and their advisors, got up
- 30 The king rose, and with him the governor and Bernice and those sitting with them.
- 31 and went into the next room to talk over what they had heard. They quickly agreed on Paul's innocence, saying, "There's nothing in this man deserving prison, let alone death."
- 31 They left the room, and while talking with one another, they said, "This man is not doing anything that deserves death or imprisonment."
- 32 Agrippa told Festus, "He could be set free right now if he hadn't requested the hearing before Caesar."
- 32 Agrippa said to Festus, "This man could have been set free if he had not appealed to Caesar."

Acts 27

MSG

NIV

- 1 As soon as arrangements were complete for our sailing to Italy, Paul and a few other prisoners were placed under the supervision of a centurion named Julius, a member of an elite guard.
- 1 When it was decided that we would sail for Italy, Paul and some other prisoners were handed over to a centurion named Julius, who belonged to the Imperial Regiment.

- 2 We boarded a ship from Adramyttium that was bound for Ephesus and ports west. Aristarchus, a Macedonian from Thessalonica, went with us.
- 2 We boarded a ship from Adramyttium about to sail for ports along the coast of the province of Asia, and we put out to sea. Aristarchus, a Macedonian from Thessalonica, was with us.
- 3 The next day we put in at Sidon. Julius treated Paul most decently--let him get off the ship and enjoy the hospitality of his friends there.
- 3 The next day we landed at Sidon; and Julius, in kindness to Paul, allowed him to go to his friends so they might provide for his needs.
- 4 Out to sea again, we sailed north under the protection of the northeast shore of Cyprus because winds out of the west were against us,
- 4 From there we put out to sea again and passed to the lee of Cyprus because the winds were against us.
- 5 and then along the coast westward to the port of Myra.
- 5 When we had sailed across the open sea off the coast of Cilicia and Pamphylia, we landed at Myra in Lycia.
- 6 There the centurion found an Egyptian ship headed for Italy and transferred us on board.
- 6 There the centurion found an Alexandrian ship sailing for Italy and put us on board.
- 7 We ran into bad weather and found it impossible to stay on course. After much difficulty, we finally made it to the southern coast of the island of Crete
- 7 We made slow headway for many days and had difficulty arriving off Cnidus. When the wind did not allow us to hold our course, we sailed to the lee of Crete, opposite Salmone.
- 8 and docked at Good Harbor (appropriate name!).
- 8 We moved along the coast with difficulty and came to a place called Fair Havens, near the town of Lasea.
- 9 By this time we had lost a lot of time. We had passed the autumn equinox, so it would be stormy weather from now on through the winter, too dangerous for sailing. Paul warned,
- 9 Much time had been lost, and sailing had already become dangerous because by now it was after the Fast. So Paul warned them,
- 10 "I see only disaster ahead for cargo and ship--to say nothing of our lives!--if we put out to sea now."

- 10 Men, I can see that our voyage is going to be disastrous and bring great loss to ship and cargo, and to our own lives also.
- 11 The centurion set Paul's warning aside and let the ship captain and the shipowner talk him into trying for the next harbor.
- 11 But the centurion, instead of listening to what Paul said, followed the advice of the pilot and of the owner of the ship.
- 12 But it was not the best harbor for staying the winter. Phoenix, a few miles further on, was more suitable.
- 12 Since the harbor was unsuitable to winter in, the majority decided that we should sail on, hoping to reach Phoenix and winter there. This was a harbor in Crete, facing both southwest and northwest.
- 13 When a gentle southerly breeze came up, they weighed anchor, thinking it would be smooth sailing.
- 13 When a gentle south wind began to blow, they thought they had obtained what they wanted; so they weighed anchor and sailed along the shore of Crete.
- 14 But they were no sooner out to sea than a gale-force wind, the infamous nor'easter, struck.
- 14 Before very long, a wind of hurricane force, called the "northeaster," swept down from the island.
- 15 They lost all control of the ship. It was a cork in the storm.
- 15 The ship was caught by the storm and could not head into the wind; so we gave way to it and were driven along.
- 16 We came under the lee of the small island named Claudia, and managed to get a lifeboat ready and reef the sails.
- 16 As we passed to the lee of a small island called Cauda, we were hardly able to make the lifeboat secure.
- 17 But rocky shoals prevented us from getting close. We only managed to avoid them by throwing out drift anchors.
- 17 When the men had hoisted it aboard, they passed ropes under the ship itself to hold it together. Fearing that they would run aground on the sandbars of Syrtis, they lowered the sea anchor and let the ship be driven along.
- 18 Next day, out on the high seas again and badly damaged now by the storm, we dumped the cargo overboard.

- 18 We took such a violent battering from the storm that the next day they began to throw the cargo overboard.
- 19 The third day the sailors lightened the ship further by throwing off all the tackle and provisions.
- 19 On the third day, they threw the ship's tackle overboard with their own hands.
- 20 It had been many days since we had seen either sun or stars. Wind and waves were battering us unmercifully, and we lost all hope of rescue.
- 20 When neither sun nor stars appeared for many days and the storm continued raging, we finally gave up all hope of being saved.
- 21 With our appetite for both food and life long gone, Paul took his place in our midst and said, "Friends, you really should have listened to me back in Crete. We could have avoided all this trouble and trial.
- 21 After the men had gone a long time without food, Paul stood up before them and said: "Men, you should have taken my advice not to sail from Crete; then you would have spared yourselves this damage and loss.
- 22 But there's no need to dwell on that now. From now on, things are looking up! I can assure you that there'll not be a single drowning among us, although I can't say as much for the ship--the ship itself is doomed.
- 22 But now I urge you to keep up your courage, because not one of you will be lost; only the ship will be destroyed.
- 23 "Last night God's angel stood at my side, an angel of this God I serve,
- 23 Last night an angel of the God whose I am and whom I serve stood beside me
- 24 saying to me, 'Don't give up, Paul. You're going to stand before Caesar yet--and everyone sailing with you is also going to make it.'
- 24 and said, 'Do not be afraid, Paul. You must stand trial before Caesar; and God has graciously given you the lives of all who sail with you.'
- 25 So, dear friends, take heart. I believe God will do exactly what he told me.
- 25 So keep up your courage, men, for I have faith in God that it will happen just as he told me.
- 26 But we're going to shipwreck on some island or other."
- 26 Nevertheless, we must run aground on some island."
- 27 On the fourteenth night, adrift somewhere on the Adriatic Sea, at about midnight the sailors sensed that we were approaching land.

27 On the fourteenth night we were still being driven across the Adriatic Sea, when about midnight the sailors sensed they were approaching land.

28 Sounding, they measured a depth of one hundred twenty feet, and shortly after that ninety feet.

28 They took soundings and found that the water was a hundred and twenty feet deep. A short time later they took soundings again and found it was ninety feet deep.

29 Afraid that we were about to run aground, they threw out four anchors and prayed for daylight.

29 Fearing that we would be dashed against the rocks, they dropped four anchors from the stern and prayed for daylight.

30 Some of the sailors tried to jump ship. They let down the lifeboat, pretending they were going to set out more anchors from the bow.

30 In an attempt to escape from the ship, the sailors let the lifeboat down into the sea, pretending they were going to lower some anchors from the bow.

31 Paul saw through their guise and told the centurion and his soldiers, "If these sailors don't stay with the ship, we're all going down."

31 Then Paul said to the centurion and the soldiers, "Unless these men stay with the ship, you cannot be saved."

32 So the soldiers cut the lines to the lifeboat and let it drift off.

32 So the soldiers cut the ropes that held the lifeboat and let it fall away.

33 With dawn about to break, Paul called everyone together and proposed breakfast: "This is the fourteenth day we've gone without food. None of us has felt like eating!"

33 Just before dawn Paul urged them all to eat. "For the last fourteen days," he said, "you have been in constant suspense and have gone without food--you haven't eaten anything.

34 But I urge you to eat something now. You'll need strength for the rescue ahead. You're going to come out of this without even a scratch!"

34 Now I urge you to take some food. You need it to survive. Not one of you will lose a single hair from his head."

35 He broke the bread, gave thanks to God, passed it around,

35 After he said this, he took some bread and gave thanks to God in front of them all. Then he broke it and began to eat.

36 and they all ate heartily--

36 They were all encouraged and ate some food themselves.
37 two hundred seventy-six of us, all told!
37 Altogether there were 276 of us on board.
38 With the meal finished and everyone full, the ship was further lightened
by dumping the grain overboard.
38 When they had eaten as much as they wanted, they lightened the ship by
throwing the grain into the sea.
39 At daybreak, no one recognized the land--but then they did notice a bay
with a nice beach. They decided to try to run the ship up on the beach.
39 When daylight came, they did not recognize the land, but they saw a
bay with a sandy beach, where they decided to run the ship aground if
they could.
40 They cut the anchors, loosed the tiller, raised the sail, and ran before the
wind toward the beach.
40 Cutting loose the anchors, they left them in the sea and at the same time
untied the ropes that held the rudders. Then they hoisted the foresail to
the wind and made for the beach.
41 But we didn't make it. Still far from shore, we hit a reef and the ship
began to break up.
41 But the ship struck a sandbar and ran aground. The bow stuck fast and
would not move, and the stern was broken to pieces by the pounding of
the surf.
42 The soldiers decided to kill the prisoners so none could escape by
swimming,
42 The soldiers planned to kill the prisoners to prevent any of them from
swimming away and escaping.
43 but the centurion, determined to save Paul, stopped them. He gave
orders for anyone who could swim to dive in and go for it,
43 But the centurion wanted to spare Paul's life and kept them from
carrying out their plan. He ordered those who could swim to jump
overboard first and get to land.
44 and for the rest to grab a plank. Everyone made it to shore safely.
44 The rest were to get there on planks or on pieces of the ship. In this way
everyone reached land in safety.

Acts 28

MSG

NIV

- 1 Once everyone was accounted for and we realized we had all made it, we learned that we were on the island of Malta.
- 1 Once safely on shore, we found out that the island was called Malta.
- 2 The natives went out of their way to be friendly to us. The day was rainy and cold and we were already soaked to the bone, but they built a huge bonfire and gathered us around it.
- 2 The islanders showed us unusual kindness. They built a fire and welcomed us all because it was raining and cold.
- 3 Paul pitched in and helped. He had gathered up a bundle of sticks, but when he put it on the fire, a venomous snake, roused from its torpor by the heat, struck his hand and held on.
- 3 Paul gathered a pile of brushwood and, as he put it on the fire, a viper, driven out by the heat, fastened itself on his hand.
- 4 Seeing the snake hanging from Paul's hand like that, the natives jumped to the conclusion that he was a murderer getting his just deserts.
- 4 When the islanders saw the snake hanging from his hand, they said to each other, "This man must be a murderer; for though he escaped from the sea, Justice has not allowed him to live."
- 5 Paul shook the snake off into the fire, none the worse for wear.
- 5 But Paul shook the snake off into the fire and suffered no ill effects.
- 6 They kept expecting him to drop dead, but when it was obvious he wasn't going to, they jumped to the conclusion that he was a god!
- 6 The people expected him to swell up or suddenly fall dead, but after waiting a long time and seeing nothing unusual happen to him, they changed their minds and said he was a god.
- 7 The head man in that part of the island was Publius. He took us into his home as his guests, drying us out and putting us up in fine style for the next three days.
- 7 There was an estate nearby that belonged to Publius, the chief official of the island. He welcomed us to his home and for three days entertained us hospitably.

- 8 Publius's father was sick at the time, down with a high fever and dysentery. Paul went to the old man's room, and when he laid hands on him and prayed, the man was healed.
- 8 His father was sick in bed, suffering from fever and dysentery. Paul went in to see him and, after prayer, placed his hands on him and healed him.
- 9 Word of the healing got around fast, and soon everyone on the island who was sick came and got healed.
- 9 When this had happened, the rest of the sick on the island came and were cured.
- 10 We spent a wonderful three months on Malta. They treated us royally, took care of all our needs and outfitted us for the rest of the journey.
- 10 They honored us in many ways and when we were ready to sail, they furnished us with the supplies we needed.
- 11 When an Egyptian ship that had wintered there in the harbor prepared to leave for Italy, we got on board. The ship had a carved Gemini for its figurehead: "the Heavenly Twins."
- 11 After three months we put out to sea in a ship that had wintered in the island. It was an Alexandrian ship with the figurehead of the twin gods Castor and Pollux.
- 12 We put in at Syracuse for three days
- 12 We put in at Syracuse and stayed there three days.
- 13 and then went up the coast to Rhegium. Two days later, with the wind out of the south, we sailed into the Bay of Naples.
- 13 From there we set sail and arrived at Rhegium. The next day the south wind came up, and on the following day we reached Puteoli.
- 14 We found Christian friends there and stayed with them for a week. And then we came to Rome.
- 14 There we found some brothers who invited us to spend a week with them. And so we came to Rome.
- 15 Friends in Rome heard we were on the way and came out to meet us. One group got as far as Appian Court; another group met us at Three Taverns--emotion-packed meetings, as you can well imagine. Paul, brimming over with praise, led us in prayers of thanksgiving.
- 15 The brothers there had heard that we were coming, and they traveled as far as the Forum of Appius and the Three Taverns to meet us. At the sight of these men Paul thanked God and was encouraged.

- 16 When we actually entered Rome, they let Paul live in his own private quarters with a soldier who had been assigned to guard him.
- 16 When we got to Rome, Paul was allowed to live by himself, with a soldier to guard him.
- 17 Three days later, Paul called the Jewish leaders together for a meeting at his house. He said, "The Jews in Jerusalem arrested me on trumped-up charges, and I was taken into custody by the Romans. I assure you that I did absolutely nothing against Jewish laws or Jewish customs.
- 17 Three days later he called together the leaders of the Jews. When they had assembled, Paul said to them: "My brothers, although I have done nothing against our people or against the customs of our ancestors, I was arrested in Jerusalem and handed over to the Romans.
- 18 After the Romans investigated the charges and found there was nothing to them, they wanted to set me free,
- 18 They examined me and wanted to release me, because I was not guilty of any crime deserving death.
- 19 but the Jews objected so fiercely that I was forced to appeal to Caesar. I did this not to accuse them of any wrongdoing or to get our people in trouble with Rome. We've had enough trouble through the years that way.
- 19 But when the Jews objected, I was compelled to appeal to Caesar--not that I had any charge to bring against my own people.
- 20 I did it for Israel. I asked you to come and listen to me today to make it clear that I'm on Israel's side, not against her. I'm a hostage here for hope, not doom."
- 20 For this reason I have asked to see you and talk with you. It is because of the hope of Israel that I am bound with this chain."
- 21 They said, "Nobody wrote warning us about you. And no one has shown up saying anything bad about you.
- 21 They replied, "We have not received any letters from Judea concerning you, and none of the brothers who have come from there has reported or said anything bad about you.
- 22 But we would like very much to hear more. The only thing we know about this Christian sect is that nobody seems to have anything good to say about it."

- 22 But we want to hear what your views are, for we know that people everywhere are talking against this sect."
- 23 They agreed on a time. When the day arrived, they came back to his home with a number of their friends. Paul talked to them all day, from morning to evening, explaining everything involved in the kingdom of God, and trying to persuade them all about Jesus by pointing out what Moses and the prophets had written about him.
- 23 They arranged to meet Paul on a certain day, and came in even larger numbers to the place where he was staying. From morning till evening he explained and declared to them the kingdom of God and tried to convince them about Jesus from the Law of Moses and from the Prophets.
- 24 Some of them were persuaded by what he said, but others refused to believe a word of it.
- 24 Some were convinced by what he said, but others would not believe.
- 25 When the unbelievers got cantankerous and started bickering with each other, Paul interrupted: "I have just one more thing to say to you. The Holy Spirit sure knew what he was talking about when he addressed our ancestors through Isaiah the prophet:
- 25 They disagreed among themselves and began to leave after Paul had made this final statement: "The Holy Spirit spoke the truth to your forefathers when he said through Isaiah the prophet:
- 26 Go to this people and tell them this: "You're going to listen with your ears, but you won't hear a word; You're going to stare with your eyes, but you won't see a thing.
- 26 'Go to this people and say, You will be ever hearing but never understanding; you will be ever seeing but never perceiving."
- 27 These people are blockheads! They stick their fingers in their ears so they won't have to listen; They screw their eyes shut so they won't have to look, so they won't have to deal with me face-to-face and let me heal them."
- 27 For this people's heart has become calloused; they hardly hear with their ears, and they have closed their eyes. Otherwise they might see with their eyes, hear with their ears, understand with their hearts and turn, and I would heal them.'

28 "You've had your chance. The non-Jewish outsiders are next on the list. And believe me, they're going to receive it with open arms!"

28 Therefore I want you to know that God's salvation has been sent to the Gentiles, and they will listen!

29 (OMITTED TEXT)

30 Paul lived for two years in his rented house. He welcomed everyone who came to visit.

30 For two whole years Paul stayed there in his own rented house and welcomed all who came to see him.

31 He urgently presented all matters of the kingdom of God. He explained everything about Jesus Christ. His door was always open.

31 Boldly and without hindrance he preached the kingdom of God and taught about the Lord Jesus Christ.